# Oath of Claws

*The Odiyan Contracts, Book 2*

Anya Kalloor

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Adult (18+). All characters are adults.

## Chapter 1

# Nine Days of Rain

Neela came back to herself on the window ledge with rain in her mouth, and before she opened her eyes she counted.

Two.

Ammu's pouch held two smears. She did not need to look. She had counted them by feel at dusk, the way she counted exits and stair treads, and the number had not improved overnight.

Her bones were still settling. The change back always felt like being poured into a jar too small, and then the jar cracked and she was only a woman, naked and shaking, crouched on teak wet with monsoon. Grey light. The cistern chain clanked once somewhere below, and the red smell of soaked laterite rose off the whole fort.

"Here."

The cloth came over her shoulders before she had finished shivering. It was warm. Not warm from the room. Warm from the brazier, the way it had been warm every dawn since the vow, rewarmed in the night by a man who said nothing about it.

She pulled it tight and looked in. Devan stood with the shutter held back on his forearm. His other hand was closed. When he saw her looking, he opened it. A grey river pebble lay on his palm, smooth as a tooth.

"Habit," he said.

"You don't need it now."

"I know." He closed his fingers again. "Come in. The third slat's going to complain."

It did. She slid down off the ledge and her knees nearly went. He caught her elbow, then let go the moment she had her feet, which was the way he did everything now: help given, hand removed, no comment. On the floor by the brazier sat the covered dish of rice and curd, the cup, the kindi with its spout toward her side.

She ate on her knees, fast and shaking, as the hollow hunger demanded. He sat on his heels across from her and waited. When her hands steadied, she said, "Two."

"Two what?"

"You know what."

"I'd like you to say it."

Of course he would. He never put a name to her fear for her. He made her do it. "Two smears. Two nights of the other one. Then Ammu's thumb is gone."

He nodded slowly. He answered with facts, because that was what he had. "The ache comes a moon after the last night you turn. Not before. That's what you told me."

"It's what I know. Nobody's ever tested it on purpose." She scraped the bowl clean. "Two nights of the other one is all the raid gets, Devan. After that I'm a woman with split nails and a fever, climbing a wall."

"Then we plan for the two nights."

"We've been planning for nine days."

"We've been resting for nine days," he said. "It isn't the same."

That was fair, and she hated it. She set the bowl down and rubbed her right wrist. The scar there was still raw under its binding, the ridges torn by the forced resin and slow to close. Across the room, without seeming to, he pressed his thumb to his own wrist. A thin red line lay there, matching hers. It had not faded either.

They both looked at it. Neither said a thing.

*

The hall smelled of damp wool and lamp oil. Rain came off the eaves in ropes, and beyond the courtyard wall the whole hill country was one grey roar.

Neela went down by the east stair. She took it fast, counting turns under her breath. At the bottom she glanced across the court toward the west stair, and then she went the long way round by the kitchen yard.

Chinna was at the kitchen door with her bad hip propped on the frame. Neela stopped and asked after it, and after the wager that had no winner, and was told it was a fine thing to have a warden's wife who remembered which hip. Unni came through with a tray and she took the cloth off it, found the fish, and told him his mother's salt had been good last week. He went red to the ears. Small courtesies. They had once been the only wealth she owned.

The names kept the house standing in her head. Chinna. Unni. Gopan on the cistern wheel. Kannan, up in his loft with the white goat. And Raiu, whom she still said under her breath on the stairs.

There was one more name, and she did not say it even there. Ammu. Not two weeks dead, and her thumb of resin sat in the cord pouch against Neela's hip. Every smear Neela spent was a piece of her sister going onto her own skin, and there were two pieces left.

She had been twenty-one years a number. She had been a name for nine days.

Then there were the other names, the ones she'd put in a crown record herself, by choice, with a pen. *Neela, of Kettamala.* The last rider had carried it out of the pass before the road went to river. Her witness entry was ash. The slip with her birth name was in Chathu's keeping. No master in the world could now say *she is ours, she is vouched.* To the guild she was rogue. To the crown she was an unvouched odiyan with her name on a border writ. Both would hunt her. Neither was in a hurry. The rains had given her four months of locked road, and she knew exactly how thin that mercy was.

Devan had laid Ittan's things out on the long table. The hide strip, the oilcloth, the sums. And the small tally book from the false-bottomed chest, forty leaves in a clerk's cramped hand.

"Read what you can," he said.

She sat and turned the pages. Dates, sums, place names. A pass-village here, a ford there. Down one margin, in a column no clerk had meant her to understand, ran small marks she knew in her bones. A hook for goods delivered. A slash for coin paid. Three dots for *balance carried*. Resin House shorthand, the kind apprentices scratched on tapping sheds. Ittan, she guessed, had copied it off the guild's own receipts.

"This is guild reckoning," she said. "Not all of it. Counts and payments I can follow. Names I can't, they're set in the masters' own marks." She ran a finger down the column. "Ittan paid the house in instalments. Four of them. Look. Slash, slash, slash, slash, hook."

"Hook is?"

"A delivery. Something was sent in return."

"What?"

"I don't know. A man, a message." She turned another leaf. "Or a death. Chathu writes them all the same."

Beside three of the lines, tucked into the margin as small as a pressed seed, someone had drawn a bird. A sunbird, wings folded, long curved bill. It was not the queen's seal, whose wings spread wide in green wax. This one sat quiet, the way a clerk's tick sits quiet. She tapped it.

"These mean something. I can't read it."

"Guild mark?"

"Not one I was ever taught."

He leaned to look, and said nothing, and she watched him decide not to guess. That was the thing she was learning about him. He kept his guesses in his pocket until they were facts.

"Here is what I have," he said, and straightened. "Ittan's chit is for my death. The writ with the queen's seal says who paid. That is one murder, and it's mine, and a high court will find it hard to hear from the man it was done to." He rested two fingers on the hide. "Asha's contract is not here. It

is in the guild's book. Chathu enters every contract against a page. Muthu saw a black-covered book in his arms on the cook-house step."

"The ledger."

"I need that entry. Not a story, not a confession. The contract itself, dated and entered, with the buyer's name. A court will take paper."

She had known it was coming. She had known since Muthu came back from the fodder run with a face like wet slate and said *Chathu, black book, held it to his chest like a child.* She made herself say her side flat, in the same voice he used.

"I don't want the entry. I want the book. Every page in it. Every one back in the hand of the person it names." Her hands had gone cold on the table. "Mine is in there too, Devan. Whatever's left of it. Every sister I have. If you take one leaf out and leave the rest, Chathu rewrites the house in a month."

"I need one page."

"All of them."

They looked at each other across Ittan's sums.

It would have been simple to be angry. She had expected to be. She waited for the heat, and it did not come, because he had not lied to her about what he wanted, not once, and it left her nothing to push against.

"Those aren't the same plan," she said.

"No."

"They both go through the same door."

"Yes."

"Then we go together." She heard how quickly she said it. "And argue after. On the road. In the dark. Wherever."

His mouth did something small. "I was going to say that."

"Then why didn't you?"

"I wanted to see if you would." He turned the tally book closed with one finger, the sunbird vanishing under the cover. "We take what the raid gives us. The page for Asha's contract is mine. The rest is yours to answer for. If it comes to one hand's reach, I will not choose for you."

"Will you promise that?"

"I won't answer that," he said gently, and for a moment she thought he was refusing. Then he finished. "Because I do not know what I will do with a dying man's blade at my throat and your life on the table. I know what I want to do. I'll say that much."

It was the most honest refusal she had ever been given, and it pleased her more than a promise.

She pulled the hide strip toward her and made it a map with her thumbnail. "The ridge track is quicker. It's also the one the pass-village watcher walks. So we take the wood road, by the lower ford. Half a day longer."

"And the smears?"

"The first goes tonight. I run the road ahead of you and find where the rain has cut it." She said the rest before he could. "That leaves one for inside the wall. One night to get in, find a black book and get out."

"And tonight's costs you a hollow morning, and a night nearer the ache."

"Yes."

"You've priced it."

"I counted it," she said. "It's the same thing."

*

Ittan's grille was a hand's width of iron in the padippura guardroom door. Unni opened the bolt for them and stood well back, not quite meeting anyone's eye.

The councillor had lost the shine off him in nine days. His clove smell had gone stale. But he rose from the cot as they came, a gracious man hosting two guests, and bowed with the ghost of the old ease.

"My friend. Warden's lady. Forgive the lamp, I'm told oil is dear in a siege."

"It is not a siege," Devan said.

"No. Of course. The rain." He smiled, and the smile slid off the end of itself. "My friend, I wonder. Has anyone thought of her medicine? The willow bark. It must be boiled slow, an hour, and she likes the window

open in the rain. If the physicians let her sicken in a shut room, she coughs herself to rags."

Neela watched him. Not his words. His eyes.

Devan said, "I'll send word to the house physicians by the first rider the road allows."

"I'd be grateful. I would be very grateful."

He asked nothing else. Not for his freedom, not for his rank, not a lawyer, not a letter. In the cold guardroom he leaned on the iron and begged only for the boiling of bark, and every few breaths his gaze slid past Devan's shoulder, past her own, to the dark corner by the door. It stayed there a heartbeat. Then it dropped to the floor, careful.

When Unni's boot scraped on the flagstones, Ittan flinched like a hit horse.

She had seen men afraid of a warden. She had seen men afraid of a blade, and of the other one, once they learned what walked the hill. This was neither. This was a man who had looked at the thing that would come next and decided Devan, with his wires and his writs and his locked grille, was the kinder alternative.

Outside in the rain she took Devan's sleeve. "He's not afraid of you."

"I noticed."

"He's afraid of whoever he thinks will come for him."

"Or for what he'd say first." He pulled his hood up. "Say that again when we have the ledger. It will matter."

*

At dusk the rain thinned to a grey mist, and she climbed the west rampart with him because she could not sit still, and because the walls were the only place the two smears in her pouch did not feel like a drumbeat.

Two. She would spend the first of them tonight, as she had said, to run the wood road by moonrise. She would lie awake first and count the cost of it. Another night's resin, another night nearer the ache, another night in the dark with a man who would hold a river pebble in his palm that he no longer needed.

Below the wall the Monkey Pass road ran down in a pale scar, a cart road gone to a brown stream. No cart could cross it. No horse. The gorge above it ran with water and the cliffs shed it in sheets. By every rule she knew, the road was empty and would be empty until the rains broke.

All day the langurs had barked from the cliff face. The sound had gone round her head for nine days, shrill and furious, the way a house sounds when a kettle won't stop. She had stopped hearing it. Which was why she heard the silence at once.

It did not come as a hush. It came as a hole. The nearest troop stopped mid-bark. Then the next. Then the ones across the gorge, and the ones high on the shoulder, until the whole cliff held its breath and there was only rain on stone and the brown water roaring.

Devan had gone still beside her. She knew the stillness by now.

"They bark at cats," she said quietly. "They bark at fire. At a goat-boy with a stick. They go quiet for one thing."

"Strangers on the road," he said.

"Yes."

"Nobody can walk that road."

"No."

She counted, because it was what she did. Her lips moved on the numbers: the tower, the gorge turn, the length of the wet stone between them and the first bend, how many breaths a man would need to cross it. The langurs held their silence. It lasted through all her counting, and well beyond it.

Somebody was down there in the rain, on a road that did not exist, walking toward Kettamala.

## Chapter 2

# The Justice at the Gate

Bhaskaran's horn cut across the kalari in the middle of the third form, and Devan stopped with one foot lifted.

One long note. Two short. Strangers at the padippura, unarmed, not many. He had taught the signal himself, and in five years it had never been blown on a day like this one.

He stood in the red earth with sesame smoke in his nose and rain running off his shoulders. The pass was a river. The road below the fort had been empty all night; he had watched it until the dark took it, and nothing had moved on it. So they had not used the road.

He took the north steps two at a time.

He had left Neela asleep. When the langurs went silent at dusk she had judged no night run worth a smear with strangers on the road, and she had kept both. She had lain down at last like a woman who'd been told she could sleep. He did not like leaving her. He liked less the thought of waking her to this before he knew what it was.

At the gate the rain came down in ropes off the roof. Bhaskaran stood under it with the horn still in his fist. Unni stood behind him, staring at the five figures in the arch as if they might be a joke someone had told badly.

Four of them stood in a line. The fifth stood in front.

She was a lean woman of fifty-eight, soaked from hem to hip, with a grey plait dripping down her cloak. Her boots were caked to the shin in red

scree. She looked like someone who had spent the night climbing something she disliked.

"Warden of Kettamala," she said. Her voice was dry as a split pot. "I am Rema, justice of the high court at Kodiyur. I regret the hour."

"You walked."

"We climbed. Your goat path is not fit for goats." She pushed back her hood. "I bring the queen's warrant. May I bring it out of the wet?"

He should have said yes at once. He looked at her escort instead.

Four, in oiled cloaks, each with a green sunbird sash worn across the chest. Their packs were oilcloth, tied tight, and dry. A dull sheen showed on them, not a bead of water standing. Their boots were stiff and square at the heel. Mud reached the ankle and no higher, and not a scuff marked any sole.

He had walked that goat path first at nineteen, on a dare. It had taken the skin off his knees.

"Bring it in," he said.

*

The warrant came out of a sleeve of oilcloth, folded in three. Rema handed it across without ceremony and watched him read.

*Councillor Ittan, Keeper of the Passes, charged with treason under the wartime charter. To be delivered into the keeping of the crown at Kodiyur.* Below it, in a clerk's round hand, ran a list of Ittan's offices. And below that, the wax.

Green. Crushed leaf, not clove. A sunbird with wings spread.

He did not move his thumb. He let his eye run down the left wing to the tip, and there it was: a chip no bigger than a grain of rice, the same notch as the seal on the writ that lay in a hollow behind the third slat of his chamber.

Of course it was the same. It was one seal. He told himself so twice, and kept his face where it was.

"The charter was invoked when the spring raids began," Rema said. "You were sent notice."

"I read it."

"Then you know the warrant outranks the warden's hold. I am to carry him to Kodiyur."

"On what road?"

For the first time she smiled. It was a small, tired thing. "That is the difficulty, yes."

"I have a request," he said. He made it flat, because flat was the only voice he trusted. "I mean to put Ittan before the court. Not as an accused man. As a witness to my sister's murder, six years ago, on the west stair of this fort. He sold the passes. I think the same hand bought her death."

Bhaskaran, behind him, went very still.

"You think," said Rema.

"I can show you the tallies. I can show you his chest of waxed blanks, his book, the sums. I cannot yet show you that the hand is one hand. That's what a hearing is for."

She studied him for the length of a slow breath. He had faced raiders with less sense of being weighed.

"The charter lets a warden hold a prisoner until assize when the roads are shut," she said at last. "It lets a justice sit assize where she stands. I stand here." She folded the oilcloth over her knuckles. "Three days, Warden. You will show me your proof. Ittan will answer. At the end of it I decide whether I carry a traitor out, or a witness, or no one."

"Three days."

"You have kept him well?"

"He has a cot and a lamp. He has asked for one thing."

"What?"

"That his wife's willow bark be boiled slowly."

Something moved in her face and was gone. "I shall want my First Guard at his door. A courtesy to the crown."

"Bhaskaran's men hold that door."

"Then both," Rema said pleasantly, "and you will not mind the company."

He minded it very much. He had a whole fort, sixty soldiers and the only wall for a hundred miles, and he understood now that all of it had been quietly put to one side. A woman with a plait and a sleeve of paper had walked into his gate, and the gate had opened because it was meant to.

"Both," he said.

He turned to the four. "Your names, for the garrison roll?"

"Crown escort does not give them, Warden." Rema was already shaking rain from her cloak. "They go by place. First, Second, and so on. It saves the clerks a great deal of ink."

"First," said the nearest. A woman, close to his own age, built like a rope. Her voice had no colour in it.

"Second."

"Third."

"Fourth."

Numbers. He had heard a woman say *Seventeen* in the dark a month ago, and it had settled in his ribs like a stone. This one fit the same hole too neatly.

First Guard shrugged her pack higher on her shoulder. Her cuff rode up. On the inside of her left wrist lay a single pale seam, the length of a finger, smooth and shiny in the grey light. One clean line, flat to the skin. Nothing like the thick ridges that lay layer over layer on his wife's wrists, ten years of burning laid down on each other. The guard's collar gaped as she moved, and the skin at her throat was bare, unmarked.

Lamp-burn, he thought. Or a rope. A night guard carries a lamp too long, wraps the cloth wrong. Half his own garrison wore marks like it, on hands and forearms. She tugged the sleeve down, and he looked away, and the thought went into the place where he kept things that were not yet facts.

*

Janu fed them in the hall, because Janu would have fed the flood itself. She scolded the mud and the hour and the queen's justice, in that order, and set a bowl of rice and fish in front of Rema twice.

Rema ate like a person who had been hungry on principle. The escort did not eat in the hall. They stood by the pillars, two and two, and Janu's girls carried their bowls to them, and the bowls came back full.

"Your goat path has a drop at the boulder," Rema said between mouthfuls. "A fall I would not want my enemies to take. My escort strung ropes at the three worst places. In the dark, mind. I would have turned back at the first."

"Good soldiers."

"The best I have ever travelled with." She wiped her fingers. "I have gone on circuit with a great many soldiers, Warden. They snore. They grumble. They sleep on their feet at the wall and wake very cross. In nine hours on that mountain I did not see one of those four sit down, let alone sleep."

She said it lightly, as praise.

He said, "I'll have the south range made ready for them."

"Kind."

He said no more. When she looked toward Janu's steaming pot, he glanced across at the First Guard against her pillar. She was looking at nothing, at the middle of the air, her hands loose at her sides. She stood very still. He watched her sash a long while and could not catch it rising.

He picked up his bowl and did not taste it.

*

Neela was sitting on the edge of the bed with her hair half braided when he came in. She had heard the horn. He could see she had counted the doors.

"Before you ask," he said.

Her fingers stopped.

"A justice of the high court. Rema. Fifty-eight, tired, no fool. She brings a warrant for Ittan under the wartime charter, sealed in the queen's green wax. I asked for an assize, with Ittan as witness to Asha. She gave me three days. She sits here. Her escort stand at Ittan's door beside Bhaskaran's men. I agreed to that."

"You agreed."

"I had no way not to." He sat on his heels so she would not have to look up. "Four escort. They gave numbers, not names. They came by the goat path in a night of rain, and their packs are dry and their boots are new. Rema says they fixed ropes in the dark and she never saw one of them sleep."

"Everyone sleeps."

"That is what I thought."

"What else?"

"The seal on the warrant has a chip at the left wing tip. It's the same as the writ." He moved his hand once, flat. "And the First Guard, a woman, has a mark on the inside of her left wrist. One pale seam, about so long, smooth. Not like yours. Nothing at her throat. I took it for a lamp burn."

Neela said, "Which wrist?"

"Left. Inside."

"Mm," said Neela. She looked at her own right wrist, with its binding, and then at the shutters. Her next breath came a moment late. He saw it, and kept it.

"There's more," he said, because he had told himself in the passage that he would not stop at the easy end. "When I came up the stair I stopped at the corridor and told Raiu's relief, the new one, that you were not to be woken, and that if the justice's people asked, you were unwell. I was going to say the same to Janu. I was going to put you in the south range behind a bar. I thought, if she doesn't see you, she can't ask."

He heard how it sounded. The silence after it was not angry. It was attentive.

"But you came up here instead," she said.

"I came up to say it to you first. You have been shut behind my fences for a month, with good reason. I do not think it is a good reason now. I do not want you behind one that you did not choose."

She put her hands flat on her knees. "Do you know what it looks like," she said, "when a warden's wife is ill the morning a crown justice arrives? After the lord of the house has spent a month doing nothing but bar his shutters?"

"Like guilt."

"Like the only story that needs no help from anyone." She shook out the rest of her hair. "Hide me and she'll ask where I am. Hide me for three days and she'll find out, and she'll have asked it about every servant who ever carried a tray to my door. If I stand in the hall and Janu complains about my cooking, I am only a wife. A wife with a name on a crown writ, who ought to be proud of it."

"She will ask questions."

"She will." Neela met his eyes. "I'll answer them. I'll say only true things. It is more than most people do, and Chathu spent twenty years teaching me which ones to choose."

He had wanted to say *no*. He had been holding it since the gate, in the part of him that had learned at twenty-six what happens to the people behind a locked door. He turned it over and found, to his surprise, that she was right, and that the wanting was only fear.

"True things," he said.

"And you tell me everything she says. Everything. Before I ask."

"I've done that once this morning."

"You did well." Her mouth tilted. "Do it again."

"I will."

She stood. She caught his wrist as she passed, quick, the way she did at the kalari when she was about to correct his guard, and the bracelets of scar on her skin pressed hot against the pulse in his. Then she let go. "Which way do I walk into the hall?" she said. "From the east stair?"

"From the east stair."

"Then I'll take the west."

He looked at her.

"She won't have noticed which I use," Neela said. "I will." And she was out of the door before he could answer, with the third slat of the shutter complaining behind her in the draught.

*

Rema had moved to the warden's chair. Devan saw it as he came down the east steps: not a challenge, a convenience, the chair nearest the brazier. Janu had put a cushion on it. He found that he had no objection to the cushion.

His objection was to the man beside the chair. Muthu. Cheerful, loud, rain still on his collar, telling the justice that the fort had never seen so honoured a guest in his time and the south range had the best roof in the hill country. He laughed at his own words. He stopped laughing when Rema looked at him, and for the length of a breath his face was very quiet.

Devan marked it, and let it lie.

"A sentence of business, Warden, and then I shall sleep like your garrison," Rema said, as he came up. "The closing writ you sent down to Kodiyur with the last rider. It bore a household witness. A woman's name, written in a clerk's hand and a fresh hand beside it. *Neela, of Kettamala*."

"My wife."

"I know whose wife." She folded her hands. "I should like to meet her. By name. In my experience a writ is only as honest as the person who signed it, and I would like to look at her while I read."

He had meant to say something. Some courteous, unhelpful, dilatory thing.

"She is here," said Neela from the foot of the west stair.

She stood with one hand on the newel, on the parrot's smooth broken beak, and a face as unremarkable as a wall.

## Chapter 3

# Numbers, Not Names

"Ward of Kunjan Chirayil," Rema said, reading it off the marriage papers as if she were tasting it. "Of Kodiyur."

"That is the name on my marriage papers," said Neela.

She had crossed the hall at an even pace, with her shoulders down. She had taken the west stair on purpose, and the parrot's beak was still smooth under her palm in memory. Now she stood before the warden's chair with the whole hall listening. Janu hovered with a ladle. Muthu leaned on a pillar. Devan had come to stand at the end of the long bench, one step behind her left shoulder, where a man stands when he means to say nothing.

"Where were you raised?"

"In a house with a great many girls. A master kept the accounts. I learned to count there."

"A warehouse household," Rema said. It was not a question. She had filled the gap herself and looked pleased with the fit.

Neela let her. She said nothing false, and she did not say what Rema had heard. Twenty years of Chathu had taught her that the best lie was a true sentence with room around it.

"You met the warden before the wedding?"

"I met him at the wedding."

"A council match."

"Yes."

"And you signed the closing writ of your own will?"

"Nobody held my hand," Neela said. "The pass was closing and someone had to."

Rema's eyes went to her wrist. The binding showed under the cuff of the day cloth, a strip of clean linen over the torn ridges. The justice's gaze rested there as lightly as a fly, and moved on.

"A burn?"

"Yes. It's healing."

Neela did not look at the pillars. She did not need to. At the edge of her sight, First Guard stood square and still, and her eyes had gone to the binding a moment after the justice's. They stayed there a breath longer. Then they dropped, and her right hand drifted across and closed on her own left cuff.

Neela kept her face where it was. She counted the pillars. Eight. She filed the hand away.

"Are you content here, Lady Neela?"

*Content.* A clever word, with a trapdoor in it.

"I'm alive," Neela said. "I have a name in this house. Ask Janu how many others I've learned."

"Eleven," said Janu, from behind the ladle, in the voice of a woman defending a debt. "And she got Chinna's hip right the first time."

A few of the soldiers laughed. Rema smiled, and it reached her eyes by a hair. "You will be sworn at assize, you understand. Wife of the warden, household witness to the writ. You will answer what I ask."

"Yes."

"Good. I find the truth sits best on people who are tired of the other thing." She rose from the warden's chair with one hand on the small of her back. "Go to bed, all of you. I shall begin with the tallies in the morning."

Muthu came off his pillar and offered his arm to the justice, laughing again. Neela watched his mouth. It was a good laugh. It stopped a hair too soon.

*

The escort had not gone to bed.

The south range was lit and ready, Janu's girls had seen to that, but the four stood where they had stood at supper, two and two by the pillars, packs at their feet. Neela took a jug of water from the kitchen girl at the door and went down the hall with it, because she asked everyone.

It was the rule she had built her whole self on. A servant, a guard, a goat-boy. You ask the name, and you say it back once so it knows you meant it. A person who has a name can't be walked past.

She stopped before the first pillar and held out the cup. "Water? I'm Neela."

"Thank you, no." The woman had a rope's body and a face with the colour taken out. "First."

"First what?"

"First Guard."

"Has your mother a name for you?"

"I am First."

It was said without heat. There was no insult in it and no joke. Neela had expected a wall, a person standing behind the word. There was no one behind it. It was only flat, and it was worse than a wall.

She went on to the next. The man at the second pillar glanced at First before he spoke. It was a short look, the look of a dog waiting for the hand. "Second."

The third said, "Third," to the air above her head. The fourth, the youngest by the look of the throat, wet his lips and said, "Fourth," and added nothing, and lowered his eyes.

Twenty-one years she had answered to *Seventeen*. She had thought she knew every way a number could sit in a mouth. She had never heard four people say it as if their mothers had given it to them.

The jug was heavy. She poured a cup for herself and drank it to give her hands something to do.

The warrant had not frightened her. A warrant was paper, and paper could be read. These four did not read. Not one of them had asked for a chair, or a boiled egg, or where the privy was. They had taken a night

mountain in a rain that had sent the langurs silent, and their packs were dry.

Who empties four people out, she wondered, and then sends them up a mountain at night with a queen's sash on?

She did not know. That was what chilled her. A man with a hidden name had something to lose, and she could always work out the cost of losing it. These four seemed to have nothing hidden at all. They had been hollowed out and set on guard.

*

The yard was black and wet. She went out by the kitchen door because she could not yet face the bed, and found the hounds loose.

For nine days of rain they had been shut in the long kennel behind the stables. Devan had let them out at dusk that day, without saying why. All fourteen ran the yard now, as the fort's hounds had always run it, big rough brindled animals who did not trouble anyone who belonged.

They did not trouble her. One shouldered her thigh as she passed. They had always taken her scent as if she had been born in it. But when she looked toward the south range, where the escort's lamps burned yellow in the shutter-cracks, there was not a dog on that side of the yard.

They stood in a half-ring at the edge of the lamplight, thirty paces off. Heads low. One whined, high and thin through its nose. Another turned in a tight circle and sat down with its back to the south range, like a man pretending not to hear.

"They've been like that since the gate."

Kannan was on the ladder of his loft, a small shape against the stable wall, with the white goat nosing at his ankle. Pepper bit at the rung. He kicked her gently.

"Since dusk," Kannan said. "They wouldn't go near when the justice's people came in. My mother Bindu's dog did that, once. When a snake was in the thatch."

"Did it find the snake?"

"It found it." He considered. "Bhaskaran says they're only wet."

"Wet dogs don't whine like that."

"No," said Kannan, with a nine-year-old's contempt for the sergeant.

She stood a while with her hand on a hound's rough head. It leaned into her palm. She should have found that comforting, and she told herself that she did.

"Go to sleep," she said. "Take Pepper."

"Pepper doesn't go to sleep. She plans."

"Then plan quietly."

*

The dispensary smelled of camphor and old paper. Eravi sat bent over a mortar with his lamp turned low, a stooped man who always looked as if the ceiling were coming down on his shoulders. He did not ask why she had come at that hour. He took her hand and turned it to the light.

"Three nails," he said. "Split to the quick. This one has bled into the bed."

"I slept badly."

"You sleep like a hunted deer, my lady, and your husband has the same trouble." He reached behind him for a pot of green clay, thumbed off the lid and sniffed it. "This is good for splitting. I had it from the justice's people only this evening. The young one, the fourth, came for his blisters. He left me a pot for thanks."

"Fourth Guard came to you?"

"He had a bad heel. They had climbed all night in new boots, whatever else you say." He worked a smear on her first nail with the tip of his little finger. "Bark salve. Their own. It will draw the heat out."

It was warm. Then the smell reached her.

Bitter. Scorched tamarind, and sap that had been burnt on a stone, and under it a thin sweet note of pine.

Night had fallen an hour ago. Resin on a wrist after sunset meant a turning inside a minute, here, under a physician's lamp. Her mind went cold and quick, the way it did on a wall.

She looked. The clay sat on the nail and on nothing else. Not the quick of the finger, not the wrist, not the pulse in it. She kept her hand where it was, because snatching it back would have been a sentence. Then she took the edge of her cloth from her lap, as if to dab at a stray smear, and wiped the nail clean under Eravi's eyes. He only grunted and reached for the linen.

She counted the minute. Sixty, slowly, against the tick of the lamp. Her throat stayed her own. Her skin stayed skin.

She had smelled that bitterness every night of her adult life. She had smelled it on her own wrists. On the day Chathu first held her hand over the clay cup she had smelled it for hours, in her hair and on her pillow, and spent a year trying to wash it out.

"What bark is it?"

"I never asked. A hill bark of some kind." He bandaged the nail. "It will be a good deal for the price."

Many barks were bitter. That was all it was. Half the tanning yards in Varanad smelled of scorched something. The justice's party had come over the mountains, and in the mountains there were many trees.

*Many barks are bitter*, she told herself, and counted the nails on her left hand, and got to four, and lost the number, and counted again.

"You've gone quiet," said Eravi mildly.

"It's late."

"It is." He put the pot in her palm. "Keep it. I have no use for what I don't understand."

She walked out with the lid pressed down under her thumb. She did not open it again.

*

The hall was dark but for the brazier and one lamp at the far end. She had come down to leave the pot in the strongbox with the rest of the things she did not want to carry, and she stopped in the arch because someone was talking.

Devan stood alone before the long bench.

The bench was empty. He had set a stool at the head of it, perhaps to be the justice, and he faced it with his hands clasped behind his back and his shoulders square, like a man about to be shot.

"My sister Asha, who was twenty-two," he told the stool, "was killed on the west stair of this fort by a creature that could not have entered by any gate, and I have reason to believe, and have long believed, that the Keeper of the Passes, in concert with persons I am not yet able to name, did—" He stopped. His jaw worked. "No."

He began again. "In the sixth year before this one."

He stopped again.

"The tally," he said, to the stool, with great force. "Bhaskaran passed a cart. The wax on the tally is council wax, and I submit, I submit in the strongest—" He stood there. The lamp flickered. He took a breath that reached the roof, and let it go, and said, in a voice she had never heard from him, very low, "I can't make it come out in order."

She had seen him with a raider's arrow in his arm. She had seen him not flinch while Eravi bled him twice. She had never seen the warden of Kettamala afraid of a stool.

She had come down to leave a pot and go. She stepped out of the arch instead, into the edge of the lamplight.

"That was bad," she said.

He turned. He did not startle. He did, for a moment, go the colour of the wall. "How long were you there?"

"Since *creature*."

"Ah."

"You used *I submit* twice. Nobody has submitted anything in your whole life. Your face is going to do that thing in front of a hundred people." She came down the hall with the pot in her hand. "Also you said *reason to believe*, *long believed* and *in concert*. That is three ways of telling her you aren't sure."

"I am not sure."

"Then don't say so in three ways. Say the part you are." She set the pot on the bench. "What can you prove?"

"Asha is dead."

"Prove it. How?"

"Janu found her. The stair. The wounds."

"Good. That's one. What else?"

He thought. She watched him lay it out the way he laid out a patrol, in a line, nothing wasted. "The tally. The tally was passed by Bhaskaran on the strength of council wax. It matches the satchel on the narrows. It matches the token Asha kept. The dot and the split are the same."

"Say that."

"I did say that."

"You said it with *submit*." She took the stool away and stood where it had been, and put her hands behind her back, and made her face a justice's: patient, tired, rather bored. "Warden. Tell me about the wax."

He looked at her. His mouth did something odd. "The wax is council wax. It carries the dot-and-split mark. Bhaskaran passed a tally of that wax at the new moon before my wedding. The tally number matches a satchel taken at the narrows. It matches a token my sister hid before she died." He stopped. She waited. He stopped some more.

"Good," she said softly.

"That's all?"

"That's all. Don't add the rest."

"The rest is the point."

"The rest is her point. Let her get there herself. If you hand a judge your conclusion she'll take it for a thing you want. If she finds it, she'll think it is true." She let the justice drop from her face. "You've commanded sixty men for five years. You say *go* and they go. This is the same, and it is harder. You're not asking for obedience. You're asking to be believed."

"They are not the same?"

"One is a rope. The other is a bridge." She heard how it sounded and shrugged. "Chathu used to have us practise in the long room. Girls who were sent into a rich house had to be taken for what they said they were. I was good at it."

"Of course you were." He said it plainly, the way he said everything, and there was no knife in it. "Again?"

They did it four times. She asked, and he answered in order, and each time something fell off the end of his answer. *In concert* went on the second. *Creature* went on the third, and she did not tell him why she was glad. By the fourth he stood with his hands loose at his sides, the wax and the tally and the date lined up in his mouth like men on parade, and no more.

"Raiders don't take notes," he said, near the end, to the empty bench.

"What?"

"I was thinking that I would rather face raiders."

"I'd rather you did, too. You'd cheat less."

His laugh was a short dry thing, mostly breath, and it startled him as much as it startled her. He rubbed his jaw. In the lamplight the tiredness stood out on him like bone.

"You do this well," he said.

"It's the only thing I do well that I'm not ashamed of."

He didn't answer that. He took the stool from the floor and set it back at the head of the bench, carefully, like a man putting away a borrowed tool. Then, without turning, he said, "May I ask you one?"

"Ask."

"I'm not spending a pass on it." He faced her. "If the court asks you what you are. Not your name. Not your house. What you are. What will you say?"

The brazier ticked. Somewhere above them the cistern chain clanked the hour, slow, iron on iron.

She opened her mouth. She had a cover, and it was good. She had true sentences with room around them, a ward of Kunjan Chirayil, a girl raised among girls, a wife who learned names. All of them were walls. He knew it. He had asked for the thing on the other side.

*A leopard*, said the part of her that had been twenty-one years a number. She could not say it. It was the one word in the world she could not give away, in any room, to any ear.

*An odiyan*, said another, and her skin went cold. That was a rope for her own neck.

*Seventeen*, said a third, and that was the only answer she had ever been taught.

"Ask me something else," she said.

"No," said Devan, very gently. "I'll wait."

"Then that is my pass." Her voice came out thinner than she meant. "One refusal each, and you said you'd let it lie. I'm spending mine."

"It lies," he said. "I didn't say I'd stop wondering."

She stood in the lamp's small ring, with a pot of bark salve on the bench beside her, and understood that the justice had set the oath for the morning after next, and that she did not know what she would swear to.

## Chapter 4

# Ask Your Captain

For the first time since the gate, no green sash stood at Ittan's door.

Devan saw it from the far end of the passage. Rema had called her escort to the hall to carry the tally chest. Bhaskaran's men held the guardroom alone, and the man holding it was Unni, thin as a spear shaft, with his mother's salt-fish smell still in his jerkin.

"Sir. The justice said two of hers at the door at all times."

"The justice is counting wax," Devan said. "Shut this behind me. Knock when the chain strikes."

Unni looked at the iron cistern chain through the passage slit, then back at him. He was not much past twenty and he had a good face for being afraid in. "Yes, sir."

The guardroom smelled of wet wool and lamp oil. Ittan sat on the cot with his writing case on his knees and his hands folded on the lid, like a man waiting for a ferry. He had been a round man. Since the sealing he had lost something from the cheeks.

"My friend," he said. "You look worse than I do."

"I haven't been given a cot."

"No. They only give those to traitors." The smile came and went. "You want something. You have your sister's face on. It is a very good face, it has never once learned to hide."

Devan took the stool by the door and kept the lamp between them.

"Rema sits assize for you. You will be heard as witness. If you swear before her that the hand that sold the passes also bought Asha's death, she has to carry you out as a witness, not a traitor. I need you sworn. I need names."

"Do you?"

"A witness gets a hearing in Kodiyur. A traitor gets a rope on the road."

Ittan looked at his hands. "Do you know what an oath is, Warden? It is a man choosing which person to be afraid of. I am a long way past choosing." He lifted his eyes. The lamp stood in them, bright and full, and nothing fell. "I will swear to nothing. Not the day of the week. I ask only one thing."

"Ask."

"My wife has a cough. It's bad in the damp, and this is the damp season." The voice was still genial. The words came slow, one stone at a time. "There is a brown jar in my case. The physicians make it, honey and root, the sweet kind, to take after the willow bark. She won't take the bark without it. If you would send it on with the next rider, and not forget that she likes it warmed."

Devan had expected a bargain. A name for a name, or a door left unlocked. He had braced for that all morning.

"I'll send it," he said.

"You will. You're a man who does." Ittan shut his eyes. "That is why they—" He stopped himself.

"Give me the names of her physicians," Devan said. "I'll write to them myself, in my own hand, with my seal. Tell them where she's to be looked after, what dose, who pays. The bill will be Kettamala's. She'll not be left."

He had not planned to say it. It came out as plain as a ration count, and he saw it land.

Ittan's mouth worked. His fingers closed on the case so hard the knuckles went the colour of tallow. For a moment the whole round, easy face was gone, and what looked out was a frightened man of forty-nine who had a wife.

"You would," he whispered. "Salt and pepper, you would. That is the trouble with you."

"Ittan."

"Ask your captain." The words fell out low and fast. "Ask your captain what he brought me."

Devan did not breathe. "When? The morning after the vow?"

Ittan opened his mouth. Then he closed it, and Devan watched him fold himself away. The hands settled on the lid. The eyes went to the lamp and stayed there. He sat four feet away, and he was not in the room.

"Ittan."

Nothing. A drip in the corner. The chain struck the hour, iron on iron, and Unni's knuckles rapped twice on the door.

*

Muthu was at the padippura, laughing.

He stood with Bhaskaran under the gate roof, arguing the price of a bad axle with a pepper carter who had walked up in the rain to complain. He had one arm round the carter's shoulders. The carter, who had come to shout, was grinning. That was Muthu's gift. People gave him their anger and walked away holding something warmer.

Devan stood in the arch until the carter went. Then he said, "Ittan says you brought him something."

"Brought him?" The laugh came up, huge and rolling, the one that turned heads in the lower market. "Warden, I brought him the fort's whole patience. Two meals a day and a blanket, and a lecture on the price of cloves from Bhaskaran, who'll—"

He stopped.

It was not a pause. A pause had breath in it. This was the stillness of a man set down in a room with no air, the big hands hanging, the face gone smooth. Devan had known that stillness since they were boys in the red earth, when Muthu had sworn he hadn't touched the sweets.

"That's all," Muthu said quietly. "Ask Bhaskaran. It's on the roll."

Bhaskaran, who had been studying the rain, said nothing. He had the sense not to.

Devan could have spoken then. He could have said *the packet*, *the grey wax*, *what you carried into that room at first light*. He weighed it, with the justice's escort a hundred paces off and the hearing a day away.

If he named it now, he lost Muthu. A man named stops being a captain. He becomes a prisoner, or a stranger, and either way he leaves the gate. And Devan needed sixty soldiers who believed their warden trusted every one of them. He needed the padippura held by a man the garrison loved, with Rema's eyes on it, until the hearing had been heard.

A man you suspect is safest on the wall, where you can see his hands.

"Hold the gate through the hearing," he said. "Nothing in or out without your mark."

Muthu's face came back, in pieces, the grin first. "As if I'd be anywhere else."

"No," Devan said. "You wouldn't."

He walked back through the rain with his shoulders square. Behind him Muthu's laugh started up again, loud and warm, and Devan thought it the worst sound he had heard in years.

*

"He told you to ask your captain," said Neela. "In those words."

"In those words. Then he shut like a door."

The lamp was low. They had not lit the second. The shutters were closed, the cotton curtain behind them hung still, and Devan sat on the edge of the bed with his sword across his knees because he had nothing else to do with his hands. Neela stood by the window with her arms folded. She had not slept. It showed in the way she held her left hand away from her body, the three bandaged fingers curled.

She had taken his report in order, as she'd asked in the morning. He had told her about Ittan before she could ask. It was the first thing out of his mouth in the door.

"Muthu is the guild's man," she said.

"Muthu is the queen's."

"You've decided."

"I've watched him write grey-wax letters for six years. They go with the palace rider." He turned the sword. "The queen's household. Rema looked at him in the hall and he went quiet for a breath. He did not do that for anyone else. He knows what she is."

"He goes quiet when he lies. You told me. He'd go quiet in front of any justice who looked at him straight." She came away from the window. "Think of the cart. I gave Muthu an order out of your hearing, and by that dusk Chathu knew to have Vellan at his gate. Who else knew?"

"You were followed."

"On a grey mare, a night and a day ahead of any hunter? No. Someone told them." Her eyes went to the floor. "A house pays its debts in news. Chathu said it to me with his sweets in front of me. And Ittan bought my contract through that house. A man who brings Ittan things is a man who answers to Ittan's creditor."

"Or the packet came from the palace and Ittan was its last stop."

"Then why would Ittan point at him?"

"To spite the one who sent it." Devan heard it as he said it, and did not like it. "A man who's lost everything tells you who to hate. It does not have to be true."

"No." She sat on the sill and the wood creaked. "Nor does yours." She looked at him. "The packet is in the hall strongbox. One cut under the wax and we'd know whose it is. Why don't we break it?"

"Because Muthu would know he is read." He had turned that over on the stair. "The day before the hearing. He'd see the seal was lifted, and he'd know by whom, and the gate goes with him. Sixty men watch the man who holds it. Whichever of us is right, I'd lose the only place I can see his hands."

"So the wax stays whole."

"The wax stays whole. We argue it out the long way."

"Then it's a choice, not a proof." She nodded slowly. "I'll take that."

"He held the gatehouse arch for me at the Resin House," Devan said. "He took spears for that."

"A man can hold a gate for you and write to someone who wants you dead. I did both for a month." The words were quiet. "He may love you. Most people who sell you do."

He had no answer for that. He looked at his hands. He had known Muthu since he was nine and Muthu twelve. He knew how the man took his tea, and which knee ached in the rains, and how he had sat up three nights after Asha with a lantern, saying nothing, drinking Janu's bitter tonic without complaint. If Muthu was lying, it was a thing built so long and so well that Devan would have to unbuild a good part of himself to see it.

"You think I'm blind," he said.

"I think you're a man who has kept one friend for more than twenty years and doesn't mean to lose him in a night." She did not smile. "I'm not arguing so I'm right. If I'm wrong, I wish to be. Muthu laughs at my jokes."

"Everyone laughs at your jokes."

"Not Rema's guards."

It almost made him smile. It did not reach his mouth.

"We have one night of it," he said. "Tomorrow, the hearing. Rema wants the tallies, the satchel, the chest, Ittan. And you sworn. What else?" He did not need to say *what else do I have that she does not.* Behind the third slat, in the hollow of the shutter frame, lay an oilcloth bundle tied with red thread. He had not looked at it in three days. He knew its weight exactly.

Neela turned her head toward the slat, and then did not.

"The payment writ," she said.

"Yes."

"Seven weeks before the wedding. The queen's green wax, with the chip."

"Yes."

"If you hand it to Rema, she reads it."

"She is a justice of the high court. It's her office to read it. The charter says a warden shall lay all evidence before a justice sitting assize." He kept his voice flat, because flat was the only way he could say it. "It's the law I've held for five years."

"And she serves the queen."

"She does."

"Then what does she do," Neela said slowly, "with a writ that proves her mistress paid for your death?"

He had asked himself that on the stair, in the passage, in the rain at the gate. He had not liked any of the answers, so he had gone on asking.

"She reads it," he said. "She goes the colour of ash. She says it's a forgery. Or she says it's real and she's grateful, and she carries it to Kodiyur in the sleeve of her coat, with Ittan in front of her on a rope." He let the sword lie. "A justice of the queen's court can try Ittan. She can try me. She cannot try the queen. There's no bench in Varanad above the queen's bench, and if there were, who would sit it?"

"So the only proof you have goes to the one person it can hurt."

"And never comes back." He stopped. "Neela, if I withhold it, I break the charter. A warden who sits on evidence at assize is a warden the queen can strip, with the law on her side. I have never broken it. Not once, in five years. It's the only wall I've built that I'm proud of."

She was quiet for a time. She did not tell him it didn't matter. He was grateful for that.

"I'm sworn at the hearing," she said at last. "As household witness. She asks me what I know. I tell her true things." Her mouth moved. "I've told you what I'll say to a justice. A true sentence with room around it. But the room is yours, Devan. If she asks me what's behind the slat, I won't know what you want me to say."

He had been about to say *I'll decide it*. He heard himself, and did not say it.

"Tell me what you want," he said. "Not what you'd bear. What you'd do."

"I'd keep it." No hesitation. "I'd keep it behind the slat until we've found a bench above hers. I don't know where one is. I'd keep looking."

"It's my neck."

"It's my name on the closing writ. If you break the charter, I'm the witness who stood beside you. I'll share that." She put one hand over her bandaged fingers. "We could be wrong. She could be better than I think. I've known three justices, and none of them was good."

"And if she asks me whether I hold such a writ?"

"Then you'll say what you say."

"I'll say I won't answer."

"She'll know there's something."

"She will know there's something," he agreed. "That's different from knowing what." He looked at the shutter, at the third slat with its small, complaining creak that he had never fixed. "I won't lie to her. I won't lie to you. I can refuse."

"Then refuse." Her voice was dry. "I'll be beside you, being a wife."

He set the sword on the floor. He stood, and she stood, and for a moment neither of them touched the other. It was not the kind of moment that wanted touching. They were two people who had weighed a thing and put it in the same pan.

"Together," he said.

"Together." She held out her good hand, and he took it as one takes the hand of a man who has agreed to a contract, quickly and hard. Her palm was cold. Then, because there was no one to see it, she did not let go for a breath.

*

Neither of them slept. In the last dark hour the lamp burned to a thread, the cistern chain struck the turn of the watch, and the thin rain seemed to hold its breath against the shutters.

Neela lay on her side with her eyes open. He lay on his back. She had told him once that she counted exits, steps and breaths when she was

afraid. He listened, and could hear it, the small dry sound of a lip moving on a number.

He was thinking of a brown jar, and a woman he had never met, who liked her medicine warmed.

The knock was soft. Two knuckles, then a third, then nothing, as though the hand behind it was ashamed.

Devan was off the bed with his sword before he knew he had risen. Neela was beside him with her feet bare. He opened the door a hand's width.

Unni stood in the corridor with no lamp. His jerkin was wet to the collar. He had run the whole of the west stair, and he was breathing in short pieces, like a boy who has been told to carry bad water and not spill.

"Sir." His voice cracked. "The justice. She's moved it."

"Moved what?"

"The execution. Ittan." Unni swallowed. "She has found a clause in the wartime charter, sir. A prisoner whose keeping endangers the pass. Dawn. This dawn. She says the hearing can sit without him." He licked his lips. "She says she'll hold it all the same, for the record."

Behind Devan, very quietly, Neela let out a breath.

"The escort," Devan said.

"They're already in the court. All four, in green sashes. First Guard has a block." Unni's eyes were enormous. "She had Bhaskaran's night men told to stand down, sir. Sixty of us, and they walked past us to the guardroom and nobody stopped them. They said it was the queen's sash."

He hesitated, and then it came out of him all at once. "Do we stop them, sir? Bhaskaran has the lads half up. They're only waiting on you."

Devan did not answer.

He saw it whole. One word, and sixty spears would go down the west stair and take the court from four people. And by noon every man who followed him would be a mutineer against the queen's own sash, with a rope in Kodiyur waiting for each. Neela's eyes were on his face. She did not tell him what to say.

Unni waited. The rain ticked on the shutters.

Outside, over the wet roofs, the sky had not yet begun to grey.

## Chapter 5

# Dawn Writ

Devan walked out into the rain without his cloak and stopped ten paces from the block.

Neela stopped a pace behind his left shoulder, where a wife stands when she has been told to be one. The court was red mud and standing water under a sky the colour of a pot lid. Someone had brought the chopping stump from the wood yard and scrubbed it pale. The four green sashes had gone dark with wet. First Guard stood beside the stump with her hands folded, as if she waited for a ferry.

Sixty men of the garrison lined the walls and the gallery with their spears grounded. Not one of them spoke.

Justice Rema stood under the hall roof, where the water ran off the thatch in a bright fringe. She held an oilcloth case against her coat.

"Justice," Devan said. He did not raise his voice, and it carried to the gate anyway. "I enter an objection under the assize charter, before the garrison, and I ask that it be written."

"Say it, Warden."

"A witness named to a sitting is held for the sitting. You granted an assize. You named Councillor Ittan to it. You cannot put him to the sword at dawn and sit at noon on his evidence."

"Your reading of the charter is correct." Rema said it without heat. Water dripped from her hood onto the case. "The queen's warrant outranks

the hearing. The sitting will hear what it hears, and the man has no need to be there to be heard of. Your objection is entered. I shall write it myself."

Neela watched the wall, because she could not watch Devan's back. Bhaskaran had a hand shut on his spear until the knuckles stood out. Unni's mouth was open. Along the gallery men glanced at one another, then at Devan, and each glance held a question every one of them already knew the answer to. Sixty spears. Four people. Muthu stood under the gate arch with his big hands hanging, and he was not laughing.

"I have sixty men on these walls," Devan said.

The rain made the only sound.

"I could stop this before the stroke. Any man here knows it, and so do you, Justice. I won't. A man who stands against a sealed warrant is a traitor in Kodiyur, and I will not make traitors of sixty for one who would not swear to the day of the week." He drew a breath. "Let it be written that I could."

Rema looked at him for a long moment. Something crossed her face that might have been regret, and might have been a thing she had trained out of herself years ago.

"It will be written," she said.

Neela's throat hurt. He had stood behind that lock for eight years, and now he had stood in the rain and called it by name so that no man on the wall could mistake it for fear. It looked like strength. She thought it was probably both, and that he did not yet know the two could be one thing.

They brought Ittan out of the guardroom between two of Bhaskaran's men, who let go of him at the edge of the stone as if they were returning a borrowed coat. He had no writing case. Without it his hands did not know what to do. He looked at the sky, then at Devan, and found a smile somewhere.

"My friend. The jar?"

"It goes down with the first runner," Devan said. "Warmed, as you said."

"Good. Good." Ittan nodded as if a price had been settled. His eyes went past Devan and found nothing in particular. "Tell her to keep the window open in rain. She likes to hear it."

Nobody answered. There was nothing to answer. Second and Third took his arms, gently. He went with them, still nodding.

Neela turned, walked to the wall stair by the gate, and climbed it.

*

The west rampart ran above the warden's window, where the sentry used to stand. Here the wall bent toward the padippura, and the whole court lay below her like a dish. She leaned her forearms on the wet stone.

She had seen men die. She had learned young that you do not watch the block, because the block tells you nothing. You watch the hands. The hands are where the order lives.

The hands of the escort did not wait for an order.

Second and Third set Ittan on his knees at the stump. They let go of his arms in the same instant, though no one counted. First Guard drew her sword in a single motion and held it in both hands. Fourth stood behind her with his hands open at his sides, and the rain ran off his fingers. Nobody spoke. Nobody looked at anybody else. When the stroke came, Second and Third had already stepped back, and Neela could not have said who had moved first.

She had seen hands move like that once. Twenty girls at the long table in the Resin House, all reaching for the bowl at the first note of Chathu's bell.

Afterwards Fourth's hands began to shake, and he put them behind him. First Guard wiped the blade on a cloth, folded the cloth, and put it away. Then her left hand went to her left cuff and closed on it, and stayed there.

Neela did not move. The wind had swung round off the hills, from the south range across the court and up the wall, and it brought her the rain and the mud. Under them came something else, thin, scorched and bitter.

Tamarind burnt on a stone. Pine sap, and old.

It was not salve. It was a jar opened long ago and shut again, a smell worn into leather and cloth and hair. She breathed through her mouth and still it came. Down in the court a hound began to whine, high through the nose. Then another. The whole loose pack drew back toward the kitchen door in a body, heads low, and sat.

Three times now. The salve on Eravi's thumb had been the first. She had told herself many barks were bitter, and she had counted her nails to prove it. There was no counting this. It came off all four of them, and it had been on them a long time.

Chathu's hunters carried resin in oiled leather for one purpose. A rogue taken in the day must be turned by dusk, whether she would or no. These four had no hooked poles and no nets. But poles and nets were things you left at the foot of a mountain. They did not come up the road in a queen's sash.

Her name was on the closing writ. She had put it there herself, of her own will, in clean ink, as the warden's wife. Any clerk in Kodiyur could lay it beside a list of unvouched odiyans.

*They are here for me*, she thought, and stood very still with her ruined nails pressed into the wet stone, and watched them carry the body out.

*

The pit was a place she had been in once before, at dawn, with her fingers on a man's neck. She came down the north steps in the afternoon with the rain thinned to a drizzle, and the sesame-oil lamps burning in their niches round the rim.

Devan could not stop moving.

He went from one form to the next without a gap between, and each was faster than the last. She had seen him do it once at dawn, quick and deadly, but that was practice. This was a man trying to run out of the end of himself. Red earth flew up from his heels.

A stinging line opened across the back of her right knuckle, thin and bright. He had scraped the pit wall on a turn. The welt rose on her skin and then paled, no wider than a thread.

She stepped down onto the earth. It was cold and wet and it came up through her toes.

"Don't," he said, without turning. "If you've come to tell me I did the right thing."

"I wasn't going to."

"Or that it was not mine to carry."

"That either."

He stopped. His chest went in and out. There was a smear of blood on the heel of his right hand and he looked at it as if it belonged to someone else. "Then what?"

"A round."

He stared at her.

"Janu told me in the first week. Eight years. Muthu asks every seventh day and you say no." She kept her voice level. "I can't comfort you, Devan. I haven't the trade for it. You would thank me and carry on being alone with it. You can't stop moving, and I would rather you moved at someone."

"I would hurt you."

"You'd mean not to. That's the usual way."

"Your hand."

"The left. I'll keep it behind me." She tucked it into the small of her back, three bound nails and all. "Two points. Light touch, no marma. You are not to pull so hard you insult me."

He looked at her for a long time. Then he went to the rim, picked up the oil lamp that stood nearest her, and set it on the far side of the pit. It was a small thing. It took the heat off her bad hand.

"Two points," he said.

The first bout was nothing. He was careful, and she hated it. He circled to keep her on his right, where her bandaged fingers lay away from him, and he never once swung at her left side. She gave ground and read his feet. She tapped the air a hand's width from his collarbone, and he stepped out of it and did not strike back.

"Who were they?" he said, circling. "Your guess."

"Hunters. Guild hunters, carrying resin."

"They carried no poles."

"Hunters leave the poles at the foot of the pass. The ones who come in leave their faces." She slipped a cut at her ribs. "They hadn't a face between them."

"The queen has a company that goes where she wants no questions asked. A standing company, sashed, trained to do the thing and say nothing." He parried her wrist. "They'd look hollow. That is how you train a man to obey."

"First Guard touched her cuff when she saw my binding."

"She has a lamp-burn on that wrist. I saw it in the hall."

"She touched it when she saw mine," Neela said. "She touched it again after Ittan."

He did not answer. He was thinking, and she took the opening. It was a clean one, the left side of his guard. She had told him it dropped there once, at the end of a long night, with her fingers at the back of his neck. It had been mended. It had mended in a week.

It was open again now.

She went in under it and laid two fingers against his left ribs, light as a leaf, and stepped out.

"One," she said.

He looked down at the place she had touched. Then up. "You saw it open."

"You opened it."

"Yes."

"That one you gave me."

"Yes." He did not say it like an apology. "You'd have found it by the third bout. I saved you the trouble."

"Don't." Her voice came out rougher than she meant. "Do it again and mean the rest. I don't want one he gave me."

"Then you'll have to earn the next one."

"I will."

She did. It took longer, and it cost her a bruise on the shoulder that rose as a faint welt on his. He came at her in earnest at the end, fast and without waste, and for three breaths she saw what the dawn drills were for. She saw too what he had spent eight years refusing to do. Then she dropped under a sweep, rolled across the red mud, came up inside his reach, and tapped the notch under his ear with one finger.

She let him see her pleased. She did not hide it. It spread across her face before she could stop it, a plain stupid grin, the first she had worn since the wall.

Devan stood in the middle of the pit and looked at it like a man reading a map he had been missing a sheet of. Mud ran down his face. Slowly, from the corner out, his mouth gave way.

"Two," he said.

"Two."

"Muthu will want it told."

"Muthu can ask." She wiped her palm on her skirt and her voice did not shake. "Same time tomorrow?"

"Yes," said Devan.

He said nothing else. He picked up the oil lamp from the far side of the pit, carried it back to its niche beside her, and set it down where it had been.

*

At dusk the escort walked out.

Rema had shut herself in the south range with the tally chest from noon and sent word that the sitting would open at lamp-lighting, once her people were away. The pass was closed to carts, but a walker with a good pair of boots could take the goat path left of the split boulder. Neela had never said how she knew it. She stood in the shadow of the padippura post and watched the four go by in file, packs high on their shoulders.

Muthu sat at the gate table with the roll open and his pen in his hand. He wrote four marks and did not laugh. He did not look up either. Neela marked it and kept it.

The rain had thickened again. The light was going out of the court.

"Walk safe," she said, because she said it to everyone.

Second and Third went past her as though she were a post. Fourth glanced at her and away. First Guard, last in line, slowed.

Neela had her bad hand on the wet gatepost. She had forgotten it. The bandage had come loose on the middle finger, and the nail showed under it, split to the quick and brown at the edge.

First Guard's eyes rested on it. They were the colour of nothing at all. She did not stop walking, and she did not seem to know she was saying it.

"It passes."

Then she was through the arch and into the dusk, and the rain took her.

Neela stayed where she was until the last green sash went out of sight over the first bend. Beside her Muthu capped his ink. He had not heard, or he had chosen to be a man who hadn't.

*It passes.* Two words. Nobody knew about the nails except Eravi, Devan and herself. She had split them in her sleep, and they would split again, and the only people in Varanad who could say those words and mean them were people who had waited out the ache.

She went in out of the rain, and did not look at the sky.

*

Rema had taken the warden's chair again. The lamps were lit down the long hall and Janu had put out a plate of boiled eggs that nobody touched. The chest of tallies stood at the justice's left hand, with the lid up.

Devan stood before the bench with his hands loose at his sides. Neela came to his shoulder. She counted the pillars, eight, and the doors, three, and found she did not need to.

"I have buried a man this day on my own warrant," said Rema. "I will not do it twice without cause." She rubbed her lower back with one hand. "The pass is shut. I mean to sit until it opens. I shall hear the warden's case, in its order, when the tallies are counted. And any other the crown has sealed."

She reached into her coat and took out a second case.

It was leather, oiled, the size of the one that had hung from her hip at dawn. The first had held the warrant. She set the second on the table next to the chest and laid her hand flat on its lid. The wax at the knot was dark and the lamp was behind it, and Neela could not read the seal. The justice's thumb rested on it, lightly, as on a pulse.

Rema had carried it up a mountain in the rain. She had stood in the court at dawn with Ittan on his knees and had not opened it.

"Lady Neela," said Rema pleasantly. "You shall be sworn when I call you."

Beside her Devan said nothing. His hand moved the width of a finger, and the back of it touched hers.

Neela did not move her hand away.

## Chapter 6

# The Ledger He Needs

"Bring me the guild's paper," said Rema, "and leave your grief at the door."

She said it to Devan, across the tally chest, with the lamps burning down the length of the hall. Neela stood at his shoulder and counted the eight pillars again, because her hands wanted something to do.

The sitting had run two hours. Rema had counted wax, weighed the satchel, and made Bhaskaran swear to the cart that passed on a council tally at the new moon before the wedding. She had been exact and dry and fair, and Neela had hated every minute of it. A fair justice is the hardest kind to lie to.

"You have a dead man's tally book," Rema went on. "It shows payments to a house in the Blackbark Wood and a mark I'm told means *delivered*. You have a slip in resin-ink that your wife says came off a courier. A slip is a slip. A sister's drawn parrot is a story." She did not look at Neela when she said *wife*. "But a house that sells deaths has to bill for them. Someone writes down who paid, who died and who was sent. Bring me that. Ink I can swear to, laid on a bench where a bench can see it."

"The guild keeps its contracts in one book," Devan said.

"Then it keeps them where I can reach them, or I have heard a great deal of grief for nothing." Rema folded her hands. "I've seen yours, Warden. It doesn't weigh anything in court. The paper might."

She dismissed them with a nod. The case with the second seal stayed unopened under her palm.

Neela walked out beside him and said nothing until the hall door shut. Then she said, "Contract books."

"Yes."

"She thinks they're only that."

"What else would she think?" He looked at her sideways. "What else are they?"

Neela did not answer. She was already counting the ways it could go wrong.

*

Devan wrote the letter at the table in the warden's chamber, by the one lamp, with the shutters barred behind him.

She had expected a short one. A man who answers questions with exact facts does not write long. But he had been at it a quarter of an hour, and the pen kept stopping. The brown jar stood by his elbow. It had come out of Ittan's writing case that afternoon with the lid still sticky. Kesu's grandson would carry it down the goat path at first light, wrapped in wet cloth against the cold.

Neela sat on the bed with her bandaged hand in her lap and watched him.

"You can read it," he said, without turning.

"I'd rather not."

"Then watch the wax instead."

She watched. He wrote to the household of the Keeper of the Passes, in Kodiyur. She caught that much over his shoulder, and a line near the foot: *He asked that you keep the window open in rain. I have promised it will be remembered.* He did not soften the first line, which said her husband had died at dawn by the queen's warrant. He did not blame anyone for it. At the end he wrote the words *the account of Kettamala*, and signed.

The wax was plain black, not the warden's red. He pressed the iron disc into it, a hill and a gate, and held it a breath longer than it needed.

"He bought my death," Devan said. "He bought hers." He did not say whose. "And he loved his wife. All of it was in the same case."

"You said that as if it were a sum."

"It is." He set down the disc. "I don't know how to carry the other thing, so I'm doing the arithmetic."

Neela thought about that. She thought about Chathu, who wept when members died and sold their pages afterward, and how she had spent twenty years unable to see that this was one man and not two. She doubted she could do what Devan had just done, with a pen, for Ittan's widow. She was not sure she would try.

"What if she hates you for it?" she said. "The letter."

"Then she'll have a jar and a roof, and she can hate me with a cough medicine in her hand." He turned the paper to dry. "Ask me the real question, Neela."

"I don't have one."

"You always have one. You ask the small ones so you don't have to answer mine."

It stung because it was true. She let it sting.

"What do you want from the book?" she said. "Not what Rema wants. You."

He took his time. The chain struck the hour, iron on iron, from somewhere below.

"I want the ledger in front of the high court before the monsoon breaks," he said. "Every contract in it. The Asha leaf, the pass-seller's leaves, the dates, the hands. Rema is a start. If she carries the paper to Kodiyur, there's a bench that has to look. I've spent six years being told I had nothing. I want to be the man who laid it down."

"And the rest of the book?"

"What rest?"

She had known it would come to this, and still her tongue felt thick. "The ledger isn't contracts, Devan. It's two kinds of leaf sewn into one cover. The front half is ink. Ordinary ink, no magic in it, in Resin House cipher. Who paid, who was sent. You couldn't read a line." She laid her left

hand flat on her knee, the three bound nails curled. "The back is pages. Mine was in it. Every odiyan's is. Resin-ink, one true witness's hand, and whoever holds a page and reads it aloud at night has the power of the one who wrote it. It passes with the page."

"I know what a page is."

"You know it as a rule. I know it as a kitchen drawer I was kept in." She breathed. "If you give the court the book, you give it all of it. The court becomes the holder. It holds forty lives, and forty more in the kennels who can't be helped by anything now. And a court that holds a page becomes a master, whatever it swears. It doesn't have to want to. It only has to keep the book."

"The court isn't Chathu."

"No. It's better at it. It has a seal and a law to say why."

He was silent. She watched his jaw work, not in anger. He was looking for the hole in what she'd said, and he was a fair man, so he looked hard and did not find one.

"Then give me the other side," he said. "What happens if I don't take it to the court? If you hold it, or I hold it, and no bench ever sees a leaf of it? Asha stays a thing I believe. Ittan is dead with his mouth shut. Whoever bought her death keeps the name." His voice stayed level. "It's my sister, Neela. I want the name of the hand set down in ink. I want to hear it read out. Do you know how long I have waited to be told one true thing about that night?"

"I know."

"Then you know what you're asking me to set down."

She did. It was the worst of it. He needed the book and she feared what the book would become, and the space between them had a person's shape.

"I'm not asking you to set it down," she said. "I'm asking you not to hand the whole thing over for the sake of the half you need."

"That's what the court is for."

"That's what the court *says* it's for." She stood. Her legs were not steady. The nails, she thought, or the hollow place under her ribs that was past her last proper resin and getting worse. "And you can't read the front

half either. Not a leaf. I'll have to read every contract aloud to you, in my own voice, and you'll hear what I was in each one. Ask me the next question. A question for a question. You've earned it."

"What's on yours?"

She had not expected that. "My page?"

"The one that burned. The witness entry went. You told me something stayed."

"A slip." The word came out low. "Sewn behind it. *Intake, sold at six years.* Two lines I couldn't read in the mud. Chathu put his thumb on it and took it." She heard her own voice and did not like it. "My name's on it, or my village. I think. I don't know what I'd do with it if I had it. I'd read it alone, maybe, with the door shut. That's the whole of what I want from that book, Devan, and it's small, and I would not trade it for a bench in Kodiyur."

He had gone very still. Then he rose from the table and stood in front of her and did not touch her.

"I did not know it was that small," he said.

"It's the smallest thing I own. It's why I'm frightened."

*

They settled it standing up, which was how both of them settled things.

"Say it as a bargain," Devan said. "I'll not agree to what I don't understand."

"The contract leaves come loose at the stitching. They're ordinary. They can't cage anyone. You take them to Rema, to the high court, to anyone who'll hear them." She counted on her fingers, as she did. "The pages go back to the people they belong to. By daylight, read aloud in full, to her face."

"By the holder."

"By whoever holds the book. I won't give that part away to the queen."

"Everyone in the room hears the night-shape."

"Everyone in the room becomes her witness." She did not flinch from it. "That's the price of handing back a page. Your own court clerk, if you bring one. Your captain, if you bring him."

He took it in. She watched him do it. "Then there are no clerks in the room. Only the holder and the one whose page it is, and whoever she chooses."

"That's a better rule than mine." It cost her something to say. "Add it."

"And the rest of the book? Anything neither of us thought of?"

"I'd burn it. I'd burn all of the back half, one at a time, by the owner's hand. But some of them have been rogue in the eyes of the crown since before I was born." She spread the good hand. "I can't promise that either. Not yet."

"Contract books to the court," Devan said. "Pages to their owners."

"A first term."

"A first term." He held out his hand and she took it, as she had taken it in the rain, quick and hard. Then he said, in the flat way he had of saying things that cost him, "I don't think you're right about the court."

"I don't think you're right about the dead."

"Then neither of us is wrong." He let go. "I'd rather that than a silence."

It was the oddest compliment she had ever been paid. She took it with both hands.

"There may be more in the contract leaves than you want," she said, careful with it. She thought of a hill fort she had seen blindfolded, and of nothing she could say. "Whatever's written, I'll read it to you the way it's written. It'll be written true."

"I know."

"Do you?"

"No." He looked at the shutter, at the third slat that creaked. "But I won't shut the book because it might hold a thing I can't bear. That's how I lived for six years. I'd like to try the other way."

She said nothing. She could not. The only answer she had was a stair she could not place, a woman she never saw, and a number.

*

At dusk the next day he went to close the shutters, and she stopped him.

"Not tonight."

He turned with his hand on the bar. There was a river pebble in his cheek. She had not noticed it until the words came out round it. He took it out and held it in his palm, and looked as if he had been caught praying.

"You're not—"

"I'm not." She sat on the window ledge with her back to the dark, where the dusk burn had begun faintly in the scars at her throat, and did not turn from it. "There's one smear of Ammu's resin left in the pouch. I spent the other the night of the execution, on the ridge, to see who walked the road. I'm keeping this one."

"For what?"

"For inside the compound." She pulled her bangle higher on her wrist and let the scars show, pale and ridged. "I can't spend it on the road to the groves. And I can't have the ache take me before then. It's coming. My nails split on the stair this morning, and the night the justice came I woke in a sweat that wasn't the rain." She did not say how near. She had counted. "A moon with no proper resin, and I'll be on a floor."

Devan set the pebble on the sill, beside the other one.

"Then what do we do?"

"We?"

"I asked it as a question."

She nearly smiled. "We do the oldest thing a rogue odiyan does." She looked past him at the shutters, and the dark beyond them, and the wood a day's hard ride off, in the rain. "I have to rob Chathu's groves before I can rob Chathu."

He did not ask if she was sure. He said, "Rema will call you to swear."

"I know."

"She's sat on that second case since the road. She'll open it when she's counted the tallies, and you're named in the closing writ whether you

stand there or not." He said it flatly. "If you're gone when she calls, she'll read it as flight."

"Then she'll read it." Neela made herself hold his eyes. "And I'll have missed whatever's in the case. If it names me, I'll hear it second-hand, from you, with no chance to answer. That's the cost. I've counted it."

"And the alternative?"

"Sit in this room while the ache takes my hands, and then I can't swear to anything, or turn, or hold a knife." She held up her wrapped hand. "Resin is the only thing I own that the guild doesn't. I'd have to steal it anyway. Better now, while I can still climb a wall."

"We ride tonight," he said.

"At full dark. The wood is a day's hard ride, so we reach the trees by noon. Nightbark can be tapped at noon, with a knife and a flask. It only burns like fire if you wear it on bare skin. And the book I came to steal is in the same compound as the trees."

"They'll have walls on the groves."

"They'll have hunters." She heard how it sounded. "I know the ridges. I know a drain that isn't a path. I'll go over as a woman and keep the smear for the night."

"And I'll ride with you."

"You have a fort to hold. You have a justice in your chair."

"I have a captain for the fort." He said it without smiling. "And Rema asked for the guild's paper. Muthu can tell her at first light that my wife and I have gone to fetch it. She can hardly call that grief." He paused. "I have a wife who is going to cut a tree the guild owns, and a knife wound of hers will open on me wherever I am. I'd rather be near enough to hand her a cloth."

She looked at him. He looked back, steadily, as a man does who has made a plain statement of fact.

"You're a nuisance," she said.

"Yes."

"I'll need you to stay behind a tree."

"I'll try."

She turned her face to the dusk. The burn in her throat eased, as it did when she did not take the resin. A breath, and it was gone, and she was only a woman on a ledge with the dark going blue behind her.

She took the flask from the sill, the one she had carried out of Kodiyur and drained weeks ago, and thumbed out the cork. It was dry inside, and it smelled of almost nothing at all.

"Then we'd better fill it," she said, and held it out into the last of the light.

## Chapter 7

# Blackbark in the Rain

The knife slipped on the third cut and went into her palm instead of the bark.

Neela did not swear. She counted. One for the sting, two for the heat, three for the bright line that welled across the heel of her right hand and ran down to the wrist. The tree went on dripping black into the flask below it, unbothered.

Thirty paces back, behind the dead stump where she had told him to wait, someone sat down hard in the wet fern.

They had ridden since full dark. The wood road ran under blackbark and wild jackfruit, red mud to the horses' fetlocks, and the rain came in sheets and stopped as if someone had shut a door on it. By the time grey light showed through the canopy she had stopped feeling her feet. By noon they had left the horses tied in a ravine and climbed the ridge above the Resin House groves.

This tree was a stray. The wind had seeded it on the high ground, outside Chathu's fenced rows and his count. Its trunk was black and plated like dried mud. Nightbark can be tapped at noon, and she had known that since she was nine. A tapper's wife had taught her on a slope like this one, closing her hands over Neela's and cutting for her, singing while she did it.

She was humming the tune now without noticing. The words had never come back to her whole, only the first verses and the last, which Ammu had sung her once.

The knife had gone because of the tune. She had been listening for the next note.

A shadow fell across the fern. Devan had crossed the thirty paces without a sound. He took a square of linen from inside his shirt, already folded, and held it out.

She stared at the cloth. Then at his right hand, held a little out from his side, palm up. Along the heel of it ran a thin red line the length of hers. The welt stood up as she watched, hot and weeping at one edge, though it did not open.

"I said behind a tree," she said.

"It was a tree. It was four paces further than the one you meant." He still did not look at his hand. "Take the cloth."

She pressed it into her palm. He closed his own hand around nothing, and for a moment they stood there, two people holding the same wound. She had cut herself a hundred times. She had never had a witness to it.

"Don't wipe the flask rim with that," he said. "Tamarind and pine. It will burn the cut."

"I know." She did not know. A black drop on the edge of her palm was already burning like a spark, and she shook it into the fern with a hiss. "Now I know."

"Does it hurt on you?"

"It hurts on both of us." She nearly smiled. "That's the arrangement."

He looked at his palm at last. "Then it's a good thing I don't need it for anything."

He went back to his stump. She wrapped the linen under her bangle, tied it with her teeth, and finished the cut one-handed, slow and careful. When the flask was full to the neck, it sat so strangely in her left hand that she held it a moment before corking it. Twenty-seven years old, and she had never once held a full flask that was hers.

*

The ridge looked down on the Resin House like a hand on a map.

They lay flat on wet leaf-mould under a bank of fern. Devan watched with his chin on his folded arms, the way he watched the pass from the wall. She gave him the counts without being asked, low, as she would have to Ammu.

"Forty in the yards. Mostly women, and men of every age down to boys. The dust-coloured wraps are first-year. The ones in grey have a mark, a shape and a number." She knew where each shed door opened. "Eight hunters on the walls. Hooked poles, nets, iron rings on chains. Two at the main gate, two at the drain, and four under the wall."

"Under it?"

"The wall tells you where a man is not."

He gave a small grunt. It was the nearest he came to praise.

On the practice ground a girl of perhaps fourteen was being taught to fall. Her teacher folded her wrist into her chest and made her do it again. Two women ran the length of the east wall and back with stones in their cloths, quick and silent.

"Twenty years ago that was me," she said. "I thought it was a school."

Below them a man limped across the yard, big-shouldered, bear-slow, dragging his left leg a half-step behind the right. He stopped at the edge of the pit and everyone nearest him went still. She had not breathed since he came into the open.

"That's him," Devan said.

"Yes."

"He's lame."

"You did that."

"I struck his shoulder."

"He took it in the thigh coming down." She counted his steps. Eleven to the well, a pause, eleven back. The pause was longer than the leg needed. "Or the ground did. I was a cat, and then a woman, and then I was running."

Devan's fingers had gone white on the fern. She felt it as a tightness in her own hand. He was watching Vellan with eyes that were not afraid and that she could not read.

"He carved Ammu a bird once," she said. "He leaves them on the mats of the little ones. I don't know what that makes him."

"A man who kills with his hands full of birds," Devan said. "I won't answer that."

"I didn't ask you anything."

"You were going to. I'd have said it badly."

She turned her face back to the compound. Below the cook-house, behind a shuttered well, stood the oldest roof in the Resin House, long and low and tiled in black. She knew what it covered. Forty-one cages and one empty. A fox. A hare. A civet with a silver anklet.

In her head, she did not draw it for the plan. She looked just long enough to see that no one went in or out, and looked away.

Devan's left hand moved six inches through the fern and lay beside hers, not touching.

*

Dusk came early, under cloud. The yards emptied in a line towards the long table. Smoke rose from the cook-house.

The door on the far side of the main court opened and Chathu came out.

She had not seen him in the daylight in three weeks, and her stomach turned over before her mind caught up. He was smaller than she remembered. Soft grey hair, soft grey coat. He walked with the uneven step of the old break that had never knit. Under his right arm, held close as a man carries a sleeping child, was a book bound in black.

"That's it," Devan said, very low.

"Yes."

"It's smaller than I thought."

"It doesn't have to be." Her voice sounded strange to her. "He doesn't shift it. Forty lives, and he carries it like an accounts ledger he's late with."

Chathu crossed the court. A hunter nodded; he nodded back. He went round the corner, behind the kennel roof, and out of sight.

Neela counted two hundred. At a hundred and eighty he reappeared, unhurried, and both his hands were free.

"The well," she said. "There's a house over it, behind the kennel roof, with shutters. I've never been inside. Nobody goes in but him."

"You're sure."

"I'm sure he came out without it. I'm sure it isn't in his room, because I was in his room at eleven with a grievance, and I looked." She wet her lips. "Hunters at the kennels guard the cages. The well house has no one."

"Because it needs none."

"Because he's the lock." She heard how that sounded. "Or something is."

Her hand rose to the ridged scars under her collar. The faint burn had begun there on its own, as it did at every sundown now.

"I can see it better from the wall," she said.

"You mean from four feet."

"I mean from the ground."

She had said all this to herself on the ride up. She still had to say it to him. She took Ammu's pouch from her waist and held out the last thumb of resin, the one smear she had kept for inside the compound. It was no larger than a cherry stone, and it shone black in the grey.

"The cache is empty, the horses are half a day down. I'm leaving you a cold camp and no fire." She breathed. "I'll keep to the dark."

"I'll take the pebble," said Devan.

He had already put one in his cheek. She had not seen him do it. When he spoke round it the words came soft. "I know the rule. I'll hold it until you're back."

"You don't have to."

"I know." He turned his face to her, in what was left of the light. "Go on."

She smeared the resin. It burned the throat first, then the wrists, the old fierce bite of scorched tamarind. Within a minute the world went wide and soft and full of smells. The last thing she knew as a woman was his hand,

steady, not on her, just near, and his face turned away toward the dark, as she had asked.

*

The night was cold and wet and perfect.

The other one went down the slope without a sound, along the drain, flat and fast under the bitter fern. The wall had a gap at its foot where the water ran. Hunters passed above, hooked poles ticking on the stone, and she lay in the runoff and let them go by.

She could smell everything. Forty bodies at the long table. Sesame oil. Smoke. Under the kennel roof, a bitter, sweet, familiar reek that tightened her flanks: deer and hare and mongoose and a thin musky animal she did not let herself name. Hounds stirred there, close to the cages, and one lifted its head toward the drain. She froze until it lay down again.

The well house stood at the end of a flagged path. Four posts, a roof of old tile, shuttered windows. She put her nose to the sill and it was there, paper and resin-ink, dry and sour, as if the whole building were a single page.

The door was a plank door with an iron hasp, a farm lock as big as her skull, and a bar of teak that dropped into two brackets. A lock needs fingers. A bar needs hands that lift.

She pushed her shoulder against it, once. It shifted a hair and settled with a small knock.

On the far side of the kennel roof, a hunter's head turned.

The other one flattened against the stone and did not breathe. The man stood listening, one hand on his pole. Then he scratched his neck and walked on.

She knew then what she had come to learn. The book was in a house she could reach on four paws and not open. By day, in her own shape, she would be one woman in a yard of forty.

Back up the slope she went, to the man who waited in the fern with a pebble in his mouth.

*

Light came grey and without sun. She lay on the ground with the burn of the turn still in her bones and the shaking hunger tearing at her stomach. Her cloth lay folded at her hand. Devan had put it there and turned his back before she woke. He sat with his shoulders to her, spitting the pebble into his palm.

Beside the cloth was flat bread, dried plantain and a gourd of water. She ate it all. She dressed with her back to him.

They went down by the old tappers' path. Rain came and went in the trees. The horses were where they had left them.

The man stepped out from behind a trunk thirty paces from the ravine.

He was tall and stooped, in a grey wrap gone to mud at the hem, with a hooked pole in his right hand. His face was long and creased, and kind in a way that had not been used much. He was looking straight at her.

Her body knew him before her mind did. She stopped.

Pachan.

The hook came down level with her collarbone. The iron point stopped a thumb's width from her throat. It was daylight and she was a woman, and there was no resin anywhere to help her.

Devan was in front of her before she had finished the thought. He did not draw. His hands were open and a little away from his sides, and he stood with his weight low and his eyes on the iron, not the man.

"Don't," Pachan said. "Please. I'm not going to shout." He said it to Devan, but his eyes had not left her face. "I only want to say it."

"Say what?" Neela said.

"You were ten, and Chathu had you at the long table with your feet not touching the floor. You wouldn't eat. I gave you a sweet out of my sleeve." His throat moved. "That's the only kind thing I ever did in that house. And three weeks ago I held a net in that yard the day he bound you. I held it, and I looked at my boots."

"I saw," she said. "Everyone looked at their boots."

"Yes." The hook trembled. He looked at the man in front of her, at his open hands, at the wet black seam of the ridge behind them. "I should shout."

"You should," she said.

"They'd pay a year of resin."

"They would."

Rain began again, soft, on the leaves. She held very still. The part of her that always counted exits found that every one of them was a door in her own head, and behind each stood a man who could have shut it.

The hook lifted past her face, past her shoulder, until the iron pointed at the sky.

"I gave you a sweet," said Pachan, "and then I held the net. I owe you more than a sweet. I can't pay it. This is what I have."

He stepped off the path into the fern and turned his face away, like a man who has seen nothing and means to say so.

She went past him without looking back. She mounted without feeling her legs, and Devan's hand was on her stirrup a moment, as if to steady a horse that was already still.

*

They rode all day between downpours. She kept the flask inside her shirt against her ribs and felt it there like a second heart.

Near dark she took out Ammu's pouch to tie it to the saddle and opened it out of habit, the way she had every night for weeks. It was light, and loose in her fingers.

She had known it was empty. She had emptied it herself on the ridge. But she had not yet held it empty, in daylight, with nothing left to spend. She turned it inside out and smelled it. Scorched tamarind, faint, and under it the soap-and-sweat smell of a girl who was twenty-five.

Then she folded it flat, as if it might hold something, and put it back in her cloth.

"You'll want to throw that away," Devan said, without turning.

"I'll keep it."

"It's empty."

"I know what it is." She heard the roughness in her own voice. "I'm keeping it anyway."

He nodded once, as a man does when something has been said that does not need his help. The road went red under the horses' feet.

She rode with her mind on a flagged path and a plank door, and a teak bar that wanted hands.

"Say it," she said at last.

"I could go in," Devan said. He had been working it through as long as she had. "Hands at night. I have those."

"You'd have eight hunters under and on the wall, and four of them are where the wall says they're not. You'd have hounds at the kennels that know every boot in that yard, and yours isn't one. Your scent on the flagged path, your boots on the stone." She shook her head. "The other one can reach the door and not open it. You can open it and never reach it."

"Then someone opens it from inside."

"Or we make a way for the hunters to look elsewhere. And someone pays for that." She looked at the road. "Chathu put it where hands and dark can't be in the same body. He didn't need a lock. He needed us to be two people."

Devan was quiet a long time.

"We are two people," he said.

The rain began again. She did not answer. At dusk she would be a woman or an animal, and the book was behind a door that wanted both.

## Chapter 8

# Six Years of Letters

Everything on the board was in its place except one roof, and the only person who knew where it stood would not draw it.

The tack room beside the kalari had two leaks and two buckets. Devan had set the tally board on a trestle between them, and rain ticked through the thatch into tin while Bhaskaran bent over it with a lump of charcoal. Neela sat on an upturned pail with her bandaged right hand in her lap. The left did the work. In four strokes it had made the Resin House wall, crooked as a dog's hind leg.

"North side bows in," she said. "Where the drain runs. Don't straighten it. A man who thinks that wall is straight walks into it at night."

Bhaskaran grunted and did not straighten it.

"Main gate. Two hunters. Drain, two. Four under the wall, here, here, and the two corners." She tapped each place with the charcoal. "Forty in the yards by day, and they're all out of the sheds by first light. Cook-house door is barred from inside once the long table has eaten. The well house." She drew a small square, and a bar across it. "Hands and dark. We haven't solved that."

"We have not," said Devan.

Muthu was on the gate, where Devan had put him that morning. Devan had not asked himself why.

The charcoal came to the black-tiled roof behind the cook-house. It stopped.

She laid it on the trestle. She put her hand flat on her knee, and her thumbnail began to drag along her forefinger, slow, the way it did when someone asked her a question she had decided to count instead of answer.

"Roof," she said. "Long. Behind the well."

"How long?" said Bhaskaran.

"Long."

"My lads said forty-odd cages in a row. They carried water to it, after. Iron, a door at each end."

"Forty-one." Her voice was perfectly level. "Draw it as they told you."

"I'd sooner have it from the one who—"

"Sergeant." Devan did not raise his voice. "Give me the charcoal."

Bhaskaran gave it. Devan drew a roof, long and low, with a door at each end and nothing under it. Then he laid the charcoal on the far side of the trestle, away from her hand.

"A roof is a roof," he said.

Neela looked at the board, not at him. After a moment the thumb stopped. "Thank you."

"For what? I can't draw."

The roof looked like a loaf. But Bhaskaran, who had a wife and four daughters and had learned what to leave alone in a marriage, studied the walls with great attention and asked nothing.

The well house sat in the middle of the board with its bar across it, and no arrow Devan could draw would reach it.

*

At dusk she sat on the window ledge in the warden's chamber with the shutters wide and the flask uncorked in her lap.

"Four people walked out of Kettamala on foot," she said. "A justice's escort. Horses at the lower stable, a cart road a day's ride from the gate, and they took the goat path." She turned the cork in her fingers. "Four of them smelled of old nightbark. One put her hand to her cuff when she saw my wrist."

"I saw the cuff."

"If they went to the coast, they're nothing to me. If they went north, to the wood, they're telling Chathu that the warden's wife is alive and has friends." She said it as a sum. "I want to know which."

"Go as far as the scree."

"As far as I can read." She looked at him. "You'll be bored."

"I've been called worse."

She smeared the resin on her throat and wrists. The burn took her at once, as it always did, and he saw her teeth set. Then she turned her face to the window, as she always had, and he looked at the dark wall and listened to her breath go out of true.

The cat went through the window like water. The third slat creaked behind her.

Devan took the pebble from the sill. It was Kannan's, the white one, which she had pressed into his hand the first pebble night and never asked for back. He set it in his cheek and sat on the edge of the bed with the shutter open and the lamp unlit.

The rule had changed in the Resin House yard. A caging needed two voices now, and one of them was hers. He could have slept with his mouth open in a room full of Rema's guards and nothing would have come of it.

He kept the pebble anyway. Nobody was at his door. Rema's escort was gone, Raiu was dead, and his own men slept. If he spat the stone into his palm, no one in Varanad would know.

The chain struck the hour. He counted it, and at the last stroke his tongue pushed the stone to his teeth. He held it there a moment, then set it back in his cheek.

Near the middle watch a thin heat went down his left shin, a line as fine as a thread drawn through the skin, and stopped. He sat very still. A second one followed, shorter. After that came a long nothing. He could not tell whether the nothing was a good sign. The cistern chain clanked twice more. He held the stone and did not stand, because there was nowhere to stand to that would help her.

*

She came up the ledge at the grey of dawn with her cloth round her shoulders and her knees shaking. The third slat creaked again, like a door in a house that was glad to see her.

Devan spat the pebble into his palm and gave her the dish he had kept warm at the brazier. She ate rice and curd on the floor with her back against the bed, in the fast, ugly way of someone paying the morning bill. He sat on the boards a pace away and said nothing until she had finished.

On her left shin was a long scrape, dark at the edges. His own shin carried its ghost, a thin red line.

"Scree," she said. "I went down it on my side."

"You lost the trail."

"In the rain. Three days of it. On the scree everything runs the same colour: water, stone, a boot, a paw." She wiped her mouth with the back of her wrist. "They went down. That much I had before the rock took it. Toward the lightning boulder and the cart road, not north. I'd have said the coast."

"Would have said."

"Because of the other thing." She put the dish down. "Something large went up the scree in the night. Up, toward the shoulder. Stones turned out of their beds, a long drag through the gravel. It was fresh. The rain hadn't filled it yet."

"Large how?"

"Heavier than I am." She did not look at him. "I followed it a hundred paces and then my nerve went. I'm not proud of it. A cat doesn't follow what it can't put a name to."

He knew the name in his own head. A stair, forty-four steps, four furrows across a boy's chest. He did not say it, and he watched her not say it. Below the window the cistern chain began to clank the hour, and her thumbnail dragged along her forefinger, and neither of them spoke until the last stroke had died.

"Don't ask me what I think," she said.

"I won't."

"You're allowed to."

"I know." He got up and set the cloth round her shoulders again where it had slipped. "I'll have Bhaskaran put a pair on the shoulder."

"He'll ask why."

"I'll tell him something large went up it." He let it be the whole of the answer. "That's true."

Her mouth moved. It was the nearest thing to a smile she had managed since the groves.

*

That evening the hall was loud.

Muthu was the reason. He was halfway down the long table with a leg of fowl in one fist, telling the story of the mule and the cistern wheel, which grew in the telling every year. Gopan had once, in the fever year, been carried a hundred paces by a mule on the chain. Gopan said it was forty. Muthu said it was a hundred and ten, and slapped the board with the flat of his hand, and the whole hall laughed with him, because it was impossible not to. His laugh came out of his chest like a dropped tray.

Devan sat at Rema's right. She had the warden's chair and he had the bench beside it, which he had not minded. Neela sat at his other side with her good hand round a cup. Janu moved up and down behind them with the ladle, scolding two guards for no reason and feeding them anyway.

Rema had said little all evening. She ate carefully, in small bites, and she watched the room the way she had watched the tallies.

When Muthu reached the mule's last moment and the hall broke into laughter again, she put down her spoon and rose. The noise did not stop at once. It thinned, the way noise does when a person of rank stands, and settled into a courteous quiet.

"I have been a guest at Kettamala for some days," said Rema. "I should like to thank one man in this hall, whose duty brought him no honour, and who deserves some."

Muthu's fist was still raised, with the fowl in it. He lowered it.

"Captain Muthu." She turned her cup in her fingers. "Six years of faithful letters to the queen's household. Not one month missed, I'm told. The

household asked me to say so to your face, and I am very glad to." She inclined her head to him, a small and entirely sincere courtesy. "A garrison is fortunate in an officer who writes so well."

Nobody moved.

Devan had known Muthu since Devan was nine and Muthu twelve, in the pit, with sesame oil on their hands. In all that time he had seen the man go quiet exactly when he lied. He waited for the quiet now, and for the other thing that always came after it, the laugh that rode over the silence like a man jumping a fence.

The laugh did not come.

Muthu's mouth was open. His face had gone the colour of tallow. Down the long table Bhaskaran stared into his bowl as if he had lost something in it. Janu's ladle hung over a guard's cup and did not tip. Unni, at the foot, looked from the captain to the warden and back, and understood less than anyone and more than he wanted to.

The cistern chain struck the hour. It was the only sound in the hall.

Six years. Devan did the sum without wanting to. Six years ago Asha had been found on the west stair with Janu holding the lamp. Muthu had begun to write that winter. Muthu had told him the grey-sealed letters went to his mother in Kodiyur, and Devan had believed it, and then he had stopped believing it and had thought *Ittan*, and then *the palace*. There was a sealed packet in the hall strongbox that he had not broken. He had thought he knew what kind of man had written it.

He had guessed the palace. He had not guessed six years of it, or how near those letters sat to the green wax, and the sunbird, and a payment writ dated seven weeks before his wedding.

Under the table's edge a hand closed over his.

He had not known his right fist was clenched on his knee until her palm covered it. It was her left, the nails still bound, and it came across without a glance from her, her face turned politely to the queen's justice. The welt in his palm, the twin of the cut under her bandage, pressed against his own knuckles, and her thumb found the pulse at his wrist. Until the chain's next clank it was the one place on his body where he could

feel her heartbeat. Rema's eyes passed over the gesture and moved on, as one looks away from a bride's hand on a husband's.

He opened his fingers. Nothing cracked.

"Captain Muthu," Devan said, "has stood at my left for as long as I've held this fort."

It was true. It was also all he could find that was.

"So I understand," said Rema, and sat.

The hall started again, falsely, in pieces. A guard coughed and another laughed too loud. Janu's ladle came down at last into the cup it had been hanging over. Muthu sat with his hands flat on the board and his fowl forgotten, and he looked at no one.

*

The hall emptied slowly, the way a hall empties after a death. Devan stayed by the cold hearth with Neela at his shoulder. She said nothing. Her thumb had found her forefinger again, and he understood that she was counting the pillars.

Muthu crossed the floor to him with the walk of a man crossing a ford.

Close up he looked ten years older. Sweat stood at his hairline, though the hall was cool. He glanced once at Neela, and she looked back at him, level and without anger, and he looked away.

"Seventh day tomorrow," said Muthu.

Every seventh day for eight years he had asked it, in the yard, in the passage, once over a corpse at the ford. *Give me a round, Devan. Come on, you great lump.* Every seventh day Devan had said no. It had become their joke, a thing a man says to a friend he is certain will refuse. Devan had never once heard what was under it.

There was no joke in it tonight. Muthu's voice came out thin and steady, like a rope pulled tight.

"Give me a round."

## Chapter 9

# The Seventh Day

Devan said yes in the grey before dawn, standing at the lip of the pit with the red earth cold under his bare feet, and Muthu's face did something he had never seen it do in twenty-three years.

It came apart. Then it put itself back together, badly, and Muthu went down the north steps without a word.

The sesame lamps burned in their niches. Above them on the east wall the paired sentries stood with their faces to the hill, as they always did, and did not turn. Muthu stripped to his mundu and rolled his shoulders. He made no joke about it. That was how Devan knew the round was not for sport.

"No marma," Devan said.

"No marma." Muthu came in low.

Devan let him. Bar one blow in the Resin House yard and two touches with his wife, he had struck at air for eight years, and the habit held him: take the first blow, strike no one first. Muthu's forearm cracked into his ribs, over the old white seam from the ford, and the breath went out of him in a grunt. Somewhere in the hall above, a woman he had left sleeping would be feeling the same blow bloom along her side. He hoped she'd stay asleep.

Then his hands remembered. He turned the next strike off his wrist, stepped inside, and put the heel of his palm into Muthu's shoulder hard enough to move him two paces.

"There he is," Muthu said, and his voice shook. "There's the lump."

"Talk or fight."

"Both. I'm a clever man."

They circled. Muthu feinted at the knee and Devan read it from the hip, the way he had read it at fourteen. His body was a stranger to him and also exactly his own.

"The winter Asha died," Muthu said, and came in. Devan blocked. "A man came up from Kodiyur. Household man. Polite. He had a grey cloak." Another strike, flat to the ribs, and Devan folded round it. "Said the queen grieved. Said she wanted you kept safe. Said the safest way was for someone who loved you to tell the household how you did."

"Keep going."

"I'm going." Muthu swept low, and Devan jumped it and came down, and the earth shuddered. "*To keep the warden safe.* That was the whole of the asking. A letter a month. What you ate. Whether you slept. Who came and went at the gate."

"Whether I sparred."

Muthu's guard dropped for half a breath. "Yes."

Devan hit him. A clean knuckle strike under the arm, no weight behind it, and Muthu staggered and came back wheezing.

"Six years," Devan said.

"Six years. My mother wasn't in it. She's alive, she writes to me on the ninth-day post, that part was a lie, and I'm sorry for it more than the rest." He lunged, got a hand on Devan's wrist and twisted. They went down together in the red dust, Devan on top, his forearm across the captain's collarbone. Muthu looked up at him with his teeth showing, and tears ran sideways into his ears.

"I thought it was the same thing," he said. "The crown and you. I thought if I told them everything, nobody could ever hurt you without it being seen."

Devan did not move his arm. The tell was missing. Muthu's voice had been loud, ragged, whole. Devan had stood in this pit and watched this man lie, and the silence always came first. It was not here. It meant less

than it should. A man who has told one lie for six years has had time to learn the shape of the truth.

"The grey packet," Devan said. "The one you took into Ittan's cell."

Muthu closed his eyes. "A rider brought the slip off post day, a week and more before the sealing. Lathered, from the household. He gave it to me with an order that's stood ever since: if the Keeper is ever held, put it in his hand and nobody else's." He swallowed. "I never thought I'd use it. Then you held him. I read it first, because I'd never carried one I couldn't read. It was a single line. *Say nothing, and your wife is kept.*"

Devan eased his weight off the arm.

"I took it for a mercy." Muthu's chest heaved. "A pardon on terms. His wife's an invalid, Devan. They'd keep her fed and housed so long as he kept quiet. That's a kindness, I thought. I carried it in like one. I didn't know the queen would send a justice with a block. I didn't know." He opened his eyes. "I'd have thrown the packet in the cistern."

"And his wife?"

"I don't know." His mouth worked. "I don't know. Ittan read the slip and gave it back to me. I'd no one to ask what to do with it, so I put it in with my own letter and sealed the lot again in the guardroom, with the grey stick I carry."

Devan sat back on his heels. The pit smelled of sesame oil and earth, and dawn was coming grey over the wall. The cistern chain began to clank the hour, and the sentries above did not turn round.

"Get up," he said.

*

The hall was empty, and Janu's girls had not yet come with the brooms. Devan lifted the cord from his neck, and the strongbox key came with it. The packet lay on top of the rest of the post, grey wax whole, thick as a man's thumb.

He set it on the long table, between the cups left from last night. Muthu stood on his right, close enough that Devan could hear him breathe. Devan did not tell him to step back.

"I had this out of your hand openly," Devan said. "In front of the yard, so you'd think it was routine. I haven't broken it. It's lain in that box since the rains began." He looked at the seal. "Today I read you, with you standing here. That's the only way I know how to do it that isn't a theft."

"Read," Muthu said.

Devan broke the wax with his thumb. Two leaves fell out, and a slip no bigger than his palm.

He took the slip first. It was in a clerk's round hand, black ink on cheap paper, with no name and no seal: *Say nothing, and your wife is kept.* He read it twice, and put it down very carefully.

The other leaves were Muthu's, square and large, in the hand of a man who writes as he talks. Devan read them aloud, because he had decided he would.

It was all there. The rain. The garrison's rice. The warden's appetite, which was *better, my lady, since the wedding.* A line about sealing day: the Keeper's five carts searched under the padippura, the Keeper held in the guardroom, the warden's wife signing the closing writ as household witness. Then the morning of the vow, in Muthu's own words: *The warden's wife spoke before the household at noon. She said she came to this house sold. She named Raiu, and the odd girl they call Ammu who died under the blackbark, and every servant down to the goat-boy. She told me, to my face, to spell her name right.*

Devan stopped. Muthu was looking at the floor.

*I do not know what she is,* the letter went on. *But I saw her bind her hand on the warden's wrist, and he did not flinch. I think she loves him. I think he is happier than I have ever seen him. I ask the household to remember that.*

There was nothing else. No mention of the Resin House, the kennels, the book, or what she was at night. No one called Chathu appeared at all. Every line was what Muthu had told him in the pit, and nothing more.

Devan laid the leaves down on top of the slip.

"I didn't know what she was," Muthu said. "I still don't. I never wrote to any guild. I don't know what a guild would want with me, or with this

house. I told nobody her cart order, either. The one she gave me the night she rode out. She gave it to me alone, in the passage, and I carried it out in my own head and never said it to a living soul." His voice cracked. "Say you believe me."

"I won't answer whether I believe that."

It landed. Devan watched it land. Muthu took it the way a man takes a hit he has been waiting for, standing, with his chin up.

"Fair," Muthu said.

"Give me the post-key."

Muthu had it on a cord at his belt, the small brass key to the gate's post chest, the one thing in the fort that was entirely his. He worked the cord over his head and put it in Devan's palm. His hand shook. "Do you want me gone?"

"No."

"Devan—"

"You're my captain." Devan closed his fingers on the key. "You'll draw the watch at the sixth clank and eat in the hall, and Gopan will see you at the chain as he does every day. Nothing changes that anyone can see. The post goes through my hand." He met the man's eyes. "A captain I know is the queen's is worth more to me than a captain I don't."

Muthu looked at him for a long moment. His mouth opened. What he said, in the end, was "Salt and ash, you're cold."

"Yes," Devan said. "Go and eat."

He listened to the footsteps go. They were uneven, and then they weren't.

*

The tally board went up again at dusk. Devan had sent the others away, so it was only the two of them in the tack room, with the rain ticking into the buckets and the lamp low. Neela sat on the pail with her bandaged hand turned palm up. Across her ribs, under the cloth, a bruise had come up the colour of a plum. He had counted it himself in the lamplight and said

nothing. She had touched his side, in the same place, and said nothing back.

"Muthu," he said.

"I heard in the yard. Everyone did."

"What did they hear?"

"That you sparred." She almost smiled. "That you hit him once and he laughed like a drain. Unni says the whole east wall turned round to look."

"They didn't turn."

"They wanted to."

He sat down on the trestle's edge. The charcoal roof lay on the board in front of him, a long loaf with two doors. He had not meant to ask. He had meant to decide it himself, as he had decided everything for eight years, alone in the dark with a lamp. Yet he was already speaking.

"I've kept a man in office who has sent six years of letters about me to the queen. I've told him I won't say whether I believe him. I don't know how to hold a man like that." He looked at his scarred knuckles. "I've never asked anyone how to hold a man."

She did not move. She went very still, the way she did at the edge of a thing she had been waiting for.

"You're asking me about command," she said.

"I'm asking you."

"I've commanded no one. I've been a number."

"You know the guild from inside. You know how a house leashes a man." He kept his voice flat. "I know it from a class and a letter. Tell me what you'd do."

She thought. Her thinking had a sound, her thumbnail going along the nail, a slow dry rasp. It stopped.

"Chathu never struck a girl who cried," she said. "He left her sweets and let her be fed and gentle until she'd learned to be grateful. It worked for years. It worked because he was always the one who decided what she was worth." She put the bandaged hand on her knee. "So don't hand Muthu a kindness. And don't hand him a cage. Either one, he'd know how to wear."

"Then what?"

"Give him a job he can't fake."

He turned that over. "Say more."

"A thing that's done in front of everyone, where the work is the whole proof. A man can lie in a letter. He can't lie in a gate that's holding or isn't." She looked at the board. "He chose a side without noticing he was choosing, six years ago. Let him choose out loud. Where it costs him, and where you can see him do it."

The rain ticked. Devan took up the charcoal, and for the first time in the whole planning he drew something with confidence: a square with a hill on it, and a gate.

"The raid goes in on the dark of the moon," he said. "I take the ridge party and Bhaskaran's best. Muthu holds Kettamala."

She said nothing for a count of three.

"With Rema inside the walls," he went on. "The queen's justice, sitting in my hall with her tally chest and the gate log. She won't be watching his loyalty. She'll be reading who goes through that gate, and when, in his own hand."

"Rema is the crown's," Neela said. "The crown sealed your death. Why would her log protect you?"

"Because she wrote against the crown." He did not look up from the board. "At the block, in her own hand, she entered her objection to Ittan's execution. Clerk's copy and all. A woman who'll put that on a roll will put a bad gate on one." He drew a bar across the square. "I don't trust her. I trust that she records."

"If he sells you, it's in the log."

"If he sells me, it's in the log, and she reads it before I'm back. He'll know that when he writes the first line. If he holds it, I'll know what he is, and so will he."

"And if it falls?"

"Then we'll both have our answer, and I'll have an hour to learn it." He set down the charcoal. "That's the cost. I'm paying it."

She leaned over the board and put one finger on the little square gate. It left a smudge. "You asked me."

"I did."

"You'll ask again."

"Probably." It came out drier than he meant. "Don't make a habit of being right."

The corner of her mouth moved. Then it went away, and her thumbnail started again along her forefinger, and he knew before she spoke that she was going back to the thing they had both walked round all day.

"The sword," she said.

"I know."

"Vellan said the watcher told him you lay it hilt toward me. A man on the hill who reads scent-posts can't see inside a barred room." Her voice was very low. "You told me what was in the packet. Muthu's letters say you eat better and you smile. They don't say where you lay your sword."

"No."

"He doesn't sleep in your chamber. Never has."

"No." Devan looked at the gate on the board, and the hall behind it, and the long passage to the south range, and the west stair, and every door in the house with a name on it. "Someone has stood where I lay it, Neela. Someone inside these walls who isn't Muthu."

The chain struck the hour. Neither of them counted it.

## Chapter 10

# Every Name in the Barracks

Corporal Kandan said it twice, loud enough for the far table. "He bowed."

Neela stood on the wrong side of the barracks door with a basket of turmeric paste on her hip and her bandaged left hand tucked against it. She did not go in.

"To a woman with a paper," Kandan said. "In his own court. Ittan sat in the guardroom, a man the warden held himself, and the warden stood by while she had the stump scrubbed. Raiu not a month burned, and our lord bows."

"She carried the queen's writ," said a younger voice.

"So did the last one who came for a head. Since when does he have to?" A spoon rang on a bowl. "Since her. Look at him. Eight years he won't lift a fist, and the week she's walking the walls he's in the pit with the captain. She's put something in his cup. Bewitched. There. I've said it, and not one of you will."

Nobody answered. Neela counted the silence the way she counted anything. Fourteen men, by the breathing. One of them chewed very slowly, so he'd have a reason not to look up.

Bewitched. It was nearer the truth than the corporal knew, though no cup had done it. What bound her to the warden was a rope with two ends, and a charm would have been easier to explain. She could not answer that from behind a door. But she could do what she did in every house.

She pushed the door open with her hip and went in.

The barracks smelled of wet wool and lamp smoke. Two rows of pallets, a table down the middle, fourteen faces coming round. She set the basket between the bowls.

"Eravi says heels first," she said. "Who's hiding a blister?"

No hand moved. Then Unni's did, because Unni was twenty and could not lie. He had stood the gate since dawn in wet boots. She sat on the bench, took his foot onto her knee, and worked paste into the raw place with her right thumb. The scab across her palm, three days old from the nightbark tree, pulled at every stroke.

"Your mother still sells salt fish by the lower well?"

He went red to the ears. "Yes, lady."

"Tell her the pepper sacks are dear this year. She should hold her price."

By the time she finished his heel she had two more. By dusk she had the rest of what she'd come for.

She wrote as she went and didn't hide it. A broken roof tile in her sleeve, a stub of chalk. A name, then the village where his mother lived. Vasu, whose mother kept ducks at Kalladi. Sankaran, whose mother had gone back to Neerattu when his father died. Kuttan, who had his mother's mouth and said so, and asked whether Neela would write her a line, since he had no letters.

She wrote it. She put the mother's name at the top, twice, so Kuttan would see it spelled.

She had seen the method once, in a shut room, on a slate gone grey with six years of dust. Asha, nineteen and new, had written every recruit's name and his mother's village. Standing there in the lamplight, Neela had understood it. You stopped a crowd being a crowd by knowing the one thing about each man that was not his rank.

Bhaskaran's lads came first. On the first day they were wary, and by the third they were arguing over which of them she had learned earliest. Vasu showed her the duck-call his mother used at dusk, and half the room tried it. Unni stood up when she came in and then looked as if he wished he hadn't.

Kandan she did not win.

She tried once, plainly, on the second evening. He was cleaning a spear at the end of the table, alone. “Kandan of Mathoor. Your mother is Kalyani, and she’s been lame in the left leg since spring.”

The cloth stopped. “Who gave you that?”

“Unni. And the well women.”

“Unni gave you my mother.” He stood. He was thick through the shoulders and past thirty, with a scar cutting one brow, and he never raised his voice. “You said Raiu’s name in the yard at your vow. The whole house heard you say it like it was yours to say.”

“I was on the stair when he died.”

“I was on the wall.” He tucked the spear under his arm. “A man’s mother is his own, lady. You don’t pick her up off the road and keep her in your sleeve.”

“Then what do you want me to call her?”

“Nothing. Justice Rema still sits in the south range taking statements for her roll.” He said it mildly, the way he said everything. “I’ve one to give her. A bride who walks a barracks learning every man’s house, and a warden who bows the week she does it. The queen’s justice can make of that what she likes. Your name’s on a crown writ already, I hear.”

He went out. Neela stood with the tile in her good hand and his name on it. She knew what a roll was. A roll was how a crown kept a record of who might be hunted.

After a while she did not rub the name out. A man could refuse to be known and still be named. But she did not take it to Devan either. He would move Kandan to the far wall and make him a martyr, and the men who were laughing at the duck-call would stop.

At dusk on the third day she was chalking on the barracks step when she saw someone watching from the yard arch. Devan stood there with Bhaskaran’s report folded in his fist. He looked at the tile for as long as it takes to read forty names. His face did not change. Then he nodded once and went in.

She could read him better than most people. She could not read that.

*

The kitchen was the warmest room in Kettamala, and after supper it belonged to the children and the lame.

Chinna sat on her stool by the door with her bad hip propped on a sack. Kannan lay on his stomach on the floor with the plank between them, the seven hollows worn smooth as spoons. A white goat stood in the doorway, glaring at Neela. Pepper did not approve of her. Pepper did not approve of anyone.

"Wall first," Kannan said, for the third time. "The stone has to hit the wall of the hollow, and then it drops. If it only drops, it doesn't count."

"I heard you."

"You throw like you're stabbing it."

"One good hand, and it's the scabbed one," said Neela. "Be kind."

He wasn't. At the fourth well she was behind by two, and Chinna's wrinkled hand had put a stone in the fifth that sat there like it had been born in it. Chinna ran the plank by an old rule. Rivals' stones could be flicked out. Cheats were rapped across the knuckles with the ladle that lay by her knee, and she had rapped every one of them, including a visiting priest, she said, though no one could say which priest.

Neela leaned over the plank and set her knee against its edge. The plank jumped a finger's width on the third well, and Kannan said "Hey." While his eyes went to the plank she touched Chinna's stone with the nail of her small finger. It left the fifth hollow as if it had thought better of it.

She sat back. Her own stone was already in the sixth.

"Beautiful," Kannan said, with deep injustice. "That one was beautiful."

"Beginner's luck."

"The plank jumped on the third well," said a dry voice from the door, "and Chinna's stone left the fifth by itself."

Everyone turned. Pepper bleated once.

Devan stood in the doorway with rain on his shoulders. He had been to the south range, she thought, and the gate, and a dozen other places that

wanted him. He looked like a man who had lifted too much of the day and put it down badly.

"Stones do that," said Neela.

"Mine don't," said Chinna, with the ladle already in her fist.

"Left knee on the plank. Small finger at the stone." He crossed his arms. "My sister's way. I told you she cheated and I never found how." He looked at her hand, resting on her knee, the nails ragged at the quick. "I found how."

"Perhaps she was good."

"She was very good."

Chinna's ladle came down across the knuckles of Neela's right hand, not hard, and a clean sting ran up to the wrist. "Rule's the rule," Chinna said. "Even for the lady."

Across the room Devan's own right hand twitched against his sleeve. A red welt rose over the old scars on his knuckles, as if the ladle had found him too. He looked down at it. Then he looked at her.

And Devan laughed.

It came out of him as if he had forgotten it was in the house, short and startled at first, and then it kept going. He put the heel of his hand against the doorframe, welt and all. Kannan stared at him with his mouth open. In the doorway Pepper stopped glaring. Since the block, the warden had gone about the fort with a face like a shut gate, and the sound went through the kitchen like the first sun after the rains.

Neela looked at her stinging knuckles and found she was smiling at them, helplessly.

He sat down on the sack by Chinna's stool, still shaking a little, rubbing the welt with his thumb. "Go on," he said to Kannan. "Deal her out again."

"She cheats."

"She does. Somebody should keep score."

Kannan gave Neela a pebble and a narrow look. Chinna put the ladle across her own knee where everyone could see it. Neela threw her stone,

struck the wall of the second hollow, and watched it drop. Devan was watching her hand, not the stone. She did not look up.

"Unni's on both," he said, low, while Kannan was busy with the plank.

She understood him a breath later. Asha's slate and her tile. "I put him first."

"I know," said Devan, and gave her nothing else, which was more than most men could have given.

*

She went up alone. The ladle's sting had turned to a heat across the back of her hand, and the day had a long tail to it. Devan stayed to be beaten by a nine-year-old.

The lower court was dark and wet, with a torch hissing at the arch. The cistern chain clanked the hour. She crossed toward the west stair with her bandage held against her chest, counting the flags, and had reached sixty-one when a voice stopped her.

"You walk round it like I do."

Janu stood ten paces off with a lamp in her hand and a covered dish under her arm. She wasn't looking at Neela. She was looking at the foot of the stair.

"Round what?" said Neela.

Janu didn't answer at first. The lamp shook very slightly, and the flame threw a long shadow of the parrot post across the rail, a forearm tall, the beak worn smooth as a river stone. "The flags are uneven there," Janu said at last, in the voice of a woman who had given the same excuse for six years. "Everyone says so." She shifted the dish. "Mind the wet. You've a hand to think of."

She went away toward the kitchen, her lamp swinging. Neela looked down at her own feet.

She had come across the court in a curve. It lay on the wet stone like a rope someone had dropped: a long bend out from the straight line, a wide arc around the newel.

She had known. That was the trouble. She had known since her first week, and when Devan asked why she took the turn on the eleventh step of a stair she had said *I don't know*, and her thumbnail had dragged along her finger while she said it. It had been a small thing then, a quirk, the sort a person keeps like a pebble in a pocket. She had blamed Raiu afterward, because a dead boy was a reason. But she had walked wide before he died.

Janu did it too. Janu, who had found Asha at the foot of that stair. It was not a quirk if two women walked the same curve.

Her thumbnail began to drag. She made it stop, and she crossed to the stair.

The newel stood at the foot with its shut black eye. She stopped beside it. Up close she smelled wet laterite and old wax, and the pala rail was cold under her palm. She did not mean to learn anything. She meant to put her foot on each step in turn and prove it was only a stair. *One. Two.* The steps were worn into dips by a century of boots. At nine her breath began to go short, and she let it, and counted. *Ten.*

She knew the eleventh. She had known it for weeks: a hollow, dull note, like a struck cup with water in it. She put her heel down on it anyway, on purpose, to hear it. It rang.

Her stomach turned over. That was new, too. A sound she had filed away as nothing had no business doing that.

She went down on one knee, and then on her elbow, to keep the scab off the stone. The stair met the wall there, and a slot ran along the riser, black and narrow. Beyond it, low in the stone, was an iron grate. She had seen it before and taken it for a drain.

She looked at the bolts.

The wall around them was black with age and the laterite had gone soft at the edges, but the bolt heads were clean and sharp, and they still showed the file. No bloom of rust. Only a skin of damp. Not new that spring, but newer than the stair. Someone had pulled out whatever stood here before and put this in, and not long ago.

For what? A drain that had blocked. Any fort had a hundred drains. She looked at the bolts and told herself so again.

She stood, because her knee had begun to shake, and looked up the stair. The steps rose into the dark above the torch, and the rail went with them, and her legs refused. She had never refused a stair in her life. She'd gone up a well shaft with a knife in her teeth.

She went down backward, one step and then another, with her good hand on the rail. At the bottom she turned to cross the court.

Her feet swung wide. She watched them do it, an arm and a half out from the newel, the same long curve Janu made. She hadn't asked them to.

"It's a stair," she said aloud.

The torch hissed. The chain clanked.

Neela turned her back on it and walked round to the east side of the court, to the narrow stair cut into the wall, and took the long way up. The wall-walk, the cold turn under the lamp niche, the long passage round the upper court. She counted it all. Eighty-one steps, against the forty-four she would have taken, and she did not slow on any of them.

At the chamber door she stood with her hand on the latch. The grate had not touched her. The stair had not touched her. She was certain of it.

Yet the last time, it had only been a habit she couldn't explain. Tonight it had a file mark on it.

So why did her knees remember?

## Chapter 11

# Sharp-Edged Silver

Parukutty bled on the queen's silver before she had finished counting it.

She sucked her thumb and laughed, embarrassed, and set the coin back in its row on the long table. Neela, standing at the back of the hall with her bandaged hand against her hip, stopped breathing for the length of a count.

Rema had paid the death-gift early. She had said so in the same level voice she used for everything. "A widow's gift is owed from the day of the death, Parukutty of the lower village. The harvest is only when the crown remembers to pay it." She wrote the receipt herself, since Ittan's clerk sat in the guardroom, and blotted it with the side of her hand. Twelve coins for Raman the spearman, who had died in single file under the shelf. It was more than the salt factor's six and a half measures and his tally fee together.

The coins were new. They lay in the light from the high window as bright as cut fruit. Sprig on one face. A rim milled so keenly that it had opened a woman's thumb. Not a dent among them, no clipped edge, no sweat-dark from a hundred palms.

Neela had seen that edge before. She had crouched above a cold camp in the lower narrows and watched it wink in a scout's satchel.

Devan sat on the bench by the window with his forearms on his knees. He had said nothing since Rema opened the purse. His face gave nothing

away. But his eyes came up once and found Neela's across the hall, and went down again.

"Take it," Rema said to Parukutty, not unkindly. "Pay what you owe before the factor hears you have it."

Parukutty gathered the coins into her mundu with the care of a woman holding eggs. She bowed to the justice, to the warden, and to the room, and went out into the court with her head high.

Neela caught her at the padippura, under the roof, where the rain came off the tiles in a bead curtain.

"Parukutty. How is Minnu's cough?"

"Better, lady. The bark you sent." She tilted her head. "Is something wrong with the silver? The justice said it was good."

"It's good." Neela took a worn panam from her sleeve, dark with years of hands, and held it out. "I've a fancy. Minnu is six, and a child under a bright coin sleeps better, my mother used to say. Let me have one for her pillow and keep this old one instead. You'd get the same weight at the factor's."

It was a poor lie. Parukutty looked at the old coin, then at her, and her mouth twitched.

"You have a funny way of asking for things, lady."

"So I'm told."

The widow picked one bright coin out of her mundu, wiped the blood off it on her wrist, and traded. "For Minnu," she said. "Chandu will say I cheated him. He wanted the best one for his father's shelf."

"Tell him the warden's wife is sorry."

Neela closed her good hand on the sharp rim. It bit her palm, in the same place as the scab, and the scab tore open.

*

The tack room smelled of wet thatch and bowstring wax. Two buckets caught the roof leaks, and the tick of rain on tin kept time with her pulse.

Devan had borrowed the pepper-weigher's brass scale from the granary. He set it on the trestle and laid the scouts' satchel beside it. It had sat in the

strongbox since the narrows. Three bright coins came out of it, as fresh as the day they were struck.

Neela put hers on the table. Four coins now, in a row.

Neither of them spoke. He put one of the satchel coins in the left pan and the widow's coin in the right. The beam shivered and settled. He added a grain of rice to the left. The beam shivered again, and held level.

"Same weight," Neela said.

"To a grain." He lifted both and turned them against the lamp. "Look at the sprig."

She looked. It was a pepper sprig like any other, five leaves on a stem. But the lowest leaf was doubled, a faint second edge ghosting beside it, as if the die had slipped in the striking. She turned the widow's coin over. The same leaf. The same ghost.

"One die," she said.

"One die, and one run. Struck together, I'd say, and not long before the wedding." He put the coins side by side and laid his thumb across them. "The crown paid Raman's widow and the men who killed Raman out of the same box."

"A mint sells its silver to a lot of hands."

"It does."

"A lot of hands could hand it to raiders."

"They could." He did not look up. "Say it. I know you want to."

"I want you to say it." She heard how it sounded. "The thing you're thinking. Who has a mint run that no one counts, and a reason to have two kinds of coin go out?"

Devan swept the four coins into his palm and closed his fist. Neela saw the palm as it went: a thin red welt across the right one, in the exact place her own had opened. It was already beading at one end.

"Your hand," she said.

"I felt it at the gate." He did not open the fist again. "It's where the coin bit you."

"Where it bit you, then."

"Same thing, now." The corner of his mouth moved. Outside, the buckets rang in the dark. "I won't guess it aloud. A guess said in this room is a thing I have to act on. I can't act on it yet. I've a book to fetch first." He put the coins in the satchel one by one, hers last. "Remember the leaf."

"I'll remember the leaf."

She would not forget it if she tried. But he had already pulled the charcoal toward him, and the tile map of the Resin House lay waiting between them, a long square with a well drawn small behind a roof.

"The compound," he said. "You and I, going in."

"You and I are going in two ways." She drew the wall with the side of her thumb. "I go as the other one. Eight hunters on the walls, two at the drain, hounds that know every boot in the yard. They don't know a leopard. They never smell one at the long table. I'll be over the east wall with the dark of the moon on my back, and the hounds will go quiet before I've reached the flagstones."

"And the well house."

"Teak bar and a farm lock. A leopard can't lift a bar." She tapped the charcoal square. "And the book isn't in the house. It's down the shaft."

He stopped. "You know that."

"I know a thing Ammu and I did at eleven." It was easier to say flat. "We dropped a pebble down that well, through a gap in the shutter. I counted. The sound was wrong. Too soon, and too dry. A ledge, a few man-lengths down, cut into the stone, above the water." She breathed. "Chathu wouldn't keep the black book in a cellar a flood could reach. He'd keep it where fire can't and damp can't, and where it's one more place a girl can't climb with a knife."

"Then I climb it."

"You climb it. On a rope, with your hands, while I stand over you and keep eight men from looking down." She moved the charcoal. "I'll open the drain from inside. You come over the wall at the ridge party's signal, and I'll lift the bar with my teeth if I have to. After that you go down, and I stay up."

"And at dawn?"

"At dawn I turn back, and I'm human with no cloth and the hunger on me, and you're sitting on the well curb with the book."

She had said it. It settled on the table like a fifth coin.

"All night," Devan said slowly. "From the ledge to first light. Every page in my hands."

"You and an animal who can't speak or read or carry." She tried a smile. "It's not the plan I'd choose."

"No," he said. "It's the only one that works."

The rain slowed. A bucket overflowed and she rose to turn it.

When she sat again he was not looking at the map. He had the scale's brass chain wound twice round his fingers, and he held it as if he'd forgotten there was anything on the other end.

"I'll ask you something," he said. "If you'll pay a question back."

"A question for a question. It's the dark rule, near enough." She made her hands lie quiet. "You first."

"What would you do, holding it, if you were me?"

"Burn it." It came too fast. "No. Burn the wrong pages and I'd have forty rogues in a night. You'd have to read them aloud by daylight, one at a time, and every one of them would hear their own shape in front of a stranger." She frowned at the chain on his fingers. "That's my answer, and you're asking something else."

"I am." He unwound the chain. "I'm afraid of myself, with that book."

She waited. She had learned that when he was close to a thing, the best course was to be a wall for it to lean on.

"I've kept my hands clean for eight years by never using them," he said. "I told myself that was virtue. It's only what I do instead of choosing. And tomorrow night I'll hold forty lives in my lap, asleep in a yard, and nothing in this world will stop me from reading any page I like but me." His voice did not rise. "There's a name in that book I want badly enough that I don't trust my hands."

She knew whose. She also knew she could not say it, and the knowledge sat in her throat, dry and hard to swallow.

"You'd read a page and cage a man," she said. "Is that it?"

"I'd like to say no." He met her eyes. "I won't say no. I've never lied to you, and I'd rather not start by being brave."

It hurt, how clean it was. She turned her bandaged hand over on her knee and looked at the dirty gauze.

"Then it's my turn," she said.

"You don't have to."

"I know I don't." The rain had almost stopped. "It's what I owe you for the last one. Listen, because I'll only say it once." She counted to three, as she did before a drop. "If I held the book, I wouldn't free anyone first. I'd turn to my own leaf, and I'd take the intake slip Chathu stuffed in his pocket, and I'd read my birth name before I opened a single cage. I want my own name more than I want to be good." She made herself keep going. "I'd like to say I'd free forty before I looked. I've killed for eleven contracts on a promise that I'd get it back. I don't think I'm that woman. I think I'm a woman who'd read hers first."

The tack room had gone very quiet. Somewhere on the wall a sentry stamped and was still.

Devan did not look away, and he did not flinch. He took the answer the way he took a blow in the pit: seeing it, standing, and keeping his feet.

"Then that's what you are," he said. "It isn't wicked to want your name."

"It isn't good."

"No. It isn't *clean*." He almost smiled. "I'd sooner hold a book beside a woman who says that than one who says she's good. The good ones are the ones I don't trust."

"That's an odd thing to tell your wife."

"I'm an odd husband."

She laughed, once, the way she laughed when he surprised her, and was ashamed of how it went through her.

"Then let's bargain like odd people," she said. "Twenty-one of my twenty-seven years I answered to a number. You've had thirty-two years and chosen almost nothing. You've known what I was since our wedding night, and you could have buried me at the pass."

"I meant to," Devan said. "I took a bride the council gave me. I meant to hold her at arm's length for a season."

"And then?"

"And then you counted my stairs." The corner of his mouth moved. "We married twice, Neela. Once for the pepper house's price, and once because I stood in my own court at noon and said it with Janu crying into a ladle. Nobody gave you to me the second time."

"Nobody gave you to me either." She lifted her chin. "So here's my price. You choose it a third time, with a book in your hands and your own name for a thing you want. And I choose it back, with mine."

"Then it's chosen."

He did not touch her. He pushed the scale a finger's width to one side and set the charcoal on the map, and she took it to mean *later*. The roof dripped. The lamp ate the oil it had.

"The rest of the plan," she said at last. "Who's on the ridge, who's at the drain, who's got the rope."

"Bhaskaran's best. I'll write it out." He drew the well house. "And the first rule of a night I'll spend holding the book."

"What's that?"

"That if I start reading a page, for any reason, you stop me."

"With what? I'll be an animal."

"Then you'll have to think of something," Devan said, "that works on a leopard."

*

On the last evening, the sky over Kettamala went the colour of old brass. Rema's tally chest stood shut in the south range. Muthu was at the sixth clank of the chain, with the gate log under his arm and the bearing of a man watched by a hawk. They would ride at first light, and by dusk they would be on the ridge above the Resin House.

Neela sat on the warden's window ledge, where she had crouched a hundred times, and held the flask in her good hand.

It was full. Black and cold and very small, with a cork she had cut herself. It smelled of scorched tamarind and pine sap, and the bitterness found the back of her tongue before she had even lifted it. Tomorrow night she would need every drop, for the ridge, the wall and the hounds.

Not tonight.

Her nails had been warning her for days. Three split to the quick, two more going. A night sweat two nights back that she had hidden by throwing the quilt off her side. The ache was a bill, and it never forgot the date. Each night she went without added a line to the account. Those other nights she had had a quiet week ahead to pay for it. This time she had a wall.

Tomorrow she had to crawl over it with eight men on top, on hands already stiff. If she went to bed human tonight, she'd climb with a fever coming up and fingers that did not close all the way. Wanting him now would be paid for in her body, on the raid.

She turned the flask in her fingers. Then she thought of the sword on the floor with its hilt toward her. Of the dish of rice and curd she had found at dawn, on mornings she'd never told him she would need one. Of his hand on the brass chain. *I'd rather not start by being brave.*

She wanted to.

Below, a spoon rang in the kitchen. Kannan was shouting at the goat. The wall behind her was warm from the afternoon, and the last of the light lay along the sill in a red bar.

She pushed the cork home and set the flask in the pouch, in the fold of her cloth, where she could not reach it without thinking. The sun still stood above the ridge. The burn at dusk was an hour off, and it would find her human.

She would have nothing to hide behind in the morning, and the ache would count it. Fine. Let it count.

She stood. The ache in her nails told her the price exactly, down to the quick. She put her bandaged hand against the shutter, felt the third slat give a little under her palm, and went to find her husband.

He was in the kalari pit, alone, with the rope for the well coiled over one shoulder and a lamp in each niche round the rim. He looked up at her step on the stair. The red line still showed across his right palm.

"Stay with me tonight," she said. "Through dusk, with no pebble in your cheek and no resin on me. All the way to the light." She came down one more step. "And then tell me what you'll let me take out of your hand."

He set the rope down on the earth.

## Chapter 12

# The Bargain in the Dark

Devan dropped the bar across the shutters himself, and the third slat creaked under it, and Neela's nails itched all the way down to the quick.

It was the hour before the burn. Outside, the sky over the pass had gone the colour of old brass. She stood in the middle of the warden's chamber with her bandaged hand against her chest and counted what she could see. The shutters. The stair door, with Devan's back to it. The bed, the sword on the boards with its hilt toward her side, the kindi full, its spout toward the pillow.

On the sill lay two pebbles, the grey one and Kannan's white one. Neither would be used tonight.

"You said all the way to the light," Devan said.

"I did."

"You'll pay for it."

"I'll pay for it in the morning, and on the wall." She flexed her fingers. Two nails had split in the night. "I've looked at the bill. I want this more than I want to be comfortable."

He crossed the room slowly, as he always did when he thought a thing might spook. He stopped a hand's width from her. He was thirty-two, she was twenty-seven, and they had been married twice. Tonight was the last night in this room before the raid, and the first she had asked for with the bill read out to the nail. Neither of them pretended it was a small thing.

"Tell me what you want," he said.

"That's my line."

"Then say it."

"Sit," said Neela.

He sat on the edge of the bed, looking up at her. His quiet had a different weight than the pit-quiet she knew. She unbound the bandage from her left hand because it was in the way and laid it over the bedpost. Then she stood between his knees, took his face in her hands, scab and all, and kissed him.

It was nothing like the nights before. Those had been stolen: from Vellan's count of days, from the new moon, from the grey at the shutters. Tonight she had paid in advance, and there was no clock to run down. His mouth was slow under hers. When she opened it he made a sound low in his chest, and his hands came to her waist and stopped there, flat and waiting.

"Is this all right?" he said against her jaw.

"Yes. Is it for you?"

"Yes." His thumbs moved once over the cloth. "Tell me if it isn't."

"I will. You do the same."

"I always do."

That made her laugh into his neck, and he laughed too, and her wariness went out through it.

She undid his shirt herself. She went over him the way she learned a house: the seam of white at his ribs, puckered and old, the brow scar she could feel with her lips, the long muscles of his back that flinched when she touched a place she had not known was tender. He let her find each of them. When she pushed him back on the quilt he went, and watched her with a steadiness that slowed her hands.

When she had nothing on but the bangle, she stood a moment longer than she needed. He looked at the pale ridged scars at her throat and the layered ones on her wrists, as he had the first time and every time since. He didn't look away, and he didn't look as at a thing to be pitied.

"May I?" He lifted one hand, palm up, and stopped before he touched.

"Yes."

His fingers rested on her throat, on the old burn, as lightly as a man testing whether a bowl is hot. Then his mouth. Heat ran down through her, and she shut her eyes and let it.

She took her time. She straddled him and set the pace, and when it was too fast, he said her name, and she slowed. When it was not enough, she said his, and he moved his hands to her hips and followed where she led.

Then she took both his wrists and pressed them to the quilt above his head, to see what he would do.

He went still at once. Entirely still, like a man who had spent eight years never striking first. His pulse jumped under her thumbs.

"Tell me," she said.

"Stay," Devan said, rough. "Don't let go yet."

So she didn't. His stillness broke by itself, slowly, the way ice takes a weight, and he turned his hands in her grip until his fingers laced through hers. It built in her. When it broke she heard her own voice go high and cracked, and under her Devan said her name like something he'd been carrying uphill, and held on.

Dusk came and went in the middle of it.

It reached her as a pull at the throat, a faint burn in the scars, as if a thread had been tugged. She stiffened on him. His hands tightened.

"Neela."

"It's the dusk." She breathed through it, the way she always did. "It's nothing. There's no resin on me, it will pass."

It passed. Her skin cooled, her shoulders came down, and she was only a woman again, breathing hard into the crook of his neck. On the sill, the two pebbles lay where they were.

"Nothing to hold in my cheek," Devan said into her hair, wondering.

"Nothing to hold in your cheek."

*

Later the lamp had burned low, and the dark rule came back into the room, as it did every night. In the dark you could ask anything. He

answered, or he said *I won't answer that*. She lay on her back with her head on his arm, her bandage still on the bedpost, a sheet across her hips. Her nails ached. She did not mind.

"I want to make a bargain," she said.

"I thought we had one."

"We have a marriage. This is a clause." She turned her face to him. "Tomorrow night you'll hold forty lives. You said it yourself. You're afraid of your own hands."

"I am."

"I'm afraid of mine." She said it plainly, as she'd learned to. "You know what I told you. I'd read my own leaf first. And it isn't only mine I'd go through. Chathu keeps the intake slips with the pages. If I sat beside that book with the lamps low and a quiet yard, I could turn other women's leaves one after another, all night, hunting for mine, and tell myself each one was only a page on the way. Forty women's shapes under my thumb, for a name."

"So."

"So whoever holds it, and begins to read a page at night, for any reason, the other takes it from their hand." She pushed up on her elbow. "No argument. No *wait, I've a good cause*. The reason's always good. The one holding it lets go."

He was quiet. She could see the line of his throat in the last of the lamp.

"There's a hole in it," she said. "Tomorrow night I'm a leopard. I can't take anything from your hand. I haven't hands."

"No."

"So the half that's mine needs teeth." She touched his wrist, the right one, over the pulse. "If you begin a page and I'm there, I close my teeth on this. A hold, not a bite. I'd not break skin, because it would open on me too, and I'd like to have both of us whole to carry that book home. When you feel them, you shut it and set it on the well curb. Away from your hands. You don't say why."

"And you don't make me say it."

"I can't speak. It's the one mercy of the shape." Her mouth twisted. "Cat's teeth on your wrist. Remember them."

"I thought of something like that," he said. "When I said you'd stop me. I didn't think what it cost you to be the one who does."

"I'd rather be stopped by you than by anyone. And I'd rather you took it from me when I asked you to than let me be right."

"What if you're right?"

"Then I can be right in the morning." She held his gaze. "By daylight, aloud, in full, in front of the one whose page it is. That's the rule for the loophole anyway."

"Night's for letting go, then."

"Night's for letting go."

"And if I won't?"

"Then I don't go over that wall tomorrow." She said it before she could soften it. "You'd have a book and no one at the drain, and eight hunters. I'd be sitting on the ridge with my nails coming off, watching you decide. I'll not hold the other end of a wire I can't cut."

He turned his head and kissed the inside of her wrist, over the scars. "Then I'll let go," he said. "I give you my word, and I'll say it twice, so you can hold me to it. If I begin to read a page at night, you take it, or your teeth do. If you begin, I take it. Neither of us says why."

"I give mine," said Neela. "Twice."

She had expected the cost to feel like a loss. Instead it felt like a joint, the place where two timbers meet and take a weight neither could hold alone. She settled her head back on his arm.

The wound-share ran between them like a wire in the dark. Each of them had made the other a witness and a wound. Now each had made the other a lock, too.

*

"Now my question," Devan said.

The lamp had guttered. Somewhere on the wall, the chain clanked once for the middle watch. She had known he would ask. She had told him in

this room, the night before the vow, that there were eleven before the twelfth, and he might have them one at a time, if he asked.

"One of your eleven," he said. "I'll take them one at a time, as you said. Not the worst. I don't want the worst. The first."

She was silent so long he began to say, "You don't have to," and she cut across him.

"I do. It's the rule." She stared at the dark beam over the bed. "And it's mine to give."

She counted three breaths, as she did before a drop.

"I was nineteen. Chathu called it the first proper work. Before that there'd been errands, a lookout's turn at a market gate, a carrying. Never the knife." Her voice had gone flat. She let it. "A man named Raghu. He collected for a port enforcer in Kodiyur, a man who ran the quays behind the pepper warehouses. Raghu went to the houses of the ones who couldn't pay. He had a stick."

Devan said nothing.

"A boatman's son had stood in his way. Eleven years old. He lost the use of his arm. The boatman wrote to someone, and the someone wrote to the Resin House, and Chathu read the leaf out to me across his table with a tin of sesame sweets between us. A small leaf, in cipher. A little hooked mark in the corner, which he said was for the accounts." She swallowed. "I was given a night, an alley, and a number of paces."

"And you did it."

"I did it. With my hands, at the end of a lane behind the fish market. A strike here." She touched the base of her own skull, a thumb's width below. "The old masters call it the door. He fell the way you fall when you're drunk, and I walked away, and nobody ran. Nobody saw. It was very clean. I was sick in a drain two streets away, and then I went back and ate."

"Ate."

"I was hungry. It was the first thing I learned about myself. I'd been told for years I couldn't kill, and then I could, and then I was hungry." She turned her head. "He had a stick, Devan, and a boy with a ruined arm. I've

told myself that for eight years. It's true. It doesn't make my hand any lighter."

She heard him move. His arm came across her, warm and heavy, and stayed. He did not say it was all right. She had braced for that, and was so grateful it hadn't come that her eyes stung.

"A man with a stick, and a boy with his arm," Devan said at last. "I'd have given you that one."

"Would you?"

"I'd have wanted to." He said it carefully, the way he would lay a hand on a hurt horse. "I know I'd want to. That's not the same as having a right to." His thumb moved against her ribs. "Thank you for telling it plain."

"It's the only way I know."

"I know." A pause. "Is there a second?"

Her stomach turned over. There was. It sat a long way down, a door at the end of a passage: a hill fort, a blindfold, a stair she couldn't see, and her own two feet planted at the bottom of it. She didn't know the fort. She had kept it from every telling, even to herself.

He had asked the question lightly. He had already moved on to the next thing as he spoke, she thought, the way a man steps back from a cliff edge he has only just noticed.

"There is," she said. "I can tell it. If you ask."

The dark held. She heard him breathe, in and out, and the small hitch a third of the way along the count.

"I won't ask tonight," Devan said. "After the book."

"Why?"

"Because tomorrow I'll hold a book beside you, and I want to hold it with both hands." He drew her closer. "After. Whatever it is. I'll hear it then."

"All right," said Neela, and the word was nearly steady.

He slept, in time, the way he slept now: one arm across her, the wall at his back, his breath going long and even. The lamp went out. Not a sound came from the passage but the draught by the stair.

She lay awake.

She counted the doors, because it was what she did. Two: the stair door, with the bar he had set himself, and the shutters, barred. Then, because the habit would not let her stop, she counted a third, the one she had no business counting. Beside her, an arm's length off, a man asleep.

Ten more to tell. She turned them over like coins in her pocket, trying to remember the faces. A magistrate with a bad knee. Two sisters in a rich house on the coast. A boy on a river barge, and the man who had paid to have him gone. And a stair, somewhere. A stair with a blindfold on.

She couldn't tell which one he would hate.

Nor which one she would hate herself for, in his eyes. That was a different sum, and a worse one. The chain clanked the hour. Her nails ached in the dark. Beside her Devan breathed, and hitched, and breathed, and she lay with her eyes open and counted them until the shutters began to grey.

## Chapter 13

# The Wood Road

The rain broke at the lower ford, and Devan chose that moment to tell her the odds.

"Three in ten," he said, "if the hounds don't quiet."

Neela kept her eyes on the water. It ran brown and fast over the stones, and Bhaskaran's men were taking their horses across one at a time, calling low to each other. Steam rose off the horses. Behind them the wood road climbed away into wet green dark. It was the first dry hour in three days, and she could not enjoy it.

"Three in ten that I come out," she said.

"That you come out unseen. Alive I put higher." He said it as flatly as a man reading a tally. "I don't like either number."

"I like them less than you do. I'm the one going in."

"Then I'll stop giving you them."

"No." She turned her mare's head. "Keep giving them. I'd rather hear the number than have you hold it back and be kind."

His mouth moved. He swung down and she did the same, and they led the horses to the bank where the men could not hear. Eight men, and she had their names by the first mile. Vasu, whose mother kept ducks at Kalladi. Sankaran. Kuttan, who could not write, and rode closest and grinned each time she looked back, because she had written his mother a line. Bhaskaran led them with his four daughters on his mind and a face like a shut gate.

At the padippura that morning Muthu had held the gate log against his chest and laughed too loudly at nothing. “Mind the wall, lady,” he had said. Then he had gone quiet, the way he did, and said to Devan, “I’ll keep the fort. And the justice in it.” Devan had put a hand on his shoulder and said nothing. Neela had watched Muthu’s hands. They had been steady, and she had not known what to make of that.

Devan took a stick and drew in the mud of the bank. A square for the compound. A line for the east wall. A dot for the well house.

“Say it as a battle,” he said. “Not as a promise.”

She crouched. “Eight hunters on the walls. Two at the drain, four under the wall, two at the gate. Hounds that know every boot in the yard. I go in as the other one. I need the hounds quiet, the drain open and the bar lifted. Nothing else.”

“And if one hunter looks down?”

“Then I’m a beast in the yard, and he has a pole and a net.”

“And a spear.” He tapped the dot. “Here is the part I don’t like. Anything that opens on you opens on me. A spear in your flank is a spear in mine, a hand’s breadth lower, wherever I’m standing. If I’m in that yard with a blade out, and you take a hit, I go down with you. Two bodies for one mistake.”

“Then you don’t go in the yard.”

“No.” He said it like a man setting down something heavy. “I stay on the ridge with the lamp men. Bhaskaran’s shuttered lanterns, his bows. I hold the signal. I come over the wall for the shaft and nothing else, and when the shaft is done I go back out the way I came.” He stopped. “I don’t carry a sword into the one fight that matters.”

“It’s the only way it works.”

“I know it is.” He looked at the stick as if it had insulted him. “I’ve commanded men into walls for five years. I have never once sat above a wall while someone else went over it. I hate it, Neela.”

“I know.”

“I’ll do it.”

She did not say thank you. It would have been a small word for what it cost him, and he would have left the bank to avoid it. She said, "Then wrap your palms for the rope. Twice. A rope burn opens on me."

"I'd thought of that." He drew a short line beside the well. "And a cut on your pads opens on my soles. I'll walk like a man in new boots tomorrow."

"You'll limp. The men will think I beat you."

"They've thought it for weeks."

She laughed, and so did he, and Kuttan across the ford waved as if they had called him. Then the clouds came back over the trees, and the first fat drop struck the map and spoiled the compound.

*

By dusk they were on the ridge.

The wood stopped at a crest of black rock, and the Resin House lay in the valley below, a square of dark with eight small lights along its walls. She had grown up inside that square. From here it looked no bigger than a tray. The wind came up the slope, and in it she smelled scorched tamarind and pine sap, so strongly that her wrists began to ache before the resin touched them.

Devan had put Bhaskaran's men three hundred paces back, at a cairn on the road, with their shuttered lanterns and an order that nobody climbed above the stones. Bhaskaran had asked no questions. He had looked at the warden's wife, then at his own boots, and gone to see to the horses. Neela marked that he looked at his boots. She would remember it later, when she had time to be grateful.

The two of them took a hollow in the rock, where a pit of coals gave out a dull red and no light. Devan laid a flat river stone beside it. Next to the stone he put a folded cloth and a leaf packet that smelled of cold rice and curd.

She watched him do it. "I never asked for the stone."

"No. You came back cold at the pass, and you came back hungry in the yard." He did not look up. "A stone's a small thing."

The last of the light went off the rim of the valley. The burn woke in her throat, as it did whenever the sun was gone, and she took the flask from her pouch and held it a moment.

"Sit where you can see my face," she said.

He sat on the rock across the coals. He had watched her turn more than ten times, and she knew it, and he knew she knew. But he had always lain still with his breath too even and his eyes a crack open. She had been a shadow at a window.

"I'm not asking you to pretend," she said. "Look. All of it."

"I never looked away," Devan said. "I only pretended I was."

"That is the least comforting thing you have ever told me."

"It's true."

"I know. That's why." She pulled the cork. In the yard at the Resin House she had turned because she had no time left and a man's life was in the mud. That had been a leap. This was a door, and she was holding it open on purpose. She had never done that for anyone, and her hands were not entirely steady.

The resin was cold and black, and it smelled of every dusk of her life. She drew it across her throat first, then each wrist, and it bit through the old scars like a hot wire.

"Neela," Devan said quietly.

"Don't help. Just stay."

The burn climbed into her jaw and down her spine, and the pull began, every bone coming untied. She did not look away from him. His face stayed on hers. He did not glance down at what was happening to her body, and he did not look as if he were watching a marvel or a horror. He looked like a man receiving something handed to him.

Her hands left her. The ground came up. The valley floor opened below her like a lit book, with every lamp-wick in the walls and every hound's breath. His smell struck her whole: sweat and wet wool, horse, iron, and underneath it the thing that was only him.

Through all of it his face held, turned toward hers.

"Evening," Devan said, to the other one.

She could not answer. She put her head down and pushed it, once, against his knee.

*

She kept the edges.

It was what the animal did with a strange place, and she let it. Round and round the hollow she went, soft-footed on the wet rock, past the horses' scent, which tasted of meat to her and which she took care to keep downwind of. She marked every cleft where a man could stand. She counted breaths as she went.

Devan had settled his back against the stone, hands loose between his knees.

"I'll talk," he said. "If you like. You said once the worst of the shape is that nobody speaks to you."

She had said it on the second night, in the dark, and had not thought he was listening. She slowed and came round the coals on her next circuit, and he took that for yes.

"Pepper ate the last of the wedding marigolds," he said. "Off the garland, off Kannan's neck. Kannan argued before the whole kitchen that she had been invited."

The other one's ears went flat with something that in a woman would have been a laugh.

"Janu said the goat had better manners than the bridegroom. She was right." His voice stayed low, steady, pitched under the wind. It held the camp like a rope holds a cart. "Asha drew parrots on the cistern wall when she was seven. Janu scrubbed them off. She drew them back. It went on two years. Janu says now that she let the last one stay a month before she scrubbed it, but she's lying."

Round the coals, past the stone, back. Each word fell where she could find it.

"She drew the newel at the west stair with a whole beak. Mended. She said a broken beak insulted the bird." A short pause. "I don't know why I tell you that."

The other one's pelt crawled along her back, and she put it down to the cold and kept walking. It was a wet night. Her nails would have been aching if she had had nails.

He did not ask her anything, and he did not wait for her to answer. When she came round the fourth time his voice slowed. When she came round the fifth, it stopped, and she looked up.

He had put his hand flat against his side, low on the ribs. The old seam, the white one. He was breathing in short, careful counts.

She stopped. Thirty years of rain in the hills had put that damp into him, and a long ride had worked it. He did not say a word about it. He never did.

She crossed the hollow and lay down along his side, spine against his ribs, as heavily as she could. The heat of her went into him.

Devan went still. "May I?" he said, and when she did not move he laid his hand on her shoulder, then buried his fingers in the pelt. His breath shook once and steadied.

They stayed like that. Nothing in the valley below changed. The coals ticked. Her side rose and fell against his, and after a time his ribs eased under her, one hard breath and then a long one. He leaned his head back on the rock.

"It's gone quiet," he said.

She did not move. She had asked a man once to stay with her through dusk, all the way to the light, and he had. The night had its cost. Tomorrow's hunger would take her at dawn, and the ache was still waiting in her nails. She counted what she was spending, and she spent it.

Below them, a hound complained in its sleep. Far off on the wall, a lamp moved and was still.

She got up.

Devan did not try to stop her. He drew his hand out of her fur one finger at a time and set it on his knee. "Two sawing calls," he said. "A count apart, when the drain is open and the bar is up. I move on the second. Not before."

She turned her head and looked at him.

"I'll sit here," he said. "I'll count a thousand, then stand. I'll be at the rope when you call, and not one step ahead of you." His voice did not lift. "I'd follow you down. I want you to know I would."

She could not tell him that she knew. She went to the lip of the hollow instead, where the dark began, and looked back once. He was a shape against the red of the coals with his hands open on his knees. Behind him, three hundred paces off, Bhaskaran's lanterns stayed shuttered.

Then she went down the slope.

The rock gave way to wet bracken and then to thorn, and the wall rose out of the dark with its eight lamps. The wind brought her the compound whole: tamarind scorch, hound, lamp oil, old cooking fat. A trace of musk in it, two days old and heavy. The hounds were quiet. They were quieter than they should have been.

She went on, low and alone, toward the wall, and the lights did not move.

## Chapter 14

# The Shuttered Well

The drain path had been bigger when she was nine.

The other one did not mind. She flattened her ribs to the wet stone and slid, shoulders first, into the culvert behind the midden. The wall's footing had washed out there before she was born. Water ran through it, and so had two girls who were told every day they had no use for dogs. Ammu had gone first, always, humming the fishing song under her breath. Neela had gone second and counted.

She counted now. Eleven body-lengths of cold slime and root. Then the grate at the far end. It was shut with an iron pin on a short chain, and she took the pin in her teeth and drew it out as slowly as a splinter. The grate swung. She was in the yard of the Resin House, and the whole place smelled of her childhood.

Scorched tamarind. Pine sap. Cold cooking fat. Over all of it lay the bear.

The musk was two days old, thick and sour, and it lay on the yard like a hand. It explained the hounds. They were down in their straw by the kitchen wall with their chins flat and their eyes rolled white, and not one lifted its head. They knew exactly who had walked here.

She set the pin on the stone, where Devan would feel it with his boot. She left the grate ajar. The first thing was done.

Eight lamps burned on the wall. She counted them, and the men who walked beneath them. Two hunters at the gate, their backs to her. Two on

the drain side, looking out. Four under the wall. None of them looked in. Nobody had looked in at this yard for twenty years, because everything inside it belonged to Chathu.

She took the flagged path along the kennel roof, hugging the shadow of the eaves.

The wind came through the slats, and she smelled the cages before she saw them. There were forty-two in a row, rank with the sour sweetness of animals that had stopped being afraid. A deer breathed in the first one. A hare. Something that had been a mongoose and now only paced. She did not turn her head. She had told herself on the ridge that she would not.

She turned it for the fourth from the end.

It was the only cage with no breath in it. The door stood shut and the straw lay pressed flat in one long hollow, the length of a woman curled on her side. Scratches ran down the iron at the height of her own shoulder. Forty-one of these cages held someone. This one held the shape of her, three weeks cold, kept for the day she was brought back.

*Nobody swept it,* she thought. *They were saving it.*

She went on, and her stride broke at the third cage from the end.

Sandal smoke, long gone, and under it fish oil, and a girl who had fallen asleep over a slate. A civet lay in the straw with its small masked face on its paws. It lifted its head.

The lamp on the wall caught something at its hind leg, a thin line of silver. An anklet. The bells had been cut off years ago.

The other one stopped. The woman under her fur did not.

*Kirri.* Kirri, who had been the big girl at the long table and taught the little ones their letters, and could not spell tide. Who had sworn to send that anklet home in a fish basket the day she had a boat.

The civet looked at her. It was a long, mild, unfocused look, the look of an animal at a smell it half-remembered. Then the head sank onto the paws again. There was no one in the eyes to sink.

Neela could not speak. She had no hands. She could not put a cloth over the bars or a name in the air. She stood there a count of three, which was all she could spare, and then she did the only thing the shape allowed.

She went close and breathed out through the slats, once, hard, so that Kirri would have her scent on the wind and no stranger's.

*After,* she told her, with nothing at all. *After the book.*

She went on down the path with her ears flat. She did not look back. A hunter looks back.

*

The well house stood at the path's end, four posts and old tile, shuttered. The door was plank. The teak bar lay in its two brackets, and over it the hasp hung on its staple with a farm lock through it, shut.

She could not pick a lock. She had no fingers for it.

But the post that held the staple was older than she was. She had pressed her thumb into that wood at eleven, on a dare, and it had come away damp. She hooked one claw behind the staple and eased it. The wood gave with a small sound like a sigh. The staple, lock and all, came out of the post and hung from the hasp. She lowered it to the stone by its weight and did not let it clank. Then she took the bar's end in her teeth, rolled it from one bracket, and let it down onto her shoulders.

The door opened inward on a smell like a held breath.

Inside was a ring of cold stone. The shaft opened in the middle of it, a black mouth with a curb around it. Over it ran a beam with an iron pulley, and a chain ran over the pulley and down. She put her forepaws on the curb and looked.

Far below, a few man-lengths down, a ledge had been cut into the shaft wall, dry and square, well above the black shine of the water. The chain ran down to it. Someone had lowered a box onto the stone and left the links slack. It was sealed all round, with a padlock the size of a fist. From inside, thin and bitter, came the scent of resin-ink.

The black book.

She was so close that she could have wept, if the shape had allowed it. She could reach the chain with her teeth. She could not haul a box that weighed as much as a child up a wet shaft with only her jaws. And she could not open that padlock with a boulder.

*Paws can't open it.* She had known that on the ridge, and Devan had known it, and the plan had stood on it. She had a part and he had a part, and the box lay between them like a hinge.

She lifted her head over the curb and gave the call.

It came out of her throat like a saw drawn once through green wood, rasping and low. She counted to the length of a held breath. She gave it again.

Two. A count apart. The drain is open and the bar is up.

*Come.*

She went to the door to watch the yard, and light swung round the corner of the kennel roof.

A hunter, thin, with a lantern on a hooked pole. He walked the path the way a man walks a round he has walked a thousand times, looking at his feet. He was ten paces off. The light came across the flags toward her in a slow yellow arc.

"Hup," he said, to nobody, and then, "What's—"

She went at him low.

She had no time to be afraid for him. She put her shoulder into his knees and her weight behind it, and he went down backwards with a grunt, and the pole swung. The hook caught her along the ribs. It was a short, flat, burning blow, and it opened her skin in a hot wet line under the fur.

The lantern hit the flags and rolled. She had half a breath to know what that blow would mean. Somewhere over the wall a man in wrapped gloves had just felt the hook land on his own side, with no enemy in reach. She hoped he would not stop.

She drove a forepaw onto the hunter's chest. His head cracked on the stone. His mouth opened, and she took her paw off his throat at once, because she would not be the thing that killed him over a lamp.

He breathed. She smelled it: sour breath, a boy's sweat, no blood but a little. Out cold. She had not killed him, and she was grateful, in the sharp quick way she was grateful for any door that did not need to be shut behind her.

The lantern had rolled against the kennel wall. Its flame lay down along the wick and began to lick the stone, and a drift of dry straw beside it caught the edge of the light. She raked a pile of wet midden straw across it with her paw and pressed it flat. The flame hissed, smoked and went out.

Dark. She stood in it, shaking, with her ribs on fire.

Something moved on the low wall above her.

An otter sat there. Sleek, black-wet, whiskered, sitting up on her haunches the way they do, watching. It was Pavi. The white chin gave her away, and the way she held one forepaw curled, the old break that had never set. Pavi, who had come to the House at eight with a fever and a doll. Neela had braided her hair the night before her first turning, because Ammu was with the little ones that night and there was nobody else.

Pavi was twenty-four now, and on the night watch. In shape, she was the same as the dark rows along the wall that Neela had not understood until this instant. Neela had left a House where watch was kept by hunters. Someone had put the shapes on the walls.

*That is a thing to ask later.*

Pavi looked at the hunter on the stones. She looked at the dead lantern. She looked at the leopard.

Neela did not move. If Pavi gave the cry, the whole yard would wake. An otter has a thin high whistle that carries across a pond. She had heard it once, at nine, in the sheds.

Pavi turned her head away.

She turned it slowly, deliberately, toward the outer wall, and kept it there. Her small round back was a wall of its own. She did not look again.

*Thank you,* Neela told her back. It was a stupid, useless thing to say to someone who could not hear it. It was all she had.

She dragged the hunter by his collar into the shadow of the nearest post, where a passing lamp would see a heap of cloth and not a man. Her ribs sang with every pull. She propped the well-house door with her shoulder and stood in it.

The wall was dark above her.

Then, softly, she heard it. A scrape of cloth on laterite. A weight set down on stone, and a breath held and let go. Boots on the flags, going quickly, going quietly, a man who had wrapped his soles in sacking so that the stones would not ring.

Devan came round the kennel roof with a coil on his shoulder and a pry bar under his arm. His palms were wrapped to the wrist. His other hand was pressed hard against his side, and his shirt was dark and wet under his fingers, right over the old white seam.

He did not speak. A voice carries across a yard at night, and the nearest lamp was thirty paces off. His mouth was shut hard around it.

He saw the dark heap at the post. He saw her. His eyes went to her ribs. She drew a breath, and his face tightened with it, as if the breath were his. She let it out, and his shoulders dropped a half-inch with hers. His fingers shifted on the stain.

"Yours?" he said, almost without voice.

She dipped her head once.

"Then it's mine." He crouched, so that his face was level with hers, and put one wrapped palm briefly flat between her ears. It was warm, and he did not linger. "Good," Devan said. "Hold the door."

He went past her into the well house with the rope. She heard him loop it over the beam and test it, the small creak of the pulley and a breath. She heard him go over the curb. The chain clinked.

She stayed in the door and did what she was best at. She counted.

Four lamps she could see. The nearest hunter was thirty paces off, facing away. The hounds had not stirred. Pavi's round back still did not turn. Down in the shaft, the rope groaned, and then the groan changed as it took his full weight.

Seven breaths. The pry bar scraped on iron below her, and she heard him swear without sound.

Then the wind turned.

It came round the corner of the cook-house roof and across the kennels, and with it came the smell she had braced for since the ridge. It was not two days old now. It was fresh and rank and close, and it was walking.

A foot came down on the flags beyond the cook-house corner. Not the rhythm of a bear's stride. A drag, and a step. A drag, and a step, as one hind leg took the weight a half-beat late. New pain, a month old. But the weight behind it she had heard on the long-ago nights when she was nine and had pretended to be asleep.

The bear rounded the corner with its nose high.

He was bigger than the wall's shadow had a right to be. The shaggy black bulk of him blotted the lamp. The pale Y on his chest hung like a scar, and his small eyes were wet and sharp. He stopped. He swung his long muzzle from side to side and drew the wind in, in great wet breaths, and found the lantern smoke, and the hunter, and the otter, and her.

He knew her. She watched him know her. The head came round and settled, and the hind leg shifted, and the breath that came out of him was not a snarl. It was something close to satisfaction.

Behind her, in the shaft, the pry bar rang on iron. The rope creaked and swung. A man at the end of it, with his back to the sky, was working at a box on a ledge, and every cut she took tonight he would feel.

*Hold the door.*

The other one lowered her head and stepped out of the doorway onto the flags. She put her whole body between the bear and the well.

## Chapter 15

# Bear and Lamp

The first claw opened across his back while Devan was reaching for the hinge.

He did not cry out. He had one boot on the ledge and the other braced against the shaft wall. A shuttered lamp hung from a nail beside his head, giving a yellow slit of light on wet stone and the iron box at his feet. The heat started below his left shoulder blade and ran down to the right hip in three lines. A fourth came after, higher, burning like a dropped coal.

*Shallow,* he told himself. *They're shallow.* He had been told they would be.

Above him, through the ring of the well-house floor, came sounds no man makes. A heavy drag across flags. A cough, deep and wet. Claws that scrabbled and found purchase and scrabbled again.

*Three in ten.* He had said the number himself, on a river bank, as if reading a tally.

He put the flat of the pry bar under the hinge plate. Chathu had trusted his lock. It was fist-sized and good, and it hung on the hasp as shut as a jaw. But a man who trusts a lock forgets the hinges. Devan set his boot on the curve of the chain and leaned his whole weight on the bar. The first rivet sheared with a crack he felt in his teeth. The second held. The fourth welt tore wider as he leaned, and he hissed through his nose and leaned harder.

The third rivet went. The lid came up on its ruined hinge like a mouth, and the lock stayed shut on nothing.

A black book lay inside, wrapped in greased cloth. It was thick as his forearm, and it smelled of scorched tamarind. He lifted it out in both hands. His thumbs found the edge of the cloth, and he stopped them there.

He had sworn twice, in the warden's chamber with a lamp between them. If he began to read a page at night, she would close her teeth on his wrist, and he would shut the book without asking why. He had made the oath before he held the thing. It was a different oath now that it was heavy in his hands.

He did not open it. He pushed it inside his shirt, against the old seam, and cinched his belt over it.

Then he took the rope and climbed.

Each pull opened something. He counted hand-lengths as she would have counted them. Nine. Ten. The welts on his back stretched and tore a little at every reach, and the sacking on his boots slid on the wet stone. At eleven his head came above the curb.

*

The well-house door stood open on the yard. It was full of lamplight, swinging.

Neela was not in the doorway. She was on the flags ten paces out, down on her side, with one forepaw lifted and her lips drawn back off her teeth. Her fur was black with wet from the ribs to the haunch.

The bear stood over her.

It had risen onto its hind legs, the bad one cocked and the good one planted. The pale Y on its chest shone in the lantern light. Both forearms were lifted like a mallet raised to a post, and every claw was open.

Devan did not strike first. He had not struck first in eight years.

He crossed the ten paces in four strides and did not strike first now. He waited for the arms to start down.

They started. He swung the pry bar up and across with both hands, and the iron met the bear's shoulder at the joint, with a sound like a mallet on wet timber. Under the iron he felt a ridge, an old healed seam in the

muscle. It was where his own blow had landed a month ago, from one knee, in this same yard.

The bear roared.

It was a huge, cracked, furious noise, and it filled the yard to the wall. The great body came down off its hind legs and swung to face him, one arm hanging wrong. It was the second time in a month Devan had struck the bear. He stood over Neela with the bar low and did not step back.

From the east wall a horn began to blow.

It was a flat, hard hunters' horn, going again and again. Lamps jerked along the wall. Boots came down the stairs. A hound found its voice, and then another.

*If the House wakes, Bhaskaran comes. If it doesn't, he comes at the lamp. Either way he comes.*

He was counting the breaths to that when the east wall bloomed with light.

Six lamps rose over the coping at once, and under each a man came over. Two more climbed from the drain grate, bent double, and straightened with spears. Eight spears, and Bhaskaran with them. They ran in a line across the yard with Bhaskaran at the head, his face a shut gate. Kuttan was grinning, even now.

"Spears out," Bhaskaran said, in his parade voice. "Lamps up. Hold the line. Nobody speaks to the animal."

It was Devan's order, given on the ridge, and Bhaskaran gave it flat as a tally. Eight points of steel came level in a row, and six lamps threw one hard white wash across the flags.

The bear swung its head from the light to the spears and back to the light.

It was a big animal and a hurt one. It dragged the hind leg, and the shoulder hung. It went back one step on the flags, a drag and a step. Then another. A bear knows light and steel at a distance. A man inside it knows more. He had hunted in the dark a long time, and he had never once been seen.

It backed toward the cook-house with its head low, and the light followed it.

*

Someone stood on the cook-house step, holding a small lamp.

He was old and soft, in a sleeping robe with a shawl over his shoulders, and his left foot was set a little crooked on the stone. Devan had seen him once before, at dusk in this yard, reading a page aloud while it burned to nothing in his hands. He knew him now by the same stillness, and by the soft way he held the light, the way one holds a candle in a sickroom. That evening the old man had not shouted. He had only looked down at the ash like a clerk finding a loss in his books. Hunters were coming in at his back, with poles and nets and iron rings on chains.

Chathu looked at the bear, and the spears, and the leopard bleeding on the flags. Then he looked at Devan's belt.

The book was a hard square under Devan's shirt. He had not drawn it. Chathu had seen the outline.

Devan took it out.

He did it without a plan. Between eight spears and a bear, there was no room for one. He drew the black bundle from his shirt and held it up in the lamplight in both hands.

"Call them off," he said.

The hunters stopped. Their poles dipped, and they looked at their master.

Chathu did not look at the poles. He did not look at the spears. His gaze went past all of it to the dark corners of the yard, where something was gathering.

"That's eleven years of feeding, warden," he said, in a soft, patient voice. "Every grain. Put it down, and I'll write the rest off."

"Your terms are late," Devan said.

Chathu's mouth moved as if he were adding. Then, quite simply, he turned on his bad foot.

"Vellan," he said. "The wood. Now."

He went. He went across the back of the cook-house at a rolling, scuttling run, faster than a man of sixty-one with a broken foot had any right to. The bear went after him in its drag and step, and the hunters broke and ran with them, bearing a stunned man between two of them like a sack. The dark under the trees took them, and the lamps lit only empty ground.

"Sir?" Bhaskaran said. "Pursue?"

"No."

Devan stood with the book in his hands and understood what he had just done.

He had known the rule since the border school. He had known it as a line in a book. *A page is a life. Whoever holds it is a master, whether he wants to be or not.* Chathu had known it too. Chathu had looked at the book in a stranger's hands and seen at once what his house would do next. He had run, and he had been right to.

The yard was not empty.

*

They slid out of the sheds and from behind the kennel roof, from under the wall and the drain. They came as low shapes at the edge of the light, and they did not hurry.

He did not count them aloud. Forty, near enough. There was a long-legged grey animal that stood like a heron's shadow, and a small lean one that was all eyes. There was a dark otter with a white chin and a forepaw held curled to her chest. There were others he had no names for, and he would not look for names. The hounds had stopped. The spears had stopped. The only sound was the lamps spitting.

They stopped where the light stopped, in a ragged half-ring, and sat or stood. None of them looked at the spears.

All of them looked at the book.

Forty to eight. He did the sum Chathu had done, and it ended where Chathu's had ended. Each of them was a trained killer in a shape no spear was made for. They had been fed and caged by the man who held that

book, and now the man had gone, and it was held by a stranger with a pry bar and four welts across his back.

Devan did not move his hands. The book weighed more with every breath he held it.

"Lower the spears," he said.

"Sir—"

"Lower them, Bhaskaran. Slow. Point them at the ground."

They lowered, one by one, slowly, like men easing off a sleeping dog's tail. Nothing stirred in the dark. The half-ring stayed where it was.

At his feet Neela got up.

It took her three tries. She stood with her flank against his leg, and he felt her ribs working against his knee. The wet on her fur was not all hers. She leaned on him, and he let her. He could not put a hand to her side with eight men and forty animals watching. He could not wrap a cloth round a hurt he felt as his own. He stood, and she stood, and in the lamp's glare his welts wept into his belt.

"No one speaks to them," he said to the men, quietly. "No one says what they are. You've seen animals tonight, and that is all you saw. If any of you are asked, you were here for a book."

"Yes, sir," said Kuttan, who could not write, and who was not grinning now.

He did not open the book. The back half held resin-ink pages, and he did not know whether the words in it were shapes or cipher. He did not mean to learn. He stood with it shut in both hands while the sky over the cook-house roof went from black to the colour of a bruise.

*Hold it till she turns back. That was the plan.* He had said it on the ridge, with his hands open on his knees. It had sounded like a small thing then.

The grey came slowly. Under the wall, one of the shapes rose and turned. Another followed. Without a sound or a signal they went in a file across the yard, toward the long low sheds by the wood where the resin smell lay thickest, and one by one the dark doors took them. Somebody had taught them long ago to turn back unseen. The training held, even now.

"Spears to the gate," Devan said. "Faces to the gate. All of you."

They turned, stiffly, glad of an order. He heard the boots grind round on the flags.

He took her folded cloth from inside his coat, where it had ridden against his ribs since the ridge. He put his back to the well-house door and held the cloth out behind him at arm's length. He kept his eyes on the line of Bhaskaran's shoulders. He had watched her return once, in daylight, in his arms. Tonight she had the wall of his back between her and the world, and nothing else.

Behind him he heard it. A breath that was not an animal's, long and shuddering. A woman's cough. The cloth slid from his fingers.

"Thank you," Neela said, hoarsely. She did not say it loudly.

"Don't," Devan said. "Eat."

He found the leaf packet in his sleeve, cold rice and curd, and passed it back without turning. After a moment he heard her sit down on the curb of the well, and heard her hands shake on the leaf. He kept his face to the gate.

*

They filed from the sheds at first light, dressed.

They wore grey work wraps, with wet hair, shaking with the hollow hunger of the morning after, as she was shaking. They came one at a time, then in twos, and stood in the pale yard in rows no one had ordered. There were men and women, tall and short, and one young woman at the front who held her right hand curled against her chest. A white scar ran across her chin.

Nobody spoke. They looked at Devan's hands.

He had been the warden of Kettamala for five years, and he knew what it was to stand in front of people who waited for an order. This was different. At the fort they waited because he had earned it, or been born to it, or because an office gave it. These forty had waited all their lives on a book. Now they stood in the cold, hungry, with the day opening behind them, and every face was turned to the thing in his hands.

*Whoever holds it is a master.* He felt it, plainly, as a kind of lean in the yard. If he spoke now, they would do what he said. He had never wanted anything less.

Neela had come to stand beside him. She was in her day cloth, hair stuck to her neck, and she held one arm clamped across her ribs. The leaf lay empty in her other hand. She was grey under the brown of her skin. She did not look at the book. She looked at the faces, one at a time, and he knew she was counting them and giving each one a name.

"Pavi," she said, very low. The young woman at the front flinched, and her chin came up.

"Chathu is gone," Devan said.

His voice carried across the yard without trying. He did not raise it.

"This was his. It isn't mine." He turned to her. "I said I would hold it until you turned back. You've turned back."

Neela did not move. "Devan."

"I know what it is."

"If I take it, I'm what he was." She said it so quietly the front rows could not have heard, but they saw her mouth. "Whoever holds it."

"Then you'll hold it where all of them can see you do it." His hands were steady. He was surprised. "And if you ever begin to read one of those pages at night, I'll take it out of your hand and give you no reason. You gave me leave. I'm giving you the same."

Her eyes stayed on his face. Her thumbnail dragged along her forefinger, once, the way it did when she had a count she would not say. Then it stopped. She had been hunted all her life by this book. She had wanted it burned, and she had been right to want that. No one had ever held it out to her.

*Whatever is in it,* he thought, *there is one page I want more than I have wanted anything in eight years.* He did not look down at the cover. He did not ask.

He held the book out to her in both hands, in the open grey light, in front of all of them.

Neela put down the empty leaf. She wiped her palms on her cloth, slowly, once each. Then she took it against her chest. Her arms sagged a little and caught.

It was done. His hands were empty, and lighter than he had known hands could be. His welts burned in the cold, and he had never felt so little like a master.

Forty faces watched her. Not one of them moved.

## Chapter 16

# Lookout: Seventeen

They bowed.

Nobody gave the word. Pavi went first, the young woman with the white scar across her chin. She folded from the waist and made her curled right hand lie flat on her thigh beside the left. The row behind her followed, then the next. The bow ran back across the grey yard like wind through young rice, until Neela was looking at forty partings and no faces.

It was the bow they gave Chathu at the long table. She knew it in her knees. She had given it every night since she was six, until she learned to wait for his back to turn.

The black book lay against her chest. Greased cloth, scorched tamarind. Its corner pressed the claw lines along her flank, and each breath found the place.

*Which am I?*

A sister would bow back. An owner would let them stay down. She stood between the two and could not feel which one her body meant to be.

"Up," she said.

They did not move. Her voice was hoarse from the turning. Perhaps it hadn't carried.

"Up. Please."

They rose together, all forty, in one breath.

That was the answer, and she hated it. No one rises together for *please*. They rose for the weight in her arms.

"Pavi," she said. "Is the cook-house open?"

"Barred from inside, Seventeen. After the table."

The number landed like a hand on a bruise. Neela kept her face still. "It's Neela. You can use that." She looked along the rows. "Open it. Eat what there is. Everyone."

Nobody moved until Pavi did. Then they all went, quietly, the way they had been taught to go.

Devan had not stirred from her shoulder. He stood with his arms at his sides and his shirt dried stiff across the back where the welts had wept. He watched the last of them cross the yard. Then he gave Bhaskaran two low orders about the gate and the wall. When he turned back, his face held nothing but the question.

"Where would he keep what I can't read?"

"His room," she said.

*

She had been called through that door twelve times, once before each contract of her own. Never once for anything good. The lookout night had come with no summons at all, only a hand on her shoulder in the dark and a cloth tied over her eyes.

By daylight it was only a room. Scrubbed boards. A low desk with an abacus on it. A shelf of small, neat account books, one for each year, each spine lettered in the fine hand she knew. A tin sat on the end of the shelf with its lid pressed down.

She did not look at the tin twice.

Devan took the stool, stood up from it again, and sat on the boards with his back to the wall. He did it without a word. She had seen him sleep that way and had not asked.

Rain started on the tiles, a few fat drops and then a steady drumming.

She laid the book on the desk and turned it so the back half, the resin-ink pages, faced the wall. She did not open it. Then she unwrapped the front. The contract leaves came loose from their stitching in her hands, as

she had known they would. Plain ink, in hooks and half-moons like bird tracks in wet sand.

"Daylight," she said. "Aloud. In front of you. Every word, in order, and nothing I skip without saying so."

"In order," said Devan.

She had learned this cipher at the long table, before she had a name to write in it. She found the first leaf. It was an index, in Chathu's hand, the kind a man makes when he cannot bear a thing he owns to be mislaid. Year, place, leaf. She read it aloud as it came, flat, one line after the next, and Devan listened with his head against the wall.

The first heading was *Released.*

"I'll start there," she said. "It's first in the index, and it's mine to check. Ten breaths. Then I'm yours."

He nodded once.

The leaf was short. Twelve names in a column, each with a date, and beside each a tick and the word *released* in Chathu's best script. She read them to him. Her voice stayed steady until the ninth.

"Kirri. Twelfth contract closed two years back. Released."

In the margin beside it, in a smaller hand, ran two words. *Kennel, nine.*

She stopped.

That numeral was familiar. In the dark, on the third cage from the end, she had looked at the civet's face and nothing else. But there had been a tag wired to the bars, with a figure painted on it in white. A nine. She had seen it and not read it.

"Every name has a number," she said. "Beside it. The kennel doors are numbered. I saw Kirri's last night. It's nine." She went down the column with her finger. Twelve names, twelve numbers. "Released means a door. All of them. Twelve."

Devan said nothing for a long moment. Then he said, "Twelve is the number that earns it."

"Yes."

"And they let them out into cages."

"They let them out of the contract," she said. "It's very tidy."

His jaw moved. That was all. Under her ribs a cold place she had been keeping shut for weeks gave way, and she let it. Ammu had asked after Kirri for years. She had written four times and been told Kirri was where she wished to be.

She turned the leaf over.

Below the twelve, set apart by a ruled line, stood one more name and a tally. *Thirty. Thirty-six contracts.* No tick. No *released.* Every few lines the tally had stepped up by one, and nothing was ever written beside it.

"That's Vellan's number," she said. "Thirty. He earned it three times over. He's never been let out. He's still useful." She heard how that sounded and did not soften it. "His contracts run on for leaves and leaves, after this. I'm going to turn past them. I will read them if you ask. Not now."

"Not now," Devan said. He was looking at the name, not her.

She turned past them. They made a thick wad of paper, a man's whole working life. She did not read a line, and she felt every leaf go by under her thumb.

After them the stitching changed. A separate quire, sewn tight, headed with the hooked mark Chathu put in a corner for the accounts. *The Keeper's.* She said so aloud. Then she said, "Tell me the year. Tell me the season."

"Six years back," Devan said. "The cold month."

"Then it's here." Her mouth was dry. "Before I read it, I'll tell you how. I'll cover everything below the line I'm on, with my hand, and slide it down as I go. I won't read ahead. If I read ahead I could change it. This way I can't."

"All right," said Devan.

He did not say *I trust you.* He watched her hand.

Her left palm lay flat over the leaf, uncovering the first line. Rain came harder on the tiles. She began.

"The cold month, six years gone."

She slid her hand down.

"Kettamala, the warden's daughter, the west stair."

She heard him go still. It was not a movement. It was the stopping of one.

"My father was warden then," Devan said, to no one.

"Buyer, the Keeper."

Her hand slid.

"Hand, Thirty."

A long breath, from him or from her. She could not tell. She slid her hand one more line.

The numeral stood there in the plain cipher, as ordinary as her own hand. She knew it the way she knew the scars on her wrists. Her mouth had said it for twenty-one years before she was told to stop.

"Lookout," she read. "Seventeen."

The rain went on. She did not move her hand.

One line was left under it, and she had promised every word. She slid her palm down and read it, in a voice that did not belong to her.

"Closed. Paid in full."

*

Nobody spoke.

She had read it. Every word, in order, with her own hand covering the next. There was nothing to take back and nothing to soften. The honesty she had sworn to was a clean floor, and it held, and she stood on it with her hand flat on the leaf.

"Seventeen," Devan said.

"Yes."

"You."

"Yes."

He did not stand. He sat against the wall with his hands loose on his knees, and she could not read his face at all. It had gone as still as it did in the kalari when a drill ended.

"Thirty is Vellan," he said.

"Yes."

"Say what you did."

She said it plainly, because he had asked it plainly. "I was brought in blindfolded. They took it off at the foot of a stair. Carved post, a bird. I had a shuttered lamp. I was to open it twice if anyone came into the court below." She counted the next part in her head and said it anyway. "No one came. I didn't go up. I heard it. I counted to three hundred and ten. Then I was blindfolded again and walked out the way I came in. They never told me the name of the fort. They never told me the name of the girl."

"Asha," he said.

"I know that now."

She stopped. There was nothing else that was true.

*I would have told you,* she wanted to say. It was true, and it was useless, and it sounded like every excuse ever made by a person who had stood at the foot of something. She said it anyway.

"I would have told you. If I had known which fort."

"I know," Devan said. He said it evenly, the way he gave facts. It was not forgiveness, and it was not the opposite. It was only a thing he knew.

She could not look at him. She looked at the leaf instead. The rereading had begun in her whether she wished it or not, the way a wall will show the damp through new plaster.

The parrot newel, smooth as a river stone under her palm the morning Rema came. The eleventh step that rang hollow under her boot and made her stop and breathe. Her long way round, eighty-one steps by the east stair, so that her feet would not pass that post. Janu, keeping ten paces from the foot of the stair without knowing she did it. And herself, a bride on her second day, walking wide of the bird without stating a reason. She had thought it a nerve in her. It had been memory, only without a name.

She had held a lamp at the foot of his sister's death. On the first night in his house, she had been afraid of the very place.

And he had asked her once, in a lamplit room, why she took the turn on the eleventh step. *I don't know,* she had said. It was true. She had known only how her body walked.

"The shutters," she said, before she could stop. "Everything you did. You closed them for me, and I thought it was —" She shook her head. The words were no use to either of them.

"Leave it," said Devan quietly.

She left it.

The only thing left to her hands was to turn the pages. The Keeper's quire ended. Behind it lay one more, the last in the front half, and it was not sewn like the rest. It was stitched in green thread, tight and even, round all four edges. Over the stitching, pressed into a lump of wax the colour of new leaves, a bird sat with its wings spread.

A sunbird. She knew that bird from a wedding gift and a cut seal in a man's sleeve.

*The queen's.* The hook mark in the corner of the first page was the same hook. She did not need to read a word to know what the Keeper's money had been for, or whose hand was above his.

She slid her thumbnail under the edge of the wax.

"Leave it whole," Devan said.

Her thumb stopped.

"It says who sealed it. If we break it, it says nothing, and anyone can say we wrote what we found." He still sat against the wall. His voice was low and exact. "Rema can break it. The high court can. Not us."

"You don't want to know what's in it?"

"I want to know." His hands went flat on his knees and stayed there. "Leave it whole."

She took her thumb from the wax.

He got up. It cost him; she saw the welts pull across his back under the stiff shirt. He crossed to the desk and took the leaves from her one at a time. He tapped their edges true against the wood, the way he squared the gate roll at a change of watch, and set them down on the black cover with both hands. Then he stood a moment with his palms flat on either side.

"I need to walk," he said.

"Devan."

"Not far." He did not look at her. "I'll be inside the wall."

"It's raining."

"Yes."

His cloak hung on the peg by the door, where he had put it that morning. He went past it. The door opened on grey water coming down in sheets, and he walked out into it with his back straight as a gatepost. She watched the dark spread through the back of his shirt, across the claw lines she had given him.

Following him was out of the question. She had learned that much about him. A man who answers questions with facts and does kind things unmentioned will also ask, once, for the thing he needs, and say no more about it.

She counted his boots across the yard. Eleven steps. Twelve. Then the rain took the sound, and the door stood open on the empty court.

Neela stood in Chathu's room with the book, and the green seal, and the tin on the shelf, and laid her palm flat on the leaf again. Paper. It was only paper. It said, in a clerk's tidy cipher, what she was.

## Chapter 17

# The Broken Beak

The rain made the yard a bad place to be fast, so Devan went slow.

He stood in the middle of the Resin House training ground with the mud sucking at his bare feet. Eight men with spears stood at the gate and kept their faces to it, as he had told them. He raised his right hand to the level of his eyes. He held it there until it stopped trembling, and then he started the first form.

It was the drill he had made for himself at twenty-five, the winter after the ford. Open hand, slow. Palm out, turn, drop. Two fingers to the post and stop a hair short of the wood. Never touch it. A hundred times, until the hand did what it was told and nothing more.

The welts across his back stretched at every reach. Four lines, shoulder to hip, and the fourth burned like a coal. They were hers. She had earned them under a bear, and he wore them in the rain like a borrowed coat.

Palm. Turn. Drop.

The post was grey pala wood, scarred by years of other people's fists. He set his two fingers an inch from the notch below its crown, where a man's ear would be.

He had put them in that notch once. The captain at the lower ford had knelt in the ash of a burned village, with his hands open and his helmet off, and said a word in his own tongue that Devan did not know. Muthu had been holding his own opened arm. There had been a knife-cut already in Devan's ribs, from before the kneeling. Two fingers, one stroke, and the

man had folded like a coat dropped from a peg. Devan was twenty-four. He had not slept properly since.

Last night he had not needed fingers. A pry bar, an old seam in a shoulder, a roar. He had known whose shoulder it was before the iron landed.

That was what he made himself look at, standing in the rain with his hand an inch from the wood. He had not hated the swing. He had waited for the arms to come down so that the blow would be fair, and it had felt like a locked door giving. He knew now he could do it again. Not as a man in a fury. As a man with a tally, who had found the last line.

Palm. Turn. Drop.

His hand shook on the fortieth stroke, and he started the count over.

*If you're reading this, I was right, and it's ugly. Say it anyway. The truth protects whoever finds it.*

The note lay in a carved box under his bed at Kettamala. He had read it so often the creases had gone soft. Asha had written it knowing she might not come back to read it herself. *Say it anyway.*

So he could say it. He could take the Keeper's quire to Rema on the day of the assize, and the leaf of Asha's death, and read it out in the hall with the court at his back. *Hand, Thirty. Lookout, Seventeen.* The court would ask who Seventeen was. The crown already held her name on a closing writ. It would not take a clerk long.

Or he could cut one line from the leaf and say nothing. That was the other road, and it was open and well-lit. He looked at it as he had looked at the notch in the post. He would not take it. He would not lie to Rema, and he would not lie to his wife by keeping quiet, and he could see no way to do neither without breaking something. Both were true. Both pulled.

Palm. Turn. Drop.

The rain came down harder, and his fingers stopped a hair short of the wood. He held them there and breathed.

"You'll take cold."

He did not turn. He had heard her on the step of the long shed, the way she set her left foot down a little short because of the claw lines. He felt it as well, a small echo along his own side.

"I'm wet already," he said.

*

Neela came across the yard with a grey wrap pulled over her head. She stopped at the edge of the drill ground, where the beaten earth gave way to puddles. She was too far to touch and too near to ignore. He had watched her keep that exact distance from a cornered man once, in a lane in Kodiyur, in a story she had told him. She kept it now with him.

"I'm not going to say I'm sorry for the House," she said.

He lowered his hand.

"It isn't mine to give. You'd know it for a cheap coin if I did." Her voice was still rough from the turning. "I won't say sorry for the stair either, not yet. I don't know yet what I owe there. When I do, I'll say it, and it will be the right size."

It was an honest thing to say. He noticed that it was honest, and noticed he could not lean on it. He stood in the mud and let the rain run into his collar.

"What do you need?" she asked.

Not *are you angry.* Not *forgive me.* He had expected one of those, and he had had an answer ready for each. For this one he had nothing.

"Can you look at me?" she said. "I'm only asking. If it's no, say no, and I'll talk to your shoulder."

He had been looking at the post. He turned his head and looked at her, and that was a mistake.

She stood in her wet wrap with her left arm clamped against her flank. Her hair dripped off her chin. Her thumbnail dragged along her forefinger and stopped, and dragged, and stopped. She looked like what she was, a woman who had read her own name aloud as the lookout at his sister's death, and then waited, with her hand on the page, to be sentenced.

He did not know the answer. He knew only that one true answer would be cruel and the other would be a lie.

"I won't answer that," he said.

She took it. He watched it land and watched her not flinch. Nothing in her face closed, and he was glad of it and sorry for it at once.

"All right," she said.

"I'm not leaving," Devan said. He said it quickly, before she could build anything on the silence. "I am not going back to the fort without you. I'm not going to the horses. I'll be in this yard, or the gate, or across the sill of whatever room you sleep in. I need a day. One."

"A day to do what?"

"To not say anything I can't take back."

She was quiet for a time. The rain ticked on the hood of her wrap.

"Have you eaten?" she said.

"No."

"Nor have I. They gave me rice with some kind of tamarind in it. It was too sour." She turned toward the long shed, and then said, still not looking at him, "The master's room has a mat behind the desk. I don't want it. I'll take the floor by the shelves."

"I'll have it moved to the wall. Away from the door."

She did look at him then, a short look, sharp. He had given her the number of doors in the room without being asked. He had guessed it from the way she counted them. She said nothing, and he did not wait for her to.

*

He did small things that day, because he could do those with his hands.

Bhaskaran got his orders first: leave both ends of the passage open, front and rear, and put a man at neither. Devan found a brass pot in the cook-house and filled it with water from the rain barrel, and set it by the mat with the spout toward the left, because she reached with that hand when she woke. He sent a boy to the sheds for the clay pot of salve the otter-girl

Pavi had offered, the green one that smelled of scorched tamarind, and left it on the desk without a word. He did not stay to see her pick it up.

He stood the afternoon watch himself at the gate, with the spearmen, and let the mud take the knees of his breeches.

Forty came past him in ones and twos. They went to the sheds, the kennels, the cook-house. They did not look at him, and he did not look for their names. Once, at the kennel end, a small man came out carrying a bucket of water for the cages. He looked at Devan's bare, shaking hand, nodded as if he understood something, and went on. Devan watched the bucket go and thought: *No one told him to.*

Nobody had asked him anything about the book. They did not ask where it was. He understood then that they did not need to. They knew the room, and the door, and who had gone in.

At the dusk change he walked through the wet to the long passage behind the master's room. He did not go in. He stood where the light from her lamp fell through the door.

Neela was at the desk, in a dry wrap, with the green salve open beside her. Her sleeves were rolled and she was binding her left wrist, as she did when she wanted her hands busy. She had not touched the resin. The flask sat corked on the shelf, next to the tin she had refused to look at. The sun was gone below the wall, and she had not so much as glanced at the window.

It was dusk and she was a woman. She had chosen that, and he understood it was not for his sake. It was a night she wanted to spend as herself.

He reached into his belt pouch and took out the pebble.

It was Kannan's, small and white and cold. Gopan had taught him at sixteen to keep one in his cheek on long cistern watches, so that a man falling asleep could not shape a clean word. He had not needed it for any watch tonight. It was not for the dark. Nothing in the dusk was going to cage her, not with her own name already in his hearing.

It was for his mouth. He was tired and hurt and angrier than he could place. Words were a thing he did badly when they came quickly. Behind

the white stone they came slowly, and a sentence that comes slowly can be stopped before it cuts.

He put it between his teeth and the soft of his cheek and felt it settle.

She looked up.

At once her eyes went to his jaw, then to the lamp, then to the unstoppered window. She had counted his sleeping breath, and she counted this too. He watched her work it out. Her fingers stopped on the wrapping.

"I took no resin," she said.

"Mm."

It came out as nothing, a hum, and he almost laughed. It was a poor laugh and he kept it behind the stone.

Her face went through three things. Her lips parted, and he thought she would say *you don't need it* or *take it out.* Then she looked at his hands, at the knuckles skinned from a drill that had touched nothing, and her mouth closed again.

"All right," Neela said quietly. She went back to the wrapping.

He stood in the doorway until the lamp burned low, and neither of them said another word.

*

He slept across the sill.

Bhaskaran's spare blanket went lengthwise over the threshold of the master's room, from jamb to jamb, and Devan lay on it on his side with his spine against the wall. His sword lay along his front, hilt toward the room. The floor was cold, and the claw lines pulled at every breath. He lay still.

Through the open door he could hear her. She was not asleep. He knew it by the tiny things, a rustle, the soft knock of a nail against wood, the count of her breathing. In the third hour she turned over, and the pot of water clinked against the floor, and she drank. Then she lay still for a long time, and he knew she was watching the ceiling.

He did not speak. The pebble lay against his cheek, and he thought about Asha.

*Say it anyway.*

He would. He had not decided how, or in what order, or to whom first. But there was a thing he had been taught at the border school and had never once doubted, and it was this: a decision made on one page is a decision made in the dark. He had a leaf that said *Lookout, Seventeen.* He knew what she had done in one night, one lamp, three hundred and ten counts. He did not know the other ten times, or the faces, or what she had been told. He would not judge a woman, or a court, or himself, by one leaf.

Rain eased. Somewhere in the yard a hound coughed, and a cistern chain that wasn't there clanked in his head on the hour.

He slept at last, near dawn, and woke to grey light and the creak of a board.

She was sitting up on the mat, with her arms around her knees. She was dressed, and she had been awake a long time. The black book lay on the desk with the leaves squared on top of it, as he had left them.

He took the pebble out of his cheek. His jaw ached. He held it in his palm, and it was warm now.

"Neela."

"I'm here."

"I want the second contract." His voice was rough with the night and came out clean. "And the third."

She did not answer for a moment.

"Not Vellan's," Devan said. "Yours. The next, in the order you took them. Then the fourth, and every one after, to the eleventh. I want all eleven before I decide anything."

"Decide what?"

"I don't know yet." It was the truest thing he had said since the yard. "That's why I want them."

Something went across her face that he could not read, so he let it go. She looked at the book and then at him on the threshold, where he had slept across the one door she could not otherwise count.

"They're not like the first," she said. "The first I told you. I was sick in a drain and ate after. The rest —" She stopped. "I didn't get sick after the rest."

"I know," Devan said.

"You don't."

"No. I want to."

She was quiet. Then she rose, and crossed the room, and stood with one hand on the cover of the black book. He sat up against the jamb, with the blanket round his knees and the pebble in his fist, and watched her draw out the loose leaves one by one.

"Daylight," she said.

"It's nearly daylight."

She turned the first leaf toward the window, where the grey was thinning to white, and drew a breath. He sat very still, and waited to hear what else she had been.

## Chapter 18

# Forty Names

She told him the second contract at first light, with the book open on the desk and her hand covering the line below.

"A magistrate in a river town. Bad knee. He sold verdicts, and somebody who couldn't afford the price wanted him quiet. He took the stair slowly, so I waited on the landing." She slid her palm down. "One strike. He looked surprised. The buyer paid in full."

Devan sat against the jamb with his arms across his knees. He did not nod, and he held her gaze.

"The third."

"Two sisters in a coast house. They owned a share of a boat that someone else wanted. I went in by the cook's door." She read the leaf again, because she had promised every word. "Twelve nights I watched them before I went. The elder one kept bees."

That was the fact she had not meant to say, and it was out. She went on.

She gave him the fourth, a boy on a river barge, and then the buyer, who had paid for the boy and been paid for in turn two years later. She gave him the sixth through the ninth. Some had names. Some had only a trade and a town. Her voice stayed flat, because flat was the only way she knew to carry weight without spilling it. She had once seen a girl carry a full water pot the length of the yard by never looking down.

The rain stopped at midmorning. The tiles dripped. Pavi passed the door with a basket of tapped bark on her hip, the old-broken hand curled round the rim, and Neela lost a line and found it again.

By the eleventh leaf Devan had said four words in four hours. *Go on. And then?* Each time, she had gone on.

She shut the book. The room smelled of wet laterite and the bitter edge of scorched tamarind. She put both hands flat on the cover.

"Now I'll argue it," she said.

"Argue it."

"I was twenty-one." She kept her eyes on the cover. "I was brought blindfolded. I didn't pick the fort or the night. I didn't pick the girl. Chathu chose. He took the money and wrote the leaf. Vellan struck. All I did was hold a lamp and open it twice if anyone came, and no one came." She heard her own voice rise a little and brought it down. "If a lamp-holder is guilty, so is the lamp-maker, and the road, and the stair. I won't carry what was put in my hands in the dark. It isn't mine."

It was a good argument. She had made it to herself on the east stair at night for a week, in the voice of someone she would have believed.

"I know," Devan said.

She waited for the rest. He let the silence sit.

"I know it isn't yours the way the strike was Vellan's," he said. His voice was even, the way he gave facts. "I have read the leaf. You've read it to me twice. You were a child on a stair, and a man had your eyes covered." He turned his hand over on his knee. "She's still dead."

Neela opened her mouth. There was an answer in it, and the answer was the argument again, with the same words in a different order.

She shut her mouth.

He did not press. He rose, slowly, with a hand on the doorframe, and stood a moment with his back stiff under the dried shirt. "I'll be at the gate," he said.

She watched him go. Her hand had tightened on the cover until the edge of the board bit her palm. It had not been an accusation. She could not put that down.

*

The forty were waiting in the yard, as if someone had called a count.

Nobody had. They stood in their rows on the churned mud, hands at their sides, faces turned toward the master's door. They had stood that way when Chathu came out to read the day's work. She walked into the middle of the ground and watched their spines straighten, and she stopped there.

"I'm going to ask your names," she said. "All of you. One at a time. Say what you answer to."

A girl in the front row said, "Twenty-two."

"That's a number. What did you answer to before?"

The girl looked at her. "Before what?"

It went down the rows like that. Most gave a number. A few gave a name, and it was a shed name or a nickname, *Sparrow* or *Long Mani*, the kind one child gives another across a sleeping mat. A thin boy of about fifteen gave her three, one after another, and said, "Whichever you like." Pavi, in the first row, her old-broken hand curled against her hip, said only, "Pavi. Because you braided my hair."

Neela wrote them down. She had no slate, so she took a plank from the carpentry shed and a stub of lamp-black and wrote each name down the board with the number beside it. The letters went crooked. Nobody told her so. Forty heads stayed turned to her the whole time, like a field following the sun.

When she finished, she had thirty-one names that meant anything and nine blanks. She stood a long while over the blanks.

The back half of the book lay open on a mat beside her, with Pavi guarding it. It was the resin-ink pages, in Chathu's careful hand. Each leaf had a slip stitched to its corner, thick paper, a different hand on each. She turned them one by one, careful not to read the entries. She looked only at the slips.

Names. Real ones. A village, a river, a father's trade. *Thulasi, daughter of a salt-boiler, Pazhayangadi. Kumaran, called Kuttu, a ferryman's son.*

The slip behind Twenty-two said a name in four syllables she had never heard anyone speak. It was lovely.

The girl had come up behind her. She said, very quietly, "Does it say mine?"

Neela put her thumb over the slip.

She knew the rule. The slip was fastened to the page, and the page was the leash. To hand the page back, she had to read the entry aloud, by daylight, in the girl's hearing, and anyone standing near would hear what shape the girl took. To burn it was to burn the slip with it, and the name would be ash.

But the name was not the page. It was a few words on thick paper. She could bend and say it into the girl's ear, here, now, and the entry would stay shut under her hand.

She saw that. Then she saw what came after. A girl with a name would want the rest. She would ask which page was hers, and why Neela held it, and she would ask in front of thirty-nine others. Or she would hear *Pazhayangadi* in her own mouth and think of a road, and run for it before the groves were held, past the hunters in the wood. Neela weighed it against a girl's face and chose.

It was a Chathu kind of choice, made for someone else's good while she watched. She made it anyway.

"Yes," she said. "It does."

"What is it?"

"I can't give it to you yet." She heard how thin it sounded. It sounded like a tin of sweets. "When it's safe, I'll hand it to you whole."

The girl searched her face. Then she bowed, a small and perfect dip from the waist, and said, "Yes, Master Seventeen."

"Not —" Neela said, and the girl was already gone.

*

She told Devan her reasons in the gate passage, with the rain-dark wall at her back. She told him fast, as if speed would excuse it.

"Burning a page frees her and marks her rogue. A rogue is hunted by the guild and the crown. Forty rogues in a yard is a hunt with a map." She counted on her fingers. "Handing a page back means reading the entry aloud, so the room hears every shape. I can't do that to forty people in one yard with Chathu's hunters in the wood. They'd hear it. Someone would say a word in a fever or a quarrel, and a girl would be a bear in a kennel by morning."

"Rema is a day's ride," Devan said.

"Rema is a crown officer. She'd take the book to a bench. The bench would take the pages." She was not sure whether she believed it. She believed it enough to say it. "The groves have to be held. Without resin, the ache takes half of them in a month. Without a watch, Vellan walks in at dusk."

"Yes," said Devan. "Those are all true."

"Then I hold the pages. Not for me. Until it's safe."

He studied her for a time. He did not say what he thought.

"If Rema asks who these forty are," she said, "they're the Resin House. I vouch for them, under my own name. A house with a master isn't rogue. The crown can hunt a rogue but not a vouched house."

"A vouched house has a master," Devan said. "The crown will write your name beside forty."

It was a fact, set down flat, the way he set down all of them. She felt it land.

"Then it writes it," she said. "Forty rogues have no name at all. Mine is already on a crown writ. Let it be beside theirs, where I can see what it costs."

"It will cost more than that."

"I know." She held his eyes. "Say it again when it does."

He took that, as he took everything, and set it somewhere she could not see. "Then do it," he said. "I'll hold the gate."

She did it.

It took one morning. She sent six to the groves with spears from the Kettamala men's spare stack, in pairs, with a rule that no pair stood where

the wind carried scent to the wood. She sent four more to the wall. She told the cook-house to feed all forty twice a day, whatever was left of the stores, and the cook-house did. She said the kennels were to be cleaned, the straw burned, every cage opened at the front and scrubbed, and eleven people took buckets and went and did it. Nobody asked how many buckets. Nobody asked why.

She had expected to argue. She had braced her shoulders for it, the way she did at a gate.

It was easy. She stood in the sun with her hands empty, and she could not stop turning it over. She said a sentence, and the yard moved. She had never in her life said a sentence that large.

At noon she said, "Someone should wash Kirri," and two girls went quietly to the third cage from the end, one with a rag and one with a basin and a cake of coarse soap. They talked to the civet in low voices. The civet, pressed against the bars, stayed very still and let them wash her face. The silver anklet with the bells cut off lay dull against one thin paw. Neela watched from the end of the aisle, and her chest hurt, and she let it.

*It is not a cage if the door is open*, she told herself. But the doors were not open. She had written no sentence for that.

*

Devan's horse stood saddled at the gate by the second hour past noon. He had split the Kettamala men, two to go with him, six to stay under Bhaskaran. He told the six their orders, and Bhaskaran took his with a face she could not read and a quick, almost privately bitter nod. Devan did not look at the forty. He looked at her.

"Rema will be at the fort by now, asking where the warden rides," he said. "I'll tell her the truth. Not all of it."

"Tell her what you can."

"I will." He pulled the strap of the girth. His hands were steadier than they had been. "Neela."

"Yes."

He didn't turn from the horse. "Chathu thought the ledger was mercy too."

He said it as he had put the brass pot by her mat, with the spout turned toward her left hand. If he had said it hard, she could have answered hard.

She stood very still. The wind moved the loose end of her wrap.

"I'm not Chathu," she said.

"No."

"I haven't kept a tin of sweets for anyone."

"No," Devan said. He put his foot in the stirrup and rose into the saddle with a small tightening about the mouth, where the welts pulled. He gathered the reins. Then he looked down at her, steady. "I didn't say you were. I said what he thought."

He rode out through the gate at a walk. The two went after him, mud flying behind. She watched until the wood closed over the last of the Kettamala coats.

Under her ribs the claw lines pulled. They would pull for days, and he would feel each pull on his back all the way up the wood road. She had not asked him whether it was a comfort or an insult to be so close.

*I'm not Chathu.* She said it again, inside, and it came out the same and meant a little less.

*

Dusk found her in the master's room, which was not a thing she had decided. The mat was by the wall, as Devan had moved it. The desk held the black book, and the loose contract leaves, and the plank of crooked names propped against the shelf. The tin was still on the end of the shelf. She had not looked at it twice.

She sat with her back to the wall and counted the doors. One. The hearth, if it counted, was two.

The cook-house had sent bread. A bowl of lentils steamed beside it. Somewhere beyond the wall the hounds were settling, and the wind off the groves brought the smell of tapped bark, bitter and sweet. Forty people

slept inside that wall because of what she had said. She turned the thought over like a coin and found no obvious flaw in it.

A knock came at the frame, light, two knuckles.

"Come," she said.

The man who came in was older than anyone she had counted that morning. He was forty-one, he had told her at the names, in a voice with no hurry in it. Thilak. He had been a tapper before he was a member, he said, and a member for twenty-two years. His hands were scarred past the wrists. He carried a brass tray in both of them, the way a man carries something he is afraid to spill, and on it stood a small covered cup.

"Your tea, Master," he said.

He set it on the desk, beside the black book, without looking at the book. Steam rose from under the lid, sharp with ginger and something earthy that she knew from the long table. It was Chathu's blend. She would have known it blind.

She waited for the edge in his voice, a tilt that would let her say *don't*. There was none. He said it as he might have said *good evening*. He believed it, plainly and without effort, and so did the room.

Her mouth was open to correct him. She had the whole sentence ready: *Neela. It's Neela. Please.*

She looked at the cup.

"Thank you, Thilak," she said.

He bowed, small and exact, and went out, and drew the door half shut behind him as the master liked it.

She sat for a while without touching the tea. Then she lifted the lid and drank, and it was hot and sweet and tasted of every night of her childhood. She set the cup down beside the black book, and did not know how long she had been sitting there with her mouth still shaped around her own name.

## Chapter 19

# Assize Weather

Rema asked where the warden had been before he had the mud off his boots.

She sat in his father's chair in the hall with the tally chest at her elbow and a clean leaf under her pen. She was fifty-eight, with iron-grey hair under a plain white cloth. Devan had never seen her hurry, and he had never seen her late.

"Where does a warden ride when he leaves at first light with his wife and comes back four days later without her?"

He stood on the flags with a night and a morning of road in his legs and the welts across his back dragging at his shirt. Janu had pushed a rice ball into his hand in the passage. He had not been able to eat it, and he held it still.

"The Resin House, in the Blackbark Wood. A day's ride. I stayed two nights."

"Why?"

"The guild's ledger was there. I have seen it."

"Seen it." Rema wrote a word. "And it is now where?"

"Where it is safe. My wife holds the House. The contract leaves will come to your hands when they can be carried without losing them."

"Holds it against whom?"

"The men who ran it."

The pen stopped. "Is there anything in that book touching Kettamala?"

It was the question he had walked the whole road to meet. The Keeper's quire lay in a black book in a room he had slept outside. A leaf in it said *Hand, Thirty. Lookout, Seventeen.* Rema's court would ask who Seventeen was, and he had no answer yet that would not hand a crown clerk his wife.

"I won't answer that," he said.

Rema laid the pen down. She did it gently, the way she did everything. A woman who raised her voice would have been easier.

"A court takes that once, as a courtesy," she said. "Twice, as a habit. The third time it writes it down as an answer, and not the answer you would choose. I am not threatening you. I am telling you how the roll reads."

"I understand."

"I hope so. The assize sits at lamp-lighting. I will swear your wife as household witness to the closing writ, as I said I would. She will need to be here."

"She will come."

"When?"

He opened his mouth and found he did not know. He had said *one day* in the rain, and he had meant it as a thing he took for himself. He had not thought what it would cost the people waiting on the road behind him.

"As soon as she can," he said, and it was true, and it was thin, and Rema wrote it down.

*

The refusal came in the yard an hour later, and it was not loud.

He had given the order at the stable door, to the duty corporal, a plain one. A patrol of six to walk the lower narrows to the shelf and back before dark. Somebody had camped on the lip above it, with bows and a bronze mirror, and no one yet knew who waited beyond the cut. The mirror had flashed a count to somebody. He wanted to know who.

Six men came out of the barracks and stopped in the middle of the yard.

Corporal Kandan stood in front of them. He was past thirty, with a scar through one brow, and he had been Raiu's comrade. He had his spear grounded and his cap in his other hand, which was a courtesy, and the courtesy was how Devan knew it was serious.

"The corporal begs the warden's pardon," Kandan said. "The men won't walk the narrows."

Fourteen others had drifted to the barracks door to watch. Someone on the wall had stopped moving. Devan heard the cistern chain clank the hour and let it finish.

"Say why."

"The warden bowed to a green sash while the Keeper's neck was on the block." Kandan's voice did not shake. He had practised it. "The warden rode out at first light with his wife to the house that sent the thing that killed Raiu. We've heard where that house is." He drew a breath. "We'll walk for the fort. We don't know that this is the fort."

It was not an unreasonable thing to think. Devan would have thought it himself. A man who bows and rides off and will not say why is a man to be watched.

He had a hundred ways to answer. He could put the six on the wall in irons for the night and send for Unni's gate watch to hold them. He could say *I order it*, and the order would hold, because he was warden and the roll said so. He could close his hand and take Kandan by the collar, once, in front of everyone, and every man in the yard would walk by sundown.

He knew exactly how it would be done. That was the trouble with eight years of an open hand. It had not forgotten anything.

He opened it, and showed them.

"I bowed to Rema because she held a warrant," he said. "I let the Keeper die because I could not stop it without breaking the pass. I went to the Resin House because the men who killed Raiu keep their books there, and I wanted them in my hand and not theirs. I'll tell you no more than that, and you may hate me for it."

Nobody moved.

"If I'm wrong, the court will say so. It sits tonight, and the corporal's statement is in front of it. Rema has read your words and I have not asked to see them. Until the court says it, walk."

"And if you're not wrong?" Kandan said. "Who tells the next man's mother?"

It landed where it was aimed. Devan took it.

"I do," he said. "Every one. Raman's widow, and the next man's mother, and the one after. Not you."

Kandan's scarred brow twitched. Devan went on, without lifting his voice.

"This is what it costs, and I'll name it. It costs you a cold walk to a place where a man of ours died single file. It costs me your good opinion, and I have little enough that I notice the loss. If I could do it myself I would. I can't be at the narrows and the gate and the court." He lowered his hand to his side. "I could put you in irons. I haven't, and I won't. I've struck no one in this yard in eight years, and I'd sooner keep it so. I would rather you walked because you chose to."

The silence went on. A langur barked once on the cliff and was still.

Kandan looked at the open hand, then at the others. One of the six, young, a boy with a cowlick like Raiu's, shifted his feet.

"Six," said Kandan, to the boy and not to Devan. "Water bags. Lamps for the shelf." He put his cap on. He did not salute, and he did not look at Devan again. But they walked.

Devan stood in the empty yard with his hand still open. It was shaking again, a little. He closed it, and the welts pulled across his back as though someone had drawn a thumbnail down them.

Neela would have said something dry about it. He found he was composing her answer, and stopped.

*

Muthu was in the gate chamber over the padippura with the post chest open beside him. He rose at once, laughing before he was fully upright.

"Warden. You look like a wet mule. I have kept your fort for four days and nobody has died of it, which I count as a triumph. Kandan's six are at the narrows, I take it, because I heard a certain corporal's voice go up."

"They are at the narrows."

"Good. Good man, Kandan. Stubborn. It's the mother." Muthu rubbed his hands. "The chest is as you left it. Nothing went down the pass and nothing came up. Lady Rema asked to read the log and I let her. She read every line, and it took a while."

Devan took the brass post-key from the cord at his own neck. He had worn it since the day he took it from Muthu's belt, with a grey packet broken open on the long table and a captain who had written to Kodiyur every month for six years. He held it out across his palm.

Muthu looked at it.

The laugh was gone. It went all at once, the way a lamp goes when the oil is out. Devan had seen it go in the kalari pit when they were boys, at the moment of a lie, and he had never forgotten what it looked like.

This was not a lie. He had settled that in the weeks since sealing day. The quiet was not Muthu telling a falsehood. It was Muthu holding his breath between two doors.

"The log's yours," Devan said. "So is the chest. I should have given it back sooner."

"You took it for a reason."

"I did. The reason has gone with the day." That was nearly true. He did not say *the reason is a slip you carried in to the Keeper, and told me of only in the pit.* He said instead, "You ran this fort honestly while I was gone. I'm not so sure of many things that I can afford to lose one."

Muthu closed his hand on the key. The knuckles went pale.

"If anything is ever put in your hand that you can't carry," Devan said, "bring it to me first. Before you carry it anywhere."

For a long moment the big man said nothing at all. Below them in the court a mule coughed.

"Aye," Muthu said, very quietly, and that was all.

It was a risk, and Devan counted it. If Muthu wrote tonight, the household would learn within a week that the warden had gone to the Resin House and left his wife there. That was the price of the key. He paid it open-handed, and went down the gate stair without looking back to see which door Muthu chose.

*

Eravi caught him in the passage by the dispensary, stooped, with a stained apron tied over his shirt and his spectacles pushed up into his hair.

"Warden, a favour. A small one." He held up both hands as if Devan might refuse before hearing it. "I'm short of willow bark and the poppy, and the pass apothecary's stock is damp since the rains. There is a tapper I know up the wood road. Honest man, keeps a dry store. I'd ride up tomorrow at first light, back in two days."

"The wood road," Devan said.

"Only as far as the first clearing. I wouldn't go near the House, of course, not with all that's —" Eravi waved a hand. "I'm too old to be caught up in anyone's war."

His cuff brushed Devan's wrist. It smelled of green salve, scorched tamarind and pine sap, the smell that had followed Fourth Guard's pot into every room Neela slept in. Eravi's own receipt, probably, or near enough. Devan registered it as one registers weather.

Half his mind was in the hall and the other half on a road a day's ride north. A hurt woman's name had been lying in his chest since noon like a stone in a boot, and he could not find where it pressed.

"Go," he said. "Take Sankaran as far as the ford."

"Kind of you. I'll be back before you've noticed." Eravi smiled and bobbed, and went into his dispensary and shut the door.

Devan walked on. It did not occur to him until much later that he had not asked the tapper's name.

*

The assize sat at lamp-lighting, as Rema had said.

She had the hall set out with trestles and a green cloth. Janu had polished the eight pillars, because Janu cleaned when she was afraid. Rema sat at the head with the tally chest, and the clerk's chair was empty beside her. Devan took the warden's stool at her left hand. He had washed and eaten at last, under orders. His wife's seat, a wooden bench at the foot of the table, stayed bare.

Rema read Kandan's statement into the roll. *The bride has learned the name of every man's mother. The warden bowed.* She read it level, with no commentary. Then she looked at him over the page.

"The corporal says you bowed. Did you?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because the writ had your hand on it, and the Keeper was your prisoner. I had no right to stop you and no wish to be seen trying." He kept his voice level. "I thought I had a better use for the pass."

"Is that the whole reason?"

"It is the one I'll give."

Her mouth moved very slightly. "That is two," she said, and wrote.

The lamps burned lower. A clerk's boy brought the wine. Rema called the first witness, Unni, to speak to the sealing day, and the young man began in the careful voice of one who wanted the whole hall to forgive him for being there.

Heat came across Devan's ribs without warning.

It began under the left arm and ran across and down, shallow and quick, as though a hot wire had been drawn along the old seam from the ford. He did not move. His breath stopped on the inbreath and then he made it go on. Under the shirt the skin rose in a long welt, tender at the edges, and the old white seam, where the knife had gone in years ago, burned beneath it like a second line.

*Neela.*

It was not a thought. It was a sentence his body said by itself.

He put his hand flat over the place. The cloth was dry. No blood. A scrape, then, or the edge of something, or a graze. A cut so shallow it could

be nothing. A cut deep enough would have taken his breath. But she had been hurt, and the House was a day's ride in the dark.

He stood.

The witness stopped. Rema's pen stopped. Somewhere in the long hall a stool scraped back.

"Warden?" Rema said.

"I ask leave of the court."

"To do what?"

"To go."

"Where?"

His hand was still pressed to his side. Rema's eyes went to it, then to his shirt, then to his face, and came back with the patient look she gave an honest ledger that did not balance.

He thought: she is too clever for this. He thought: I cannot say *the bond cuts me when she is cut*, not before a crown officer, not with a clerk's boy at the door. He thought of saying no, and of saying yes, and found neither would serve.

"I won't answer that," he said.

"That is the third time today," Rema said. She did not raise her voice. "I am keeping count."

"I know."

"The court may not grant leave. There is no blood on your shirt, Warden, and I am not blind."

"Then the court will say so," Devan said, "and I will hear it from the road."

He put his stool under the table. Nobody stopped him. At the doorway Muthu was on his feet with half his face open, and Devan shook his head before the man could speak.

"Hold the gate," he said. "Nobody follows."

*

He did not take a lamp. He took the grey mare, because she knew the wood road in the dark, and he took no one, because no one else could be told why.

The padippura swung wide for him on Unni's word. The night watch did not ask where. The cistern chain clanked behind him at the hour, and then the dark came down on the road, and the smell of wet laterite, and the langurs fell silent on the cliff as he passed.

He was not ready. He had asked for a day in the rain, and he had meant it. He had not decided what he owed the woman who had read *Lookout, Seventeen* and waited to be sentenced. He had not decided what the court would hear, or in what order, or from whom. The eleven leaves lay in him unsorted, and the hard thing had not settled.

None of it mattered.

The welt on his ribs was shallow. He rode as if it were mortal.

## Chapter 20

# Nellimala

The arrow came out of the grey with no sound before it, and it opened her across the ribs.

Neela went down between two nightbark trunks and counted. One, for the burn along her left side. Two, for the thorn scrub on the wood side, where a bowstring had spoken once and then kept quiet. Three, for the pair at her back, Vasu and Kuttan, who were already shouting and had their spears up at nothing.

"Stay on the trees," she said. "He's gone."

He was. It was a hunter's way: one shot, then away through the scrub before the light was good enough to give him a face. She pressed a hand to her side and it came back red to the second knuckle.

It was not deep. It was the second arrow of the night. The first had come at lamp-lighting from the same wood and only scored her, a line she had wiped and forgotten. She had read it as a test of the pairs, and she had been right. Then she had left the east pair standing through the dawn change, when men have stood longest and see worst. She had been awake for a day and a night, and she had counted wrong.

"Hold this." Vasu thrust a strip of his own sleeve at her. She folded it and pushed it under her wrap.

Hooves came on the wood road below, slow and uneven. Kuttan swung his spear toward the sound.

"Down," Neela said. "That's the grey mare. She favours the off hind."

Devan came up the grove path on foot, leading her. He was mud to the thighs. The road had been running water for a day and he had ridden all night through it, and his face was the colour of the clay. He stopped ten paces off. His left hand was flat against his own ribs, in exactly the place hers was.

For a moment neither of them spoke. The grove smelled of wet bark and bitter sap.

"Show me," he said.

"It's a scrape."

"Then it's a short look."

*

She took him to the tapping shed, because it had a door she could see from any corner. Pavi brought warm water without being asked, and the green salve in its clay pot, and went away again with her curled hand held close to her chest.

Devan stopped at the threshold. "Which side do you want me?"

It was a strange thing to be asked. She looked at the room. The door, the shuttered window, the drying racks. "Right. So I can see the door."

He took her right. He did not ask her to strip. He lifted the hem of her wrap the width of the wound and no more, and held it there with two fingers while he worked. The water was warm because he had had it warmed. She had once told him cold water on open skin made her teeth hurt. She had said it in the dark, in the middle of something else.

"Breathe out," he said, and pressed the cloth.

It stung. Under her ribs the claw lines from the bear pulled, and her breath went thin. His hand paused.

"Go on," she said.

He went on. His shirt had ridden up where he leaned. Across his left ribs, over the old white seam from the ford, lay a raw red line that matched hers to the finger's width, a half-breath behind. His mark was cleaner than hers and did not bleed. He cleaned hers.

"That's mine," she said.

"It's ours." He turned the cloth. "I felt the first one at lamp-lighting, in front of a crown officer. This one I felt coming up the hill."

"Rema?"

"Is counting." He said nothing more about it.

She watched his hands. There were seven pale scars across the right knuckles and a thin line at the thumb. They moved with the same care he gave to hurt horses. Eleven leaves lay between them, all of them read aloud and all of them still on the desk across the yard. She had not spoken of the stair. He had not spoken of his sister. The silence sat in the shed with them like a third person who had been asked to wait outside and had not gone.

He pressed the salve on with his thumb, light as breath, and laid a clean pad over it. "Hold," he said. She held. He wound the long cloth round, twice, snug and not tight, and tied it on the side where it would not rub her arm.

"You rode all night for a scratch," she said.

"I rode all night for a woman who counts the doors in a room." He rinsed the cloth. "I wasn't asking what it was worth."

She had nothing dry to answer with. She said, "Thank you," and it came out plain.

*

Pavi came back to the shed door in the sun, not quite in it.

"Master. There's a thing on the gatepost."

"Neela," she said, from habit.

"Neela." Pavi tried it as if it might not hold her weight. "The hunters put it there in the night. It was still warm when I found it. Nobody saw who."

It was a flat tin, round, no longer than her hand, wrapped in a cloth against the damp. She knew it before the cloth was off. She knew the dent in the lid. Eleven times before eleven contracts it had come to her mat, and each time she had learned a little more of what it was for. A twelfth had been held out to her in the kennels, and she had not touched it.

She lifted the lid. Sweets lay in rows, dark jaggery gone glossy, sesame seeds pale on top. Whoever had shot at her in the dark had stood at that gate and set this down while her hands were busy with a wound. And the gatepost had stood unwatched while she counted wrong.

A gift is the start of a bill. She had understood that by the fifth tin. She had not guessed the bill might be tucked under the sweets.

A folded leaf of thick paper lay beneath them, and a note beside it in Chathu's fine hand.

*Child. The book is not yours to carry. Bring it home, and the account closes. Under the sweets is the first of it. The rest I keep for your coming: who sold you, and every roll I did not burn. Refuse, and Thilak walks the north tapping path at dusk, as he has for twenty-two years. The hunters know the hour. Come home. C.*

Devan had come to the door behind her. He did not read over her shoulder. He stood where she could feel him, a pace off and to her right.

She turned to Pavi first. "Kuttan goes to the north path now, and he doesn't come back without Thilak. Tell Thilak I want him under this roof before the light goes. Tell him it's about tea."

Pavi ran. Then she unfolded the leaf.

It was not her slip. It was the rest of the roll leaf her slip had been cut from. Along one edge ran the fastening-holes where it had been stitched to a page now ash, and along the other ran a torn edge, ragged and brown. Four lines stood on it. Two were in the members' cipher, which she had read aloud for days. Two were in the masters' hand, which she could not.

She read the first two with her finger beneath them.

*Intake.* And below it, *Sold at six years.*

Her mouth went dry. She knew those words. She had known them since the mud of the Resin House yard, and had told Devan in his chamber what the slip behind her page said, without being able to say the rest. The rest was in the masters' lines. Two lines of strange letters stood under the words she knew, small and tidy, and she could not make them say anything.

*

They went to the master's room because it had a table.

The black book lay where she had left it. Beside it, under a river stone, lay her torn slip, with half its entry gone at the tear. She laid the new leaf against it, edge to edge. The brown tear met the brown tear and closed like a key in a lock. Neither of them spoke.

"The masters' cipher is on a separate leaf," she said. "At the back of the contract leaves. I found it two nights ago. A grid of cipher letters set against plain ones, and the masters' marks below. I have not had an hour to learn it."

"Then learn it now."

She found the grid. She laid the key leaf beside Chathu's and put her finger on the first strange letter of the first line. Down the left of the grid ran the cipher letters, across the top the plain ones. She found the cipher letter, followed the row until it met the plain one, and wrote it on the back of her hand in lamp-black. One. Then the next. Her lips moved. It was slow, and it was dull, and her finger shook only once.

The first word came out as four letters. She checked it against the grid a second time, because she did not believe it.

I. N. D. U.

"Indu," she said.

Then she went on, because she had to, and the rest came out of the grid a letter at a time. *Of Nellimala. Coast side of the Monkey Pass.* And on the second line, *Village burned the second harvest.*

*

It did not feel like anything. That was the first surprise. She had expected a door to open, and it was a word. It sat in her mouth like a pebble from somewhere she had never walked.

The second surprise was that the rest came after it, quietly, and fell into place.

"The goat path," she said. "Left of the split boulder. I walked it without a map." She was speaking to Devan and to the table. "I told you I couldn't say how. My feet knew it. They'd known it since before I had a number."

"Below Kettamala," he said.

"A day below, on the coast side. Nellimala." She turned the leaf over and the back was empty. "And lantana. All my life I have hated the smell of lantana. I used to cross a yard to be upwind of a hedge. The village is under it. It must be." She laughed once, short. "A hedge. It was a hedge."

"Neela."

"Indu." She said it to see if it would stay said. "Chathu gives it me now. After twenty-one years in his drawer."

Devan's face had gone still, the way it did when he was working out a cost. "He kept it until he could spend it."

"He kept it for the twelfth contract. Release meant the page burned and the birth name returned. That was the promise." She set the note on the leaf. "It was never going to come. Now he hands me the first of it. He's put my name in one pan of the scale, and the rest in the other, and Thilak on the beam." She could hear how level her voice was. "He knows what each of them weighs."

"Yes."

"Thilak brings me tea. He calls me Master and means it."

Devan did not say *I'm sorry*. He said, "What do you want to do with it?"

It was a question, and he waited for the answer as if there might be one. She looked at the black book, and at the tally book she drew from her wrap in its oilcloth. It was the size of her hand, forty leaves, and it had been in her wrap since the night they took the ledger.

"Read," she said. "First I want to read something."

She opened the key leaf's last page and laid the tally book beside it. "I've read this twice. I read the place names, and I read the sums. The marks beside them were only ink to me. They're the masters' marks, and they don't live in the receipts."

"They live in the key."

"They live in the key's last leaf." She laid her finger beneath a small inked bird with folded wings. She had passed it three times in the margin

of Ittan's book and taken it for a clerk's habit. The mark leaf had a line for it. She read it slowly. "A sunbird alone. By leave."

"By whose leave?"

"The masters' receipts use it for the party that grants the passage." Her finger moved down the page. "A hook for a thing delivered. A slash for coin paid. And the bird, for permission given. Ittan copied his shorthand from ours, so his columns are ours." She opened the tally book flat. "He keeps two columns. On the left, his own passes, the extras, with the hook. Those I've read. On the right, a second column. Not every line in it carries the bird. Some do, tiny, folded, and with the key I can see where I'd missed them."

Devan sat down beside her. She did not notice at first that he was not across the table. He had pulled the stool to her left and put the book between them, and he looked at it as if it might bite.

She read down the right column. Dates, boats, a count of men, a place. *Three boats of Thurai men, the long coast road, by leave. Eleven boats, the lower ford, by leave.* The sums beside them were small and tidy. The oldest leaves were written in an ink gone brown, copied from some earlier book in a younger hand. She turned back toward the front and the years dropped away.

"Twenty-one years," she said. "Count with me. The roll says sold at six. I was twenty-seven this spring."

Devan counted on his fingers. "I was eleven," he said, softly, to himself.

Her finger stopped.

*Nellimala. Second harvest. Two boats of Thurai men, the coast road to the foot of the pass. By leave.*

It stood in the right column, in the brown ink, under its bird. It had been there when she read it the first time. She had read the name and gone on to the sums, because it was a name like any other, and nothing in her had so much as flinched.

She said it aloud. Devan said nothing. She read the line again, and then the roll leaf, and put them side by side so the dates touched.

"The village was burned by raiders," she said. "That's what I thought. That's what I told you."

"They did."

"By leave." Her throat was dry. "Someone gave a bird to two boats and let them up the coast road to the foot of the pass. And a little girl in Nellimala was six."

The fire spat in the hearth. Outside, someone dragged a bucket across the yard. Devan sat with his eyes fixed on the small ink bird, and she saw him go the way she had gone, one step at a time, down a road with no turning.

"The crown permits raids," he said at last. His voice was even. It was what he did with facts that cut. "Not Ittan's extras. These are the other thing. The ones he didn't sell."

"My village was in the other thing."

"Yes."

"It wasn't a failure of the border. It wasn't the cost of a bad year." She turned her hand over on the table, palm up, and looked at it. "It was agreed."

He did not touch her. He moved his own hand to the table's edge, near hers, with the palm open as it had been in the yard. She looked at it. After a moment she laid two fingers across the old scars on his knuckles, no more than that, and felt them under her skin, seven small ridges and a thin line.

He turned his hand a little, so her fingers lay in the hollow of it.

"It's the same bird," Devan said. "It's on my own death. It's on your village."

She did not answer. She left her fingers where they were.

*

She rose and crossed to the window. The shutter was stuck with damp. She put her shoulder to it and shoved it wide, and the sun came through in a flat white slab and lay across the ledger, the roll leaf and the open tin.

"Say it," she said.

"What?"

"The name. In daylight."

He lifted his eyes from the page.

"Indu," Devan said.

He said it carefully, as if he was afraid of putting weight on a thing so new. Her shoulders came down from where they had been since the arrow, and the sun warmed the backs of her hands. It was a name, said in the clean light with the shutter open, and the sound of it went through her and left nothing behind but the sound.

"Indu, of Nellimala," he said, and then waited.

"Again."

"Indu of Nellimala."

She closed her eyes and let it sit. When she opened them, he was still looking at her, steady, and had not moved his hand.

"Both," she said.

"Both?"

"I'm going to keep both. Indu was what the village called a girl who is gone. Neela is what I did with the years after." She breathed. "I'll answer to either. I'll not answer to Seventeen."

"Neela," Devan said. A pause, quite small. "Indu."

"Yes."

Kuttan's voice came across the yard, hoarse with running. She went to the door. Thilak stood behind him, tapper's knife still at his belt, breathing hard, bewildered, alive.

"Under this roof till I say," she told him. "Pavi will find you tea."

Then she picked up the tin. It was no longer warm. She held it a moment, the dented lid, the dark sweets in their rows, and thought of eleven tins eaten and a twelfth refused, and a man who had wept at her mat and kept her name in a drawer. *Who sold you. Every roll I did not burn.* There were forty women and men in this wood who did not know where they were born. Chathu had just offered her the key to forty drawers, and she was about to put it in the fire.

She crossed to the hearth and tipped the tin.

The sweets slid out in a sticky dark rush. The fire took them with a spit and a hiss. Jaggery bubbled, the sesame seeds jumped, and a thick sweet smoke rose into the flue, so rich it caught in her throat. It smelled of every night of her childhood. She stood in it and did not step back.

When the smoke thinned, she dropped the tin in after them, and then Chathu's note on top.

Behind her, Devan had not spoken. She turned. He was looking past her, at the tally book, at the small ink bird folded in the margin of a line she could not stop seeing.

"Everything I meant to carry to the high court," he said, very quietly, "has the queen's bird on it."

## Chapter 21

# The Sunbird Column

Devan laid the three things in a row on the master's table, and they would not make one line.

The tally book lay open on the left. In the middle was the roll leaf with Neela's village on it, and on the right the Keeper's quire, unsewn from the ledger, with Asha's leaf on top. The shed fire had burned down to a red seam. Across the yard a bucket clanked, and Pavi laughed at something, and the sound was so ordinary it hurt.

He had been staring at the same ink bird for an hour. Neela had gone to settle Thilak under a roof with a door she could count. He had told her he would sit with the book, and she had looked at his face and left him to it.

There were two columns in Ittan's hand. He had read the left one already, the hooks. *Delivered.* Extra tokens, sold on top, to Thurai men who came up the coast road with coin that was new and silver and never handled. The right column was the bird. *By leave.* A boat, a ford, a count of men.

He put one finger on each column and made himself look at what lay between them.

The hooks were thin in the oldest leaves, a few to a page. Further on they thickened, like weeds in a field somebody had cleared and left. Ittan had not built the raids. They had been there before him, agreed, with a bird beside each. He had stood in the cleared field and planted his own.

So there were two kinds of crossing. The queen's: limited, counted, through the passes she chose, in exchange for no fleet landing. Devan had not known the shape of it until Nellimala. Now he could see the whole bargain, and he felt like a man who has walked a long time along a wall and finds it has no door. Then Ittan's: extras, uncounted, sold on top of hers and paid into his own purse for a wife's physicians.

Asha had found an extra.

He made himself say it in order, in his head, as he would have said it to a patrol. Six years ago his sister found one token whose wax was too good. She wrote *Need a second to be sure* and tied it in red thread. She was right, and it was ugly, and she meant to say so. Ittan heard. A man who sells what the crown has not sold cannot afford a warden's daughter with a slate full of names. He sent a letter to a kind old man in the Blackbark Wood, and a bear went up the west stair.

Then, eight weeks before his own wedding, Devan had written to the council that the raiders' tallies carried true wax. He had asked to see every seal register. The registers led to Ittan's box. Within days the queen's green wax had come down on a payment writ, and a contract had been opened on him.

Ittan bought Asha's death. The queen bought his.

They were two crimes, and a single hand could not have written both. It was the plainest thing he had learned in six years, and it had come out of a margin.

He sat back. His ribs ached where hers did. The dressing under his shirt was clean, and the line had faded to a pink thread, but he still felt the wire of it.

What could he prove?

He made himself list it, the way Asha used to, with a stub of chalk on her slate. Ittan's tokens: yes. Thirty-six blanks, the wax matched to Asha's token and the scouts' tally, the tally book in the Keeper's own hand. Asha's murder: the leaf in the Keeper's quire, *Buyer, the Keeper*, hand and lookout named, in the guild's own record. Rema's court could hold that. It was a conspiracy, and it had a body and a chain.

The treaty was another matter. So was the writ on his own life. Those had the sunbird on them. A warden's word would not carry them, nor a ledger from a house of killers, brought in by the man whose wife was named on a leaf. They needed the high court in full session, with the green-stitched quire opened before every bench. Rema could not do that. Rema could not even say it aloud and keep her post.

That was the case. Not the whole of it, but one he could stand behind. Yesterday he had gone to the Resin House with his sister's name in his chest like a fist. He would go home with a list.

It did not feel like less. It felt like walking on a floor.

*

Neela came in with the light behind her and a clay cup in each hand.

"Thilak's tea," she said. "He made me drink some first. He says no master has ever refused his, and he's not starting with a new one." She set a cup at his elbow. It was ginger and something bitter, and he drank a mouthful out of manners. "He's afraid. He won't say. He asked if I would burn the black book now."

"What did you say?"

"That I read it first." She looked at the three things on the table and then at him. "You've been busy."

"I've worked out what I can prove."

He told her. He kept it short, the way he would have briefed Muthu: the two columns, the cleared field, the thirty-six blanks. She followed the line from hooks to Asha without stopping, and he saw where it hurt her, which was the same place it hurt him. When he reached the end she put down her cup.

"And the other half?"

"Needs the high court sitting whole. The bench, the senior clerks, the other wardens. Not Rema alone." He turned the roll leaf a little, so the tear caught the light. "I want to write it down. All of it, in plain words, so a clerk can read it aloud without a key. What each leaf says, who wrote it,

where it was found. And I cannot do it. I can't read the cipher, and half the ledger is in it."

She did not smile, but something eased. "You can't read it."

"No."

"You're asking me to read it to you while you write."

"I'm asking for help." The words came more easily than he had feared. "I'm no scribe either. Asha wrote my letters. I'd write *the thing* where I mean the name of it. I need someone to say it's wrong."

"I'll say it's wrong." She took the stool across from him and pulled the quire toward her. "Say it plain. 'Lookout, Seventeen' is plainer than anything you could do to it."

"I know."

"And I need something from you." She said it just as straight, and he saw what it cost. She kept her eyes on the leaf. "The groves. Hunters shot at me twice. Eight men stand on the wall of this place and I don't know yet whose they are. Bhaskaran's six can hold the pairs, but they don't know the trees, or which of the members I'd let carry a spear. I need you to stand a night with them before we leave. Tell them where the sun comes into the wood. You're the only one they'll take it from without a fight."

He looked at her. He had the fort, the court, a roll in Rema's hand with three of his refusals on it. She had forty people and a ledger and no wall of her own.

"Tonight," he said.

"You'll lose a night."

"I've lost worse." He thought about it. "I'll show Bhaskaran the east pair's blind side. You'll tell me the rest."

"Done." She drew a breath. "That's what we do, isn't it. You can't read. I can't hold a line. I ask you for a wall and you ask me for a cipher."

"It seems a fair trade."

"It's a good one." She looked, briefly, almost shy. Then she tapped Asha's leaf with one finger. "Now. Plain words."

*

They worked through the lamps. She read, and he wrote, and every few lines she stopped him. *Say who* and not *a hand*. *The Keeper, not the one who bought*. His letters stood in rows, large and square, a soldier's hand, and the pages grew in the lamplight. By midnight he had the first quire in order, and Ittan's tokens fell into place like a ledger of his own.

He came to the last leaf and put the pen down.

"This one," he said.

She did not look up. She knew which one.

*The cold month, six years gone. Kettamala, the warden's daughter, the west stair. Buyer, the Keeper. Hand, Thirty. Lookout, Seventeen. Closed. Paid in full.*

"I have to tell you what I'm going to do with it," Devan said. "Before I do it. I won't have you hear it in a hall."

Now she looked up. The lamp threw a gold line down one side of her face.

"The contract goes to the court whole. The lookout line goes with it. Every word. I'll not cut it, or blot it, or leave it in the quire and say nothing, because a case with a hole in it is the kind a queen's clerk drives a cart through." He kept his hand flat on the table so it would not move. "I will not strike out your number."

She was quiet for a moment. He could hear the cistern chain, faintly, in the wood's silence, and then remembered it was a sound from home and he was hearing it only in his head.

"You'll name me," she said.

"The leaf names you. It says Seventeen. Rema already holds your name from the closing writ. A clerk who can count will put the two together before the sitting is over." He did not soften it. "I could have kept it from them for a while. I'd have won you a month. And I would have built the thing I mean to bring against the queen on a lie, and she would find it."

"A month isn't nothing."

"No. It's a month of you waiting for it to break."

She turned her cup between her palms. A tendon moved in her wrist, over the pale scars.

"I'm not asking you to," he said. "I want you to know that. If you ask, I'll hear it. I won't pretend I haven't thought of it. But I've thought of it for three days, and I can't find the place where I'd strike it out and still be the man who wrote *Buyer, the Keeper* underneath."

"The crown hunts a rogue it has a name for."

"Yes."

"The queen could send her sashes for me by the next moon."

"Yes."

"You'd have that on your hands."

"I'd have it on mine," Devan said. "It will be on yours too. That's the cost. I'm not hiding it in the margin."

For a long breath she said nothing. Then she gave a short, dry, unhappy laugh.

"I spent twenty-one years being a number nobody read aloud," she said. "Now you're going to read it in a hall."

"I'm going to read it with you in the room, if you'll be there."

"I know what you'll say. It's *true*, and we need the truth whole." She put the cup down hard enough to slop it. "You're right. That's what's hateful. If it were only cruel I could argue it. Mine is a true leaf, and I held that lamp. Whoever sits on that bench ought to hear that Seventeen was there." She rubbed her eyes with the heel of her hand. "And I don't want to be read. I want to be Indu, in a village, with a hedge. I want that more than any court."

"Both of those are real."

"Both are real," she said. "I won't ask you to strike it. I'll not do that to Asha."

It was a gift, and he knew it. He felt it settle somewhere under his ribs, next to the ache that was hers.

"It isn't the same as standing beside it," he said. He could not stop himself. "I'm not asking that, either."

"No." She met his eyes. "It isn't the same. I haven't got that far yet."

"You don't have to."

"I know. I'm telling you where I am." She said it without heat, as she'd have given the count of a wall. "I won't bargain you out of it. I won't promise I'll walk into the hall with my head up when they read it. Ask me that in a day, or when it's in the lamplight."

He nodded. He wanted to say something that would make it easier, and had enough sense to know that every such thing was a small lie.

"Thank you for telling me which," he said.

"Thank you for telling me first." She gave a crooked half-smile. "You could have just done it, and let me hear it from a clerk. I'd have hated you properly."

"I'd rather you hated me properly in advance."

That got a real laugh out of her, brief, startled. It broke the edge off the room.

*

She walked out with him to the grove before the wall changed. The east pair stood where they had stood the night before, and he showed Bhaskaran's men the dead ground under the tallest trunks, where a bowman could kneel and not be seen from either post. Bhaskaran grunted, and moved his pair, and said nothing, which from Bhaskaran was a speech. Neela named the trees. She named three members who could be trusted with a spear and two who could not yet. Vasu counted her hands with his eyes and then looked away.

When the sky greyed, they stood together at the gate. The dressing under his shirt had gone warm, and so, he thought, had hers. The wall behind them was only a wall.

"I'll leave the six, with Vasu over them," she said. "Pavi will hold the shed. Thilak stays under a roof." She counted them off in the air, with her thumb. "And I'm riding back with you."

He had been about to ask. He closed his mouth.

"The roll leaves are packed. The ledger rides in my saddlebag, so no one else carries it." She paused. "And I'm coming to Kettamala because there's someone there I owe. Before the court, and before anyone reads a word."

He looked at her. She was watching the road, her chin level, her mouth set the way it was when she had put a number on something and would not say it twice.

He thought of a dozen names. He did not say any. There was one he did not let himself think, because then he would also have to think what he'd say to it, and she had not asked him.

"I'll saddle the mare," he said.

"The mare favours her off hind."

"I know," Devan said. "I'll walk her up the hills."

She almost smiled. Then she turned and went to fetch her cloth, and he stood at the gate in the cold with the case he had made folded in his coat. It was larger than he had expected and lighter than it should have been, because someone had read it with him.

## Chapter 22

# The Hollow Step

Neela did not put the ledger down.

She had carried it up from the Blackbark Wood in her saddlebag, thumped against her hip for a day and a half of wet road. When the grey mare stopped under the padippura, she slid off with the bag still on her shoulder. Unni took the reins. She gave him her thanks and his mother's name, the salt-fish seller, and he went red to the ears.

"Rooms are aired," Unni said. "Janu says you're to eat first."

"Janu says a lot of things."

"Yes, wife of the warden." He ducked his head. "She says them louder when you're thin."

Devan had already gone to find Rema and the pit and, she suspected, a wall to put his hand against. He had looked at her once at the gate. It was the look of a man leaving a lamp lit in a window and walking away from it.

The kitchen was warm, and it smelled of coconut oil and curry leaf. Chinna sat on her stool by the hearth with her bad hip stuck out. Janu stood at the long table with her sleeves rolled, banging a lid onto a pot.

"Sit," Janu said, without turning. "Look at you. You've gone down to a lamp-wick. Two nights in a wood with men, and nobody thought to hand you a plate."

"We had rice."

"Cold rice is not rice." Janu turned, wiped her hands, and looked her over. She was sixty-one, small and square, with a brass key on a cord at her neck, and her eyes missed nothing. "Sit."

Neela sat. The saddlebag stayed on her knee, both arms over it. Janu's eyes went to the bag and away again, which was her way of asking nothing.

The plates came. Rice, ghee, fish curry, a dish of plantain, buttermilk with curry leaf floating on it. Janu scolded as she set each one down. The guests ate too little, the warden ate nothing, and the stew had been made for forty and would feed six. Then she set down another plantain.

Neela picked up a ball of rice. It was warm. She held it while the kitchen noise went on around her: Chinna's grumble, a girl scraping a pan, the iron cistern chain clanking its hour out in the yard. Her gaze fell on the key at Janu's neck.

*She holds it six years and cannot go in.* Devan had told her that, and Neela had seen the shut door at the end of the south passage.

She put the rice back on the plate.

"Not hungry," she said.

Janu stood very still. For a moment Neela thought she would be scolded properly, and wanted it. Instead Janu said, "Whatever it is will be a worse thing on an empty stomach," and put the plate where Neela could reach it. She did not push it. She stood with her arms folded, and then she went to see about the fire.

Neela sat with the book on her knee and a full plate going cold. In the end she ate three mouthfuls. They tasted like ash.

*

The dispensary was a low room off the north court, hung with bundles of bark and leaf. It smelled of camphor and boiled cloth, and under that of something else.

Eravi was stooped and slow. He unwound Devan's dressing from her ribs with fingers that shook a little and never slipped. He studied the graze for a long breath.

"Clean," he said. "Cleaner than I'd have done. Your husband has a gentle hand for a man who breaks people."

"He's had practice with horses."

"So I hear." He smeared salve from a clay pot. Cool, then a sting. "You'll keep this. The skin's closing well."

She watched his hands, because she watched everyone's. They were spotted, and the cuffs were stained green. His satchel sat on the stool beside her, flap open, and the smell came off it like heat off a stone. Scorched tamarind. Pine sap. Nightbark.

She kept her face as it was. There was a tapper on the wood road, he had told Devan. A man for willow bark and poppy. A man for a bad hip. There were tappers everywhere in the hills, and resin got into everything they touched, and an old physician might carry its smell home on his coat the way a cook carries onions.

She counted the bundles on the beam. Eleven. Nine of them were willow.

"How many does the House hold now?" Eravi asked, winding the cloth.

"The House?"

"Janu likes to know how many mouths." His eyes stayed on his work. "Forty, I heard. I only ask for the beds and the pots."

"Who's asking, you or Janu?"

"I ask for everyone. It's the trouble with the work." He tied the knot and patted it, kindly, as he might have patted a child's hand. "Oh, and forgive an old man, I nearly forgot. The day you read the pages back. If I knew which, I'd keep the dispensary open. When it falls, I mean. A day of that sort, there will be tears and fainting, and nobody sends for the physician until the floor is wet."

She had said that sentence to four people. Devan. Pavi. Bhaskaran in the grove, and Thilak over tea. None of them would tell a fort physician, and Devan had been at her side every hour since.

"Thank you for the dressing," Neela said. It came out level. She stood and eased her tunic down over the cloth. "It's very neat."

"It's my work."

"It is." She lifted the saddlebag onto her shoulder. At the door she looked back, once, at the old man scrubbing his hands in a basin, humming something that was not a tune. His satchel sat on the stool, its flap hanging open on the dark inside.

She walked out into the court and filed it. *How many. Which day.* Two questions, side by side, with nothing under them. She would not answer them yet, and she would not forget them.

She counted nineteen steps to the arch without meaning to.

*

The sun was going down behind the west wall when she came to the stair.

She avoided it. Since her first week at Kettamala she had taken the east stair, eighty-one steps by the wall-walk where the west way took forty-four, and she had climbed the west only when forced. She had told herself it was the view. She had counted the west stair once, in the dark of her own head. She had shouted from the head of it on the worst night of her life. Once she had come down it on purpose, under Rema's eyes, and her knees had known the difference.

She had touched the newel once, for Rema's benefit, and not let herself feel it.

The lower court was nearly empty. A boy was carrying water, one slow bucket at a time. Beside the first tread stood the newel, a carved parrot as long as her forearm, its beak broken short and worn smooth as a river stone.

She put her bare hand on it before she could decide not to.

The stone was cold. At her throat, where the resin scars lay in their pale ridges, there was a faint burn, the first warning of dusk. She had smeared nothing. She breathed through it, in and out, and it passed, as it did on the nights she kept her own shape. She stayed a woman. She stood a woman with her palm on the bird.

She climbed.

One, two, three. The treads were worn in the middle by feet. Pala wood in the rail, smooth under her fingers. Four, five, six. Nothing in her stirred but the count. Seven, eight, nine. The light went amber on the laterite. Ten.

Eleven rang.

It was not loud. A hollow note under her heel, like a knock on a shut door in an empty house. The drain slot ran beneath it, and the tread over it gave back the sound of the space below. She stood on it and did not move.

She had stepped on that note before. She had known it at once on the first day, and told Devan *I don't know* with her thumbnail dragging along her finger. She had said it for two months.

Eleven. She went on to forty-four and stood on the landing. The passage ran off toward the south range, dim, with a window at its end. She looked at it and did not walk it. Then she turned and went down again, counting aloud under her breath, and stopped with her hand on the newel.

The memory came the way water comes up in a well, from under.

A hand on her shoulder in the dark. The cloth over her eyes, with its smell of scorched tamarind. A walk she did not remember, some of it uphill, some of it stone. Then the cloth coming off, and the world very sharp and very black.

She had stood where she stood now. A stair rose in front of her. A brass lamp was in her hand, a shuttered one, small and warm as a held bird.

*Hold it. If anyone comes into the court, open it twice. Do not speak.*

She had held it. The thin bar of light had leaned across the bottom step and the carved bird, a parrot, with its beak broken short. She remembered thinking it looked insulted. She was twenty-one and she had been given a job, and she was good at her jobs.

Then a big man's weight went past her on the stair. Soft, for a thing that size. Up and up, a step at a time, into the dark. She had heard the eleventh tread ring under him, very faintly. She had held the lamp.

And a voice, above her. A woman's, young, quick, not frightened yet. It came down the stairwell with a laugh just fading out of it.

*Who's there?*

Neela stood below with the light in her hand.

*Who is that?*

The lamp did not shake. She had made sure of that. She had been told to hold it, and she held it, and the bar of light lay across the bird, and she said nothing.

There had been a sound, after. She had not needed to hear it twice, and she did not call it up now. Afterward she had counted. Three hundred and ten. Then the hand on her shoulder, and the cloth.

That was all of it. It was the same night she had seen in the book's lamplight, in the master's room in the wood. She had told Devan about the blindfold and the lamp and the count. She had left out the voice. She had not decided to. It had simply never come up out of the well until her hand was on the bird.

*Who's there?*

She had known the answer. Someone had stood at the bottom with a light, and the light was hers.

Neela took her hand off the newel. It left a damp print on the stone. She watched it until it dried.

"Ask me now," she said to the bird, to the stair, to a girl of twenty-two with a laugh in her voice. Her own voice came out flat and small. "Ask me who it is."

Nobody asked.

*

Boots crossed the court behind her.

She knew the tread. It stopped a long way off, and she was grateful for that, and angry at being grateful. When she turned, Devan stood by the well post at the edge of the lower court, twenty paces away, with a lantern unlit in his hand.

He did not come nearer. His shirt was damp from the pit, and there was a smear of red earth up one forearm. He looked at her face, then at the newel, then at her face again. She saw him understand it, all of it, without a word said. His mouth flattened. He set the lantern on the well curb.

"You're going to tell Janu," he said.

"Tonight." Her mouth was dry. "I thought I'd have a day. But she'll be along with the lamps."

"At the hour." He nodded toward the cistern. "She comes round the court at dusk. She always has."

"She stops short of the stair."

"Ten paces." His eyes didn't leave her. "Six years."

Neela folded her arms and held her own elbows. A boy crossed the court with a bucket, saw them, and went wide.

"I won't ask you to help me," she said. "I'd like that understood. I'm going to say it, and it'll be the wrong words. If you step in and say them better, I'll never know if I could."

"I know."

"If you say a single thing for me, I'll hate it."

"Then I won't." He said it slowly, as if setting down something heavy. "I'll stand where you can see me. That's all. Here, by the post, or closer if you tell me. I won't speak for you. If you stop, I won't finish it. If you want me gone, say *go* and I'll go, and I won't ask why."

She looked at him. He looked back, with that dry tired steadiness, a man who could have crossed the court in five strides and was keeping his boots where they were.

"And if I want to hit something?" she said.

His mouth moved, a very little. "The newel's yours."

It was a small joke, and it cost him. She heard that. Something in her chest that had been clenched since the kitchen let go a notch.

"It's insulted enough already," she said.

"Asha thought so too."

Neela breathed in. She breathed out. "Stay there."

"I'm staying."

"Don't come nearer."

"I won't."

She turned back to the stair. Her whole body wanted to run. She stood with her hands open, and above her the light went from amber to a thin rose, and the first lamp showed in the south range.

The cistern chain clanked its hour.

Across the court a door opened. Janu came out of the kitchen passage with a lamp in each hand, brass, lit, swinging a little as she walked. She was already scolding someone behind her about the oil. She came down the flagged way along the north side of the court with her small quick step, and her eyes went up the stair, and she stopped.

She stopped ten paces from the foot, where she always stopped. She did not seem to know she did it.

Neela's hands were cold. She had held a lamp steady for a long time. She had learned how.

"Janu," she said.

The lamps stopped swinging.

## Chapter 23

# Ten Paces

Janu stayed where she was. She stood with a lamp in each hand and looked at Neela's bare palm, still pale where it had pressed the stone.

"You're at the stair," she said.

"Yes."

"You never come to the stair." The scold was in her voice, but it had thinned. "Eravi's done your dressing? Good. Come in. The plantain will go leathery."

"I need to tell you something first." Neela's voice came out level, and she hated how it sounded, like a clerk's. "You'll want to stay where you are."

"I'll decide where I stand in my own court."

"Then stand there."

Across the flags, Devan did not move. Neela kept her eyes on Janu's face, on the creases at the corners of the mouth, the brass key on its cord.

"Six years ago, the night Asha died, I was here," she said. "I stood at the foot of this stair. I held a lamp."

Janu's face stayed as it was. The flames in her two lamps stood straight and still.

"A shuttered lamp," Neela said. "I was told to open it twice if anyone came into the court. No one came. Someone went up the stair past me, and I held the light. I didn't move. I didn't call out. I never went up."

"What lamp?"

"I was part of it. I'm not saying I knew her name. I'm saying I was there, and I was part of it, and it was me."

The cistern chain hung quiet. A swift went over the court, high, going home.

"Why?" Janu said.

It was a flat word. She might have been asking why the oil was short.

Neela had thought it through on the climb, on the way down, and all the way across the wet road from the wood. She had seen where she would put it. Late. She would put it last, after the plain thing was out, and she would not lean on it. Now it was asked, and she answered.

"Because I was sent. I was sold at six to a house that kills for coin. They raised me. They put a lamp in my hand and a name in my head, and I did what I was put there for. They made me, Janu." She heard it come out and stopped. "That's the true answer. It isn't a reason. I was twenty-one. I was good at my work, and I did it well, and I never once asked whose stair it was."

She stopped there. She didn't say *I was a child*, because she hadn't been. She didn't say *I didn't know*, because she had known enough.

Janu set the lamps down.

She did it carefully, one and then the other, on the flags, the way she set a full pot on the table. She straightened. Then she walked.

Neela counted without meaning to. One. Two. The small quick step she knew from the kitchen, the step that went round a house and missed nothing. Three. Four. Janu's eyes were on the stair. Five, six, seven. Eight. Nine.

On ten she stopped, an arm's length from Neela, at the foot of the stair for the first time in six years. Neela braced to be struck.

Janu's hand went past her and slapped the newel.

The flat of it, hard, on the carved bird. The sound cracked across the court. Then again, and again, with a small furious noise in her throat. Her palm must have been stinging. She struck the broken beak with the heel of her hand, as if it were a child that had hidden something.

"Stupid thing," she said. "Stupid, *stupid*."

Then her hand closed on the stone and held on. Her shoulders went down.

"I was asleep," Janu said.

Neela said nothing.

"She said keep her supper warm. She was late. She was always late. She was on the wall, or in the barracks with her slate, or down the village, and she'd come in at all hours with her cap in her hand saying she'd eat standing." Janu's eyes were on the bird. "I put the rice by the kitchen fire. I sat down beside it to wait. Only for a moment, and I slept. I woke at the cock. The pot had burnt dry and the fire was ash." She breathed. "I came out for water in the grey. I found her here."

"Janu."

"I'll not hear that it wasn't my fault." The words came sharp, and Neela closed her mouth. "I know what people say. The kitchen's across the court. The doors were shut. No one could have heard. I've said it to myself six years, and it's true, and it makes no difference. I ought to have been awake."

"I wasn't going to say it."

"Good." Janu turned her head at last and looked at her. Her eyes were red-rimmed and dry. "You'd have had a hard time saying it. Of everyone in this fort."

Neela took that. It was fair. She stood and let it land.

Ten paces. She thought of Janu's tread going round the court every dusk and stopping short of the stair's first step. She thought of the key on its cord and the shut door at the end of the south passage. Six years of keeping the house in order so nothing else would break.

"One thing," Janu said. "I'll ask you the one thing, and you'll tell me true."

"I will."

"Was she afraid?"

The court was very quiet. Neela had known the question was coming, though not from where. She had known it from the moment her hand

touched the newel, and she had no soft answer ready. She hadn't tried to build one.

"She asked who was there," she said. "From the top of the stair. She had a laugh in her voice. It was just fading, like she'd been in the middle of something. She wasn't afraid yet. She called down, *Who's there? Who is that?*"

Janu's hand tightened on the bird.

"I was holding the light," Neela said. "She could see it. I had it on the bottom step. And I didn't answer. I stood in the light with my mouth shut and she asked twice, and I said nothing."

For a long moment Janu was silent. A muscle moved in her cheek.

"She was frightened of the dark," she said at last. "From a tiny thing. I'd leave a lamp in her room and she'd count the stairs going down so she'd know where the floor was." Her voice was steady, which was terrible. "She'd have seen a light at the foot and thought it was a friend's."

"Yes," Neela said. "I think she did."

She added nothing. She had learned that much from the master's room and from the deck of a boy's barge and from eleven tins of sweets: the extra word was where the leash went in.

Janu took her hand off the newel.

"I don't forgive you," she said.

"No."

"I don't know that I can. I'll not lie to you. If I say it tonight I'll mean it for an hour, and then I'll find I don't." She wiped her palm down her wrap, once, the way she wiped it before kneading. "I'm sixty-one. I haven't the time to say what I don't mean."

"I wouldn't take it if you did."

"Good." Janu looked at her, and then past her at the dark stair, at the forty-four steps going up to a passage with a window at the end of it. Her mouth worked. Then she bent and picked up one of her lamps.

"Come and eat," she said.

Neela could not move.

"The plantain's drying. I didn't stand over that fire for a woman who'll let it go cold." Janu held out the lamp. "Take this. The court's dark. Mind the step by the well."

Neela's hands were cold. She took the lamp. The brass was warm from Janu's fingers, and the flame stood in it small and upright and steady. She watched it for a breath because she couldn't look at Janu.

Janu bent for the second lamp. She straightened with a hand to the small of her back.

"You'll tell the rest," she said, not turning. "Not tonight. But you'll tell me, in order, with nothing left out. I'll know when you leave something out."

"All of it."

"Hm." It was the sound she made at a pot she had decided to trust. She went away across the flags with her small quick step, and passed the corner without a pause.

*

Neela stood holding the lamp until the kitchen door shut.

Then she breathed in, and out, and a sound came out of her that was not a word. She set the lamp on the bottom step, next to the bird, where it laid a bar of yellow across the stone. She stared at it. She picked it up again and put it on the well curb instead, as far from the stair as the curb would let her.

Boots crossed the court. This time they didn't stop twenty paces away.

Devan stopped an arm's length off, where Janu had stood. He had said he would stay at the well post, and he had. He hadn't spoken, or moved, from the first sentence to the last. She could see what it had cost him in the set of his shoulders.

"You didn't speak," she said.

"You asked me not to."

"I know. I didn't think you could do it."

"Neither did I." His voice was rough. "I counted the court stones. There are eighty-six between the post and the kitchen door."

A laugh got halfway out of her and turned into something wetter. She pressed the back of her wrist to her mouth. He didn't reach for her. His hands were open at his sides.

She looked up and saw that he was looking at her.

It struck her how long it had been. Not the glance across a room, or the nod at the gate. He had looked at her, but the way a man reads a page with his thumb over one line, taking in everything else and keeping clear of the part that hurt. Since the ledger's last quire he had found the table to speak to, or the road, or her shoulder.

Now he was looking at her face. He wasn't hurrying to finish.

"You're looking at me," she said.

"Yes."

"You haven't, for three days. Not properly."

"I didn't know where to put my eyes." He said it plainly, as he gave the count of a patrol. "I looked at you and saw a lamp on a step. I couldn't make it stand still. I knew it was the same woman. I couldn't find how."

"And now?"

"You told her what you did before she asked what you'd done." His eyes held. "You said *they made me* only when she asked. You said it, and then you said it was no reason. I stood there and listened to you not defending yourself." He drew a breath. "I can look at that."

She wanted to say something dry. She had nothing dry in her.

"Don't thank me," she said instead. "Don't tell me it was brave. She still doesn't forgive it."

"I wasn't going to." His mouth moved, very slightly. "I was going to say you have red earth on your sleeve from the newel, and I'm going to let you keep it."

She looked down. There was a red smear on her cuff, from the bird. She rubbed at it with her thumb and made it worse, and she laughed again, shorter, and found she could stand up straight.

"I haven't got it all out," she said. "The rest of what I owe. But that was one."

"It was one."

"Janu's right about the plantain."

"She usually is."

Neela turned toward the kitchen, and her eye caught the side of the stair. A low arch of laterite where the treads rose over the wall. Under the arch, half hidden by the lip of the eleventh step, was the iron grate she had seen on the day she walked round the newel.

She had meant to ask about it then. She had told no one. She had kept it behind the thing she couldn't say.

"Devan." She crouched. "Come and look at this."

He crouched beside her. She put a finger through the bars to the bolt heads. They were bright. The edges of each were still sharp, cut clean with a file, and not a flake of rust on them.

"The step rings hollow over a drain slot," she said. "I knew that. I've stood on it. But this isn't the drain slot, it's a grate in the wall under the stair. The wall is six years old, or more. This iron isn't." She turned a bolt with her thumbnail. "Rust takes a year in this damp. Two winters on laterite and these would be orange. It's been put in lately, and by someone with a file."

He said nothing. He had gone very still, the way he had in the lamplight at the Resin House with the leaf under his hand.

"Asha was found on this stair," Neela said. "A bear's wounds. Inside walls no bear can climb. Every man in this fort can tell you how she was found. I've heard it told at the well and let them tell it, and I knew what kind of bear. I didn't let myself ask how it got in." She looked up. "Someone opened a door."

"The padippura was held. Four men."

"The padippura was held that night, yes. And this is not the padippura."

He rose. He said nothing for the length of one slow breath. Her eyes went, before she could stop them, across the north court to the dispensary window, a small square of yellow where the old man worked late. She looked away. Nobody had said anything yet. She did not mean to be the one.

Devan had followed the glance. He did not follow it with a word.

"Not a shout across the court," he said, very low. "Someone in this house talks to the guild. Gopan lights the stair lamps at this hour. He'll come to us."

They did not wait long. The old keeper of the cistern came across the flags with an oil can in one hand and a bunch of wicks in the other, as he did each dusk. He had been in the post nineteen years, and he walked as if the court were a shelf he had stocked himself. He reached the stair lamps and set down the can.

Devan crouched at the grate again, so that he and Gopan were of a height and the court saw two men at a lamp.

"Gopan," he said, barely above the oil's gurgle. "This grate. How long has it been iron?"

Gopan squinted. He grunted down onto one knee and laid two knuckles against the bars.

"That's not mine," he said slowly.

"Whose is it?"

"I couldn't say. The old gate was wood, strapped with iron, and rusted to lace. It's the slop-gate, the old postern. Opens on the outside path, under the wall." He rapped a bar. "Never opened in my time. I used to go round by the outside path in the damp months and feel it over for swelling." He frowned at the bolts. "Wood's gone, I see. New iron. Somebody's had a smith up."

"I gave no order for it."

"No, Warden. Nor your father." Gopan said it with the plain honesty of a man who had never been asked to guess. "But I'd not have seen a smith. The lip of that step hides the grate from above unless you kneel, and outside there's a bank of lantana grown over the path, thick as a hedge. I've been meaning to cut it these ten years. And the fever year I kept the chain from a cot, and the sergeant's lads walked my rounds. Before the lantana closed the path, I put my hand through to the lock, felt it hanging where it always hung, and thought no more."

"The lock?" Neela said.

"Big as my fist. Same one." He felt past the bars for it, and his knuckles knocked iron. "There. Old lock, moved to the new door. Same key still fits it, I'd wager. Why would a man buy iron and keep the old lock?"

"Because he wanted nobody to look twice," she said. She spoke to Devan, but her eyes were on the bolts. "The postern was there six years ago. It was there that night. New iron means someone still uses it, and has kept it oiled and quiet, and kept the same key."

"Then who has the key?" Devan said.

Gopan looked up at him, and then at her. His old eyes crinkled with something like surprise at being asked at all.

"I haven't," he said. "Nor the sergeant. Nor Janu, for all she keeps every other." He pulled himself up by the arch with a creak. "There's only the one that ever carried it. Only the physician keeps that key."

The chain clanked above them, the hour, once and then again.

Neela didn't look at Devan. She saw the dispensary, the bark on its beam, eleven bundles and nine of them willow. She saw the satchel on the stool with its flap hanging open on the dark. A pair of green-stained cuffs, wrapping a dressing. A kind old voice asking which day.

She straightened, and the bright bolts were at the height of her hand. Across the court, the dispensary window burned small and yellow.

## Chapter 24

# The Physician's Key

Devan had been under the west stair for four hours when the old man came across the court.

He knew the step before he saw the lamp. It was slow and a little dragging, the walk of a man who has been on his feet since the grey of morning. It came from the north court, past the well, and stopped at the stair's foot. Someone held his breath there.

Devan did not move. He sat on the bare laterite in the black space under the treads, back to the wall, with the iron grate three paces from his knee. The eleventh step sat above him. The dark smelled of wet red stone and old drain. He had picked the place because it was the one spot in the fort where a man could watch the grate and not be seen from above.

A key turned. The lock was fist-sized and well oiled, and it gave without a sound. A hand's breadth of iron door swung inward.

*Outside,* Devan thought. *Come on, then.*

Beyond the bars the lantana rattled. Something small came down the cut path under the wall, careful, with a boy's breath. A runner, hooded, no taller than Kannan's shoulder. The pass village, by the mud on his shins.

"Late," the old man whispered.

"The road was wet, master."

"It always is. Take this. Say it was left by a tapper's wife. Tell him—" The voice stopped. When it came again it was flat and low, a man reciting.

"Tell him she's here. The House has no master in it. The forty think she's one of them, nothing more."

Clay touched iron. A jar, passed through the bars.

Devan stood.

He did it slowly, so that his boots made no sound, and stepped out of the shadow into the thin light from the court. "Eravi."

The old man did not cry out. He went still with his arm through the gap and his hand empty. The boy snatched the jar. For a moment his face showed under the hood, round and terrified. Then he was gone, crashing through the lantana. He ran the way a hare does, in lines, and the sound faded downhill.

Devan let him go. He had thought about this for a long time under the stair. He wanted the hand that passed the jar. A boy could be taken at the first ford and know nothing.

"The salve," Eravi said at last. His voice was very dry. "Fourth Guard left a pot. I only..."

"You said *she's here.*"

The arm came back through the bars. The key hung from his fingers, and he looked at it as if it belonged to another man.

"Yes," Eravi said. "I did."

*

He told it sitting on the lowest tread with his hands between his knees. Devan stood. He kept his own hands loose at his sides, where he could see them.

Twenty years, Eravi said. He had come to Kettamala at forty, from a coast clinic that had thrown him out for a drunken wrong dose. The fort's purse was small and the physician's budget smaller. A tapper's widow sold him poppy and willow bark at half what the factors asked, and the House stood behind her. They asked only for the weather in the hills. Who was sick. Whether the pass was open. News, in place of coin, and what harm was in that? A physician who talks to the sick hears everything. He went on saying yes, and a year became ten.

"And six years ago?"

"A man came to the sick-bay door in the cold month." Eravi's mouth worked. "A big man, with a gentle way of speaking. He said he was the House's. He said there was a theft to put right, a stolen token. He needed the old slop-gate open for one night, and the old lock oiled, and he would be gone by the cock." He raised his eyes. "I said it was a smuggler's door. I said it to myself for a week."

"It was the night my sister died."

"Janu found her. They brought me to her in the grey." The words came out in a thread. "I was the one who wrote that she died of a bear. I wrote it, Warden. You took it from my hand. And I never once let myself..." His shoulders jerked. "I kept the key."

Devan heard the pass-village hounds far down the hill, and above him the cistern chain, patient. He thought of the report in Eravi's neat hand, the one he had folded and kept, the one that had made a bear of what was not.

He thought: *he bled me twice and despaired.* In the fever, before the storm, with the cat behind the curtain. Eravi had counted his pulse with the same shaking fingers, and Devan had trusted them.

His own hands were still. He watched them be still. He had sworn on this stair, the day of Asha's death, never to be the man who held a throat. He looked at the old throat above the stooped collar and kept his fingers where they were.

"The rest," Devan said.

"Three things, before tonight." Eravi counted them on his fingers, and the shaking made the count untidy. "When you lay sick, I sat by your bed. Your sword was on the floor on her side, with the hilt turned to her. I told them that. I thought, a husband's habit. Weeks later I stood in the passage outside your sickroom while she gave the captain his orders. A cart, the second dawn. I told them that." He looked at his feet. "And on the last day I took the oil. The west stair lamps. I tipped the cups and left the wicks white. A physician carries oil to the sick, and nobody looks."

"Three, and tonight's jar makes four."

"Yes."

"Then tell me why you asked my wife which day she would read the pages back."

Eravi's face worked. "A note came in the salve pot, last week. It asked how many the House holds, and the reading day. I asked her. She didn't answer, and I wrote back that I didn't know." He wet his lips. "It's the truth. Tonight's jar was the first thing I sent that was true and whole. I thought, if I give them what's already known…"

"You thought you'd be paying less."

"Yes."

So Chathu did not have the day. He had the rest. Devan filed it, cold and exact, and moved on.

"I was told it was to dark the stair," Eravi said. "They said a lamp-fall would be a mischief, a thing to frighten you. They said you'd be hurt, no more. Not the boy."

"Raiu."

"I sat with his body in the morning." Eravi's face crumpled, and he did not hide it. "Four furrows. I counted them."

The chain clanked. Devan breathed out through his nose.

Every step of this had a price, and none of the men who took the steps had paid it. Raiu had paid, nineteen and unruly-haired. So had Asha. Janu had slept six years with it on her chest, and Neela had come to this foot of the stair with her palm on a carved bird. Eravi had bought cheap bark.

"You'll be held," he said. "In the gate chamber, with Bhaskaran's man at the door and a lamp. You'll write down everything you've passed on, in order, with the dates. You'll write it for Rema, because she keeps records, and the crown will read it."

"Yes."

"No one lays a hand on you. If I hear that anyone has, I'll make the sergeant answer for it." He heard how level it was. "You'll eat. You'll have your bed."

Eravi looked up, wet-eyed, almost afraid. "Why?"

"Because the next man who needs a physician will be a soldier of mine, and you're the only one I have." He held out his hand for the key. "And because I'm not going to be the thing you were afraid of."

The old man put the key in his palm. The iron was warm.

*

The gate chamber over the padippura held a table, a lantern and three men who had not slept. Bhaskaran stood at the door with his arms folded and his face shut. He had ridden back from the Resin House at Devan's stirrup that morning, and had not said ten words since. Muthu sat on the bench by the shuttered arrow-slit with a cup of cold water he hadn't touched. His big shoulders were round. He had gone quiet, as he did when he had been caught, or when he was hurt.

Eravi settled at the table with a lamp and a stack of clean paper. Bhaskaran's lad took him in hand without a word.

Devan stood at the door and kept his voice low. "The jar will be at the pass village by now. Chathu hears tonight that the House has no master in it."

"Then I ride," Bhaskaran said.

"At first light. Not before." Devan had weighed it the whole way up the court. "I rode that road in the dark three nights back and nearly drowned the mare. The ford is up, and the cut below the cairn has no footing. A rider lost at midnight warns nobody. Your best man, at grey, to Vasu. Bar the gate, trust nothing from the pass village, bring the six in if they can come."

"It's a night's start for him."

"I know." Devan did not look away. "Have the horse saddled in the yard before the watch changes."

Bhaskaran gave one hard nod.

Devan waited until the door had shut. Then he said, in front of Bhaskaran, "Muthu."

"Warden."

"For six years I let you carry grey letters I believed were to your mother." He kept his voice flat. It was the only way he could say it. "And when I learned they weren't, I read every one of them as betrayal. I took the post-key off your belt and wore it on my own neck. Each time you went quiet, I took it for proof."

Muthu didn't look up. A muscle moved in his jaw.

"A man in a grey cloak asked you, the winter Asha died, to write each month to keep me safe. You believed him. The slip that threatened Ittan's wife came later, and you carried it to him, and you told me nothing until the pit. That was a wrong, and you know it. But I held mine longer. The man in my house was sitting on my own bed with a basin, and I looked past him at you." He drew breath. "I should have asked you straight. Instead I watched you. I'm sorry."

The lantern hissed. Bhaskaran looked at the wall.

Muthu put the cup down on the bench. When he spoke, the old loud laugh wasn't in it, but his voice was his own. "You've got the words in the wrong order, Dev."

"I've been practising."

"It shows. You sound like you're reading a charge." He rubbed his face with both hands. "Two grown men, thirty-two and thirty-five, and one of us has to be talked into saying sorry. I'd have done the same, mind. I know what I look like when I go quiet. My mother told me when I was nine." He lowered his hands. "Don't do it again. Ask me. If you ask me, I'll tell you, and if I can't, I'll say I can't, like you do. Fair?"

"Fair."

"Then I'm taking it." Muthu stood, rolled his neck, and held out a hand. Devan took it. The grip was crushing. "And don't think this means I'll let you off the round on the seventh day."

"I'd expect nothing less."

"Good." The corner of Muthu's mouth moved. "Now get out. You look like a man who's been under a stair."

*

The shutters creaked, the third slat last, as they always did.

Devan came in with a plate. Janu had left it at the chamber door under a cloth, plantain and cold rice and a twist of salt. He hadn't asked how she knew. Neela sat on the bed's edge in her sleeping wrap with her knees drawn up, awake, a lamp on the sill.

She was human. No resin smell hung in the room. Her nails were bitten short, and she hid them when she saw him look.

"Eravi?" she said.

"Held. He's writing it all down." He sat beside her and set the plate between them. "He took the oil from the stair lamps. He told them where I keep my sword. He told them about the cart." He heard the roughness in his own voice. "I didn't touch him."

"I didn't think you would."

"I thought about it."

"Thinking is allowed." She picked up the plantain and, to his surprise, ate half of it. She chewed slowly, watching him. "You haven't looked away once since you came in."

"I'm trying not to."

"You said you counted the court stones."

"Eighty-six." He took the plate off the bed and set it on the floor. His hands wanted to be busy. "Neela. I heard what you said at the stair. What she asked you. *Who's there.* I stood by the well and heard every word."

Her face went still.

"I've heard her on that stair in my sleep for six years," he said. "I never knew the words. I thought it was a scream, or I thought it was nothing. Now I know she laughed first. She wasn't afraid. She asked." He swallowed. "And I know whose light she saw."

"Devan."

"I know, and I'm here." He turned so that she had to see all of his face. "I knew when I stood in the court. I've killed a man who knelt, and I went eight years without striking a living thing, and then I struck a bear twice for you, and none of that is what I'm telling you. I'm telling you I've heard it all and I choose you. Knowing. Not before I knew, not instead. With it."

She breathed out. It came ragged.

"Don't forgive me yet," she said.

"I won't."

She looked up sharply.

"I won't," he said again, gently. "I'll tell you why. If I said it tonight, you'd carry it like a coin you hadn't earned, and every time I was quiet you'd think I was counting. I don't want you to pay me for staying. I'll choose it. Tomorrow, next winter, on the day Janu does or doesn't. Forgiving may come in a year, or it may not come. The choosing doesn't wait for it."

For a moment she only looked at him. The lamp moved in her eyes.

"That's the worst possible thing you could say," she said, "and it's the only one I could stand."

"I know."

"You don't get to be that sure."

"I'm not sure of anything else." He lifted his hand, slowly, and laid two fingers against the scar at her throat. The ridges were warm. "I'm sure of this."

She turned her face into his palm.

It was not like the first time, with rain on the roof and her scars still new to his eyes. She was twenty-seven and she knew her own mind, and she put her hands to the knot of his shirt herself. He let her, and he held still while she did it. The wrap fell from her shoulders. Lamplight lay along the ridges at her wrists, and she watched him look at them, and he didn't look away.

"Tell me if I'm wrong," he said.

"Stay where you are, and you won't be."

He stayed. Her mouth found his collarbone, then the old seam at his ribs, and she traced the white line with her tongue until he said her name and could not manage the rest. She laughed at that, low, against his skin. He drew her up and kissed her properly, and the bed took their weight with a long wooden complaint. Her bitten nails scored his shoulder. He tasted salt and plantain and her. Her thighs closed on his hips, and for a while neither of them kept count of anything.

Afterward she lay with her cheek on his chest and her palm flat over his heart. The shutter slat was still. He felt her breath settle.

"Nobody's watching," she said, drowsy. "Nobody's at the window. For the first time since the wedding."

"The grove has a watcher."

"The grove has a watcher who can't see through a latch." Her hand closed. "Stay till morning."

"You don't have to ask that."

"I want to hear you say it anyway."

"I'm here," Devan said. "Till morning and after."

She slept. He didn't, for a long time. He lay with her breath moving under his hand and thought about a ledger and an old man's key and the small cost of a night without resin: the ache that would count against her tomorrow, and the day after. He had filled her kindi, spout toward the pillow, as he did every night. It was the one thing in this house he could do that was nothing but care.

He thought of the rider, too, and the road. First light was the best the wood allowed. He told himself so twice, and slept at last without believing it.

*

He woke to a horse on the wood road.

The sky behind the shutters was the colour of ash. First grey. Neela stirred against him, and the sound came again, a rider pressed hard, hooves slapping wet clay and then stone, and the cistern chain clanked as if it too had been startled.

He was at the window with his mundu knotted before he decided to be. Through the slats he saw the road come out of the wood and drop to the padippura, and a single rider on it, low over a mare's neck, lathered to the girth. The sentry's horn gave one long note and two short. Unarmed, one man.

Bhaskaran's voice rang across the court. The gate groaned. Below, a lad stood by the stable arch with a saddled horse and a message not yet spoken,

caught in the very act of going. By the time Devan reached the stair, the rider from the wood was down in the yard with his hands on his knees, hauling air. Mud to the thigh. A face Devan knew: Vasu, whose mother kept ducks at Kalladi.

"Warden." He straightened with a gasp. "The House. They've shut the gate on us."

"Who has?"

"Hunters. They came back out of the wood in the night, dozens, with nets and poles, and the gate was barred before the tapping bell. Bhaskaran's lads are outside the wall, in the sheds, six of us and Pavi." He wiped his mouth. "They're on the walls, Warden. All of them. Chathu's hunters, with the forty standing in among them, and I couldn't see..."

He stopped.

Devan looked at the lad by the arch, and the horse that would have carried a warning through the dark road and arrived behind the hunters. He had chosen the grey over the night. Whatever the night would have bought was gone now, and the choice had been his.

"What couldn't you see?" he said.

Vasu looked at him, and then at the stair, where Neela had appeared at the top in her wrap, one hand on the rail, her face quite white.

"Anything," he said. "I couldn't see what they'd done with them."

## Chapter 25

# The Gate Shut

Devan left the assize table in the middle of a sentence.

Neela watched it from the hall door. Rema had called the sitting at first grey, the moment Vasu's news was in, and had just asked a clerk to read Eravi's dated account into the roll for the second time. Devan stood, said "Forgive me," and walked out past eight pillars and forty-odd faces. He didn't hurry. A man who runs from a hearing gives it a story. He gave it a back.

Rema looked up from the warden's chair. She did not call him back. She dipped her pen.

"The court notes the warden's absence," she said, and wrote it, and the scratch of the nib followed Neela out like a hand on her collar.

Within the hour they were on the wood road, the morning barely begun. Devan, Neela, Bhaskaran and eight Kettamala spearmen rode two by two on wet clay, the grey mare favouring her off hind under Neela. The ledger rode in her saddlebag, wrapped in greased cloth. It pressed her knee at every stride, a block of other people's names.

Nobody spoke for the first long stretch. The wood closed over them, black trunks and dripping leaf, and the langurs in the high branches went silent as the column passed.

"Thirty-one real names on that plank," she said at last. "Nine blanks."

"I know."

"I told Twenty-two I couldn't give hers yet. I said a name means reading the entry aloud, and I couldn't do it safely." She stared between the mare's ears. "I wanted the reading day to be right. Daylight, the holder and the owner, no clerks. I wanted each of them to choose who sat in the room. That took until after the assize."

"It was a good plan."

"It was slow."

He didn't answer that, and she didn't ask him to.

*

They reached the last rise in the long gold light of late afternoon. The Resin House sat in its clearing below, laterite wall and tapping sheds, the bitter smell of scorched tamarind coming up the slope on the wind. The gate was shut. The sun stood a hand above the trees.

The walls were full.

She counted without meaning to, because counting was what she did when she was afraid. Hunters first: eight at the gatehouse, more along the north wall, nets coiled on their shoulders, hooked poles ready. Then the others, standing among them in the open. Grey wraps and cropped heads, thin wrists. Men and women she had braided hair for and shared a bench with. They stood where the hunters had put them, a pole's length of air at each shoulder.

Thirty-nine.

She went along the wall again and got the same number. One short. Beyond the wall, in the lee of the tapping sheds, five men in Kettamala grey huddled round a cold fire, and Pavi's curled, old-broken hand showed among them. They were outside their own wall, and they looked up at her like drowned things. Pavi was the one of the forty Chathu didn't hold.

"Eight hunters at the gate," Bhaskaran said quietly. "More inside. We are eleven."

"And five outside," Devan said.

"Five who can't climb it."

Neela rode down alone to the edge of bowshot and reined in. She said the names. It was a habit, and now it was a plan. "Thilak. Madhavi. Kuttu. Meenu." Some of the faces flinched. One or two looked at their feet. Meenu, who had cried at the roll leaf, was pressed against the stone as if it might open. Twenty-two stood second from the end, looking straight at Neela with her mouth shut.

Then a voice came down from the gatehouse, thin and cracked.

"Master!"

Thilak, forty-one, tapper before he was an odiyan, stood at the parapet with a hunter's pole laid across the back of his knees. He had brought her tea every evening she held the House and never once asked her for a thing. His hands gripped the stone. She saw why he'd been chosen to shout. No one else on that wall would say *Master* to her and mean it as a plea.

"You kept the book!" His voice had gone high and steady, a man reading from a slate. "So did he. He says he'll burn ours."

*Ours.* It took her a breath. Not the pages. It fell into place cold and exact: Chathu had kept the other thing. He had kept the trees.

"Thilak," she said.

"I'm to say it twice." His eyes held hers. They said what his mouth couldn't, and she took it, the only gift he had. "I've said it."

The gate wicket opened above the arch. A man came out onto the gatehouse walk, one foot uneven from an old break, one hand resting lightly on the wall as if on the head of a child.

"Seventeen," Chathu said.

He didn't raise his voice. He never had. It came down warm and soft and tired, the voice of a man calling a girl in from the rain. Even the hunters on the wall seemed to lean into it.

"I won't ask you to come in. I know you can't hear that from me. Let me say a smaller thing." He spread his hands. "The groves for the book. That is all. You keep the thirty-one names you've written on your plank, and the nine you haven't. You keep your husband. You ride home. I keep the House, and the trees stay standing, and the resin comes as it always has."

"And if I don't?"

"Then it doesn't." He said it sadly. "I have a fire in the oil store, child, and a man at the nearest grove with a torch. I'd rather not. The nightbark takes forty years to bear. But you know what a moon without resin does. They ache first. You'll ache. You've had the first of it already." His eyes went to her hands on the rein, to the nails she hadn't hidden. "Do you imagine I haven't counted yours?"

She hadn't thought he would. Her hands tightened, and she made them loosen.

"I call that a fair price," Chathu said.

He believed it. That was the worst of it. He was doing his sums, as he always had, and she was a debt on the page.

Neela sat very still. She thought of the plank in the carpentry shed and the lamp-black names, and of Twenty-two asking, *Does my roll name me?* She thought of the reading day she had put off. Until the assize. Until the right day. Until it could be done safely and with consent and by daylight, with no clerk in the room.

She had called it protection. It had been a delay, and Chathu had gone straight through it like a man through a door left on the latch. While she waited to be right, he had come back out of the wood with his nets and his poles. She had left the forty their names unread, and he had walked in and found them unowned.

*I handed him back what I'd taken.*

She couldn't argue with that. She looked at it plainly and it did not get smaller.

*

Something moved at Chathu's shoulder.

A man had come up beside him on the walk, big and bearded and slow. He wore a plain brown wrap and came on a short stiff stride that hitched on the left leg, a drag and a step, though he was not in his shape. He didn't look at the road. He sat on the stone coping with his back to the drop, drew a knife, and began to carve.

Vellan.

Neela had seen him from a dozen angles. In the Resin House yard when she was nine, vast and quiet. At the meeting stone in daylight with a wooden bird in his hand. In the ledger, in Chathu's neat black ink: *Hand, Thirty.* She had never seen him look so ordinary. A man whittling in the sun.

Beside her Devan went still.

She did not turn. She felt it all the same, along the length of the saddle, a change in the air at her left side. His reins stayed slack. His breath went in and did not come out for a long time.

He knew who it was. He had seen that face by day only once, from a ridge, too far to read, and he knew it, the way you know a stair in the dark.

Vellan's knife turned. A curl of pale wood fell. He lifted the thing in his hand: plum-sized, a bird, one wing folded, the head turned to listen. He blew the dust off its beak.

Then he looked down at her.

Not at Devan, who had every right to a look. Not at Bhaskaran with his spear, or the Kettamala horses. At her, only, with a flat tired steadiness that held no threat and no regret and no apology either. It was the look of a man checking that a thing he had set down was still where he'd left it.

She thought: *He's waiting to see which of us breaks.*

She would not break first. She sat the mare and looked back. In the end it was Vellan who dropped his eyes, to the bird, and went on carving.

*

"Seventeen," Chathu said again. "Hear the rest."

"I'm listening."

"At dusk I'll put resin on every one of them on this wall. Not the way you do it, with a hand and a choice. The way the House does it when it must." He said it without relish, the way he'd have said *the rice is late*. "They'll turn on the stroke of sunset, and it will tear them. You've felt that. Some will bleed a week. Then the gate opens, and they go into the wood. Animals with their minds whole and every hunger of the shape in them,

and the nearest living things on the hill will be you and the man beside you."

A breath went along the wall. Neela saw Meenu's mouth open and shut.

"Don't think they'll refuse you the kindness," Chathu went on. "I was the first witness at every one of their turnings. I'll stand on this wall with the word in my mouth, and any of them who will not hunt you, I'll cage where he stands. And my hunters hold the wood road behind you. There is no riding home tonight, child. There is only the hill."

He leaned on the coping. "You have their pages. I know you do. They are in the bag against your knee. At dusk you can read them. One by one, in the dark, in their hearing. That is a witness's power, and it is yours." His voice softened further. "Cage them, and they stop. They'll be in the kennels with the room I have ready. Or don't, and they'll find you. That's all it is. A choice. I only describe it."

"You'd do that to them."

"I'd do it *for* them. To keep a House together. To keep them fed." He looked genuinely grieved. "You'll learn it, if you keep the book. Nobody holds a page and stays clean of it. I was twenty-six when I learned."

"Chathu."

"Until dusk," he said, and turned, and went in. The wicket shut. Vellan stayed a moment on the coping and then rose, with that hitch, and followed him.

*

The wall did not empty. The hunters stayed, and the thirty-nine stood where they were put, the sun going down behind the trees.

Neela turned the mare. Her legs felt hollow. Devan fell in beside her, and they walked the horses up the slope to where Bhaskaran's men had drawn together, out of bowshot, on a bare shoulder of ground above the road.

She looked back once, down the way they had come. Two hunters stood in the road where it left the rise, nets over their shoulders, where an

hour ago there had been no one. As she watched, a third stepped out beside them.

The sun was still up. The thirty-nine were within hearing. She made herself look at the plain thing: she could ride down now, break the seals, and read the pages back in daylight, as she had always meant to.

She turned it over and it did not hold. A handover was read in full, and a full reading said every night-shape aloud. Every hunter on that wall would hear them, thirty-nine words handed to men with nets and rings. And Chathu would still stand there, the first witness at every turning, with his own mouth. Pages in their hands would not unmake him. At dusk he could cage whoever he pleased. She would have made herself a master for nothing, and told his hunters the shapes besides.

So it was the binary he had given her, with the sun already going.

She waited for the other thing.

She knew exactly what it would be. *I asked you to read them the day we rode out.* He had asked, on the ridge road, without heat. *Read them now, before the assize.* She had said no, and given a good reason. He could say it now, and be right, and she would have to carry it. She wanted him to. It would have been something she could be angry at.

He said nothing.

He sat the horse with his hands on the pommel and his eyes on the wall, his face grey under the road mud. A small muscle worked at the corner of his jaw. She found she was counting again, under her breath, the hunters on the north wall, because her mind wanted something to hold. Her lips moved. She lost the number at the third pole.

"Nine along the north," Devan said, very low.

She stopped.

"Eight at the gate," he said. "Two on the corner post. That's nineteen." His eyes didn't leave the wall. He was counting for her, in her order, gate first and then the north, and he had learned the order from watching her lips. "Go on."

She went on. She named the posts and he gave the numbers back, steady as a man calling out soundings. When she reached the end of the

wall she was breathing evenly, and the number she had was a real one. He turned his horse a half step, and the animal's shoulder came between her and the place where Meenu stood against the stone.

"You could say it," she said.

"I could." He said it quite evenly. "It wouldn't undo one hour."

That was all. She looked at him, at the hands loose on the pommel, and her throat closed.

"Whatever I do," she said, "it lands on you too."

"Yes."

"If I read them, I'm a master. Your wife is a master, and the crown has my name beside forty." She heard herself and made herself go on. "And if I don't, they'll hunt us, and you'll have to fight my sisters and brothers, and you have already struck a man for me this winter, and you can't tell me what you'll be after that."

"I can't."

"And you're not telling me what to do."

"No." The wind lifted the wet hair off his brow. "What you do is yours. I'll carry my half, whichever way."

She nodded, because her throat would not do anything else.

Behind the wall a bell began to ring. It was the tapping bell, thin and sweet, calling the long table to its meal. Out on the wall a hunter laughed at something, short and bored, and the thirty-nine did not move. The sun touched the tops of the nightbark.

She had less than an hour. She had a bag against her knee, with forty names in it, and a man beside her who would not tell her what to do.

*Cage them with their pages,* Chathu had said, *or be hunted by them.*

She did not yet know which of those she could survive being.

## Chapter 26

# Human at Dusk

Neela's hand went to her belt for the flask, and found nothing.

Devan saw it from a horse's length away. She did it the way a man pats a pocket he knows is empty. Her fingers closed on cloth and stayed there.

They had climbed the bare shoulder above the road, and the sun was sinking into the tops of the nightbark. Bhaskaran's men sat their horses in a tight ring behind them with their spears grounded. Below, in the clearing, the tapping bell had stopped.

"It's in the store," she said. "Behind the tapping floor. I put it in the week I took the House."

"Inside the wall."

"Inside the wall." She was looking at her own fingers. "Everyone's flask went in the same box, Thilak's and Pavi's and mine, with the ration written on a tag. So nobody could say I kept more than they did." She laughed once, short. "It seemed clean at the time."

"Pavi is outside. Pavi could—"

"Pavi tried. At noon, before we came, by the drain. It was pinned again and two hunters sat on the grate." She turned her wrist and showed him the inner side, the old ridged scars pale in the failing light. "The last thumb of Ammu's resin went on the ridge, scouting the well house. There's no more. I'm a woman tonight, Devan. Thirty-nine of them will be animals, and I'll be a woman on a hill with no claws."

He had known it for a little while. He had worked it out when she stopped at the rim of bowshot and did not reach for anything. Knowing it did not make it lighter.

"Yes," he said.

She said nothing else for a time. The wind brought the smell of scorched tamarind up from the clearing, and her nostrils flared at it as if it were a hand on her throat.

"I did this," she said.

"Chathu did."

"I put the flask in the box. I put off the reading. I put their names on a plank in lamp-black and told them it was safe." She still hadn't looked up. "I've become him, Devan. I kept them and I called it care, and the day it counted I wasn't there to read the pages, because I wanted to be right. That is what he does. He is always about to be right."

Devan thought about arguing. He had the facts for it, and they were good ones. She had stood on a wall under hunters' arrows and carried a ledger through the ache. She had asked thirty-one people their names.

He put them away. She hadn't asked for comfort. She had said a thing aloud, which was the hardest sort of work she did, and the worst answer was to take it from her.

"Maybe," he said. "That's yours to carry or put down. What you do next is still yours. I won't tell you it isn't."

She breathed in, slowly. The tension in her shoulders did not go, but it moved.

"You're not going to say I'm not like him."

"I don't know that. I know you counted the hunters out loud for an hour so you could breathe, and he never needed to."

Her mouth twitched. It wasn't a smile, but it was near one.

*

She went to the saddlebag like a woman walking to a door she dreaded.

The ledger came out in its greased cloth, the black book with the contract leaves loose at the stitching and the resin-ink pages sewn in behind.

She unwrapped it on a flat rock, in what light was left. Bhaskaran's men turned their heads away without being told. She turned the pages with her thumbs. They were stiff and tacky and wrong to the touch, like skin that had been wet and dried.

Near the front of the back half she stopped. She did not need to read the name. She knew the place by the number: *Thirty*.

"Vellan's," she said.

She took the page between two fingers at the stitching and tore it, slowly, so the thread gave in a line. It made a small dry sound. She laid the page flat on her palm and held it out to him.

He did not take it.

"Chathu says I'll cage the forty tonight," she said. "He's not sure which one I'll choose, and I won't be sure either, so I may as well be honest about it. If the House comes down the hill at me and I'm out of ground, I don't know what my hand does." She kept it steady. "I don't want this one in my hand. Vellan will come. He'll come for me, or for you, because he's the one thing Chathu can still point. If it's his page or one of our lives, I don't want to be the one who decides."

"Neela."

"It's yours." She said it quickly, as if speed would make it cheaper. "He killed your sister. Whatever's written there, that's the oldest right on this hill. If he comes tonight, the choice belongs to the man with the most claim to it. I'll not take it from you and I'll not make it for you." Her eyes finally came up. "And I trust you not to read it. Not until you choose."

He looked at the page. A strip of tacky paper with a name at the head, a single line of black ink beneath it, and a number. He looked at her face instead, and kept his eyes there, and did not let them drop to the line.

It was the cruelest thing she had ever given him. It was also the most trusting. She knew both, and he saw that she did.

"The bargain stays," he said. "You told me, if I begin to read, you take it. I told you the same. That holds."

"It holds."

"Then I'll hold it." He took the page by its edge. It was warm from her palm. He folded it once, along the tear, and tucked it inside his shirt against his ribs, over the old white seam, where he'd feel it with every breath.

She let her hand drop. It shook, and she pressed it flat against her thigh until it stilled.

"That's the most I've ever given anyone," she said.

"I know what it cost."

"No." She almost laughed. "You don't. But thank you for saying it."

He took Kannan's white pebble from his belt pouch and put it in his cheek. He had no resin to guard against and no sleeper's mouth to fear. But the page lay against his ribs, and he had sworn on a stair never to be the man who held a throat. A pebble slowed words. It was the only lock he trusted tonight.

*

Bhaskaran took it badly, and then he took it.

"You want us to ride *off*," he said, low. "With the wall full."

"East along the ridge to the cairn, where the camp was. Horses and spears." Devan took the pebble out to say it and set it back. "Face the way you ride. Nobody looks at the wall after the sun touches the trees."

"They're not our enemies."

"They'll turn. Whoever sees it becomes a witness, and carries a word in his mouth for the rest of his life. Every one of them would know exactly who you are." He held the sergeant's eyes. "I won't hand nine good men that. If you hear a thing you can't help, you hear it. You don't turn round."

Bhaskaran's mouth worked. He looked past Devan to Neela, who stood by the rock with the ledger in her arms, and some of the hardness went out of him.

"The hunters hold the road," he said. "Mine are on the ridge track, then."

"Yes. Take Pavi and the five from the sheds with you if you can reach them." Devan did not say *if they live*. "Go."

They went in a clatter of wet harness. Bhaskaran was the last to turn his horse, and he said nothing, only touched two fingers to his brow, as he had at Raiu's pyre.

Then the hill was theirs. Neela, himself, the rock. The long gold light went red along the ridge.

*

It began as the sun went.

He had set himself with his back to the Resin House and his face to the wood. Neela stood at his shoulder facing the same way, arms wrapped round the ledger, eyes fixed on the trunks. He could see, without looking, that she was counting them. The rim of the sun slid below the nightbark. Then he heard it.

The first cry came thin and high. It might have been a girl's. A second followed, lower, ripped off short. Then another and another, from every part of the wall, a rolling chorus that was not a battle cry. He had heard those. This was the sound a body makes when it is turned inside out against its will.

"Don't," Devan said, as she flinched toward it. "Don't turn round."

"I know."

"I'm not saying it for them. I'm saying it for you."

"I *know*." Her voice cracked on it. "I can hear Meenu."

He could hear her too. A thin shriek, and a breath, and a longer one. Meenu, who had cried at the roll leaf. A name, now, as well as a number.

He stood and listened, because there was nothing else to do. The pebble was hard against his teeth. After the first sixty heartbeats the cries changed. They went down into something worse, grunts and a wet tearing, claws on stone, a hunter shouting a short sharp order and getting no answer. Over it all a bitter wind off the nightbark carried the smell of fresh blood.

"A forced turning tears them," she said. Her teeth were set. "The scars at the throat and wrists. It opens them all, and they'll bleed for days."

He took the pebble from his cheek.

"This is cruelty," he said, to the dusk, to the trees, to nobody. His voice was quite level. It was the voice he used for reading a charge. "I want that said, once, in the open. It isn't discipline, or mercy, or a hard sum. Chathu knows what it is. Thirty-nine people are bleeding on a wall to make them dangerous. They didn't agree to it, and he's lying to himself if he calls it a kindness. I won't call it anything else, and neither will you."

She turned her head and looked at him. He hadn't thought he had said it for her. But he saw, in what was left of the light, that she had needed to hear a man say it who had a right to.

"Thank you," she said.

"It's only the word for it."

"Yes," she said. "I haven't had one."

He put the pebble back.

*

When the cries had thinned to scattered whimpering, he turned and unslung his pack.

It was an old canvas thing, still smelling of the kalari's sesame oil. He had packed it at Kettamala without thinking, with a flint and a water skin and a twist of rice. He knelt on the wet ground and unbuckled the flap.

"What are you doing?"

"You'll be running."

"I'll be—"

"Fast. If the ache lets you. Which it won't, for long." He took the ledger from her arms and set it in the pack, the black book wrapped in its greased cloth, and buckled the straps over it. "You shouldn't carry other people's names on a hill. I will. I'm bigger."

"You'll be slower."

"Yes."

"Then they'll catch you."

"They'll catch both of us, one way or another." He stood and shouldered the pack. It was heavy, as it ought to be. He took the lamp from the saddle and trimmed it with his thumb, and the oil smelled of sesame,

the kalari, the early mornings. He hung it from the strap at his chest, unlit. "I'll light it when you say. A lamp makes a witness of the person who holds it. Mine, not yours."

She stared at him. In the dusk her face was bare, with all the guarding gone.

"The pages?" he said. "The forty?"

"Here." She touched her ribs. She had folded them flat in oilcloth and bound them with a strip of her own wrap. "Where I can reach them. Not Vellan's." She swallowed. "I won't read them, Devan. I mean it. Not unless there's nothing left."

"I heard."

"I still want to be able to."

"Then keep them," he said. "A thing you can't reach isn't a choice."

She nodded, jerkily, and dragged her sleeve across her face.

His hand had gone to the folded page inside his shirt, to the edge against his ribs. It pressed there, warm. Six years he had wanted a sentence, and now it lay a finger's breadth from his heart, and he did not know if he'd have the strength to leave it folded.

*Asha,* he thought. Only that. He did not say it. His lips moved around the shape of it behind the pebble, and he hoped she didn't see.

She did. Her hand came down over his, flat, over the page.

"I'm here," she said.

"I know."

"If you start to read," she said, "I'll take it."

"And if I don't let go?"

"Then I'll hold on till you do."

It was not an answer he could improve on.

*

The gate opened.

They heard it before they saw it: the bar lifting, the long drag of wood across stone, and then the hush that comes before a flood. The lamps along the wall had gone out. In the dusk the gateway was a black mouth.

"Wood," Devan said. "Not the road."

"The road's held."

"Then upslope. Keep the trees close. Let them come to us through the trunks, not the open." He felt her take her hand away. She had her feet planted, and he had never seen her so entirely alone in her own body. "You'll feel it first. Anything that bites you opens on me. I'll feel it a breath behind. Don't spare yourself on my account."

"I won't. I'll spare you on mine."

"Neela—"

"Don't tell me what it costs. I've counted." She was almost smiling, and it made the rest of her face worse. "Every bite on me, a welt on you. Every scratch. A mortal wound drags you down beside me. I've known it since the yard, and I'm going to bleed on you anyway, because I've nothing else to run on."

"Then bleed," he said. "I'm here."

They came out of the gate in a rush.

First the sound, a pouring of padded feet on packed clay. Then the shapes, low and quick and many, spilling past the hunters as water goes round stones: a sleek otter-dark one, a long spotted back, a jackal's thin legs, things with horns and things with teeth and things he had no name for. Their eyes caught the last red light. Thirty-nine, he counted, because she had taught him to count. And behind them the great slow shadow with a hitch in its stride, coming through the gate last of all.

Neela's breath went in.

"Run," Devan said.

## Chapter 27

# Before Dawn

Neela ran with a lamp in one hand and forty names strapped against her ribs.

Devan had pushed the lamp at her in the first twenty strides. "I need both hands," he said, and she understood what the hands were for. She held it by the ring now, unlit. The oilcloth packet shifted under her wrap at every step. She did not touch it. She ran upslope between black trunks with his breath at her shoulder and counted: strides, roots, the slap of the pack on his back.

The wood filled up behind them like a bowl.

They came in ones and twos. A long spotted back slid between two trees on her left, belly low, and was gone. Something heavy broke through the ferns. Eyes showed green at knee height, paired, then paired again. They did not rush. They closed wide and patient, the way hounds do when the slope will do the work for them.

Every one of them knew her. That was the horror of it. The mind sat whole behind each eye, and the hunger belonged to the animal, and the legs belonged to whoever had been smeared and sent.

"Thilak," she said. It came out ragged. "Thilak, it's Neela."

A heavy shape checked at the edge of the dark.

"You brought me tea every evening I held the House. You never asked me for a thing." She ran on and kept talking, because the other choice was

to go quiet and be caught. “Madhavi. Kuttu. Meenu, I heard you on the wall. I’m sorry. I’m here.”

Nothing answered. Nothing could. The shape stood a breath longer than a hunter should, then turned and went crashing back downhill.

She nearly stopped. Devan’s hand caught her elbow and kept her moving.

“Again,” he said.

“He can’t hear you out here!” She flung it at the trees. “Chathu’s on the wall. His word doesn’t reach this far. Nobody is caging you tonight.”

In the House she had been Seventeen, and they had all been numbers. Now she dragged names up out of the plank in the carpentry shed, lampblack on pale wood, and threw them into the dark one at a time. “Thulasi. Kuttu. Madhavi.”

They broke off by ones. A low shape veered away. Then a pair, side by side, as if they had been waiting for permission. Others came on with their heads down, and she saw it in how they ran. It was not hunger. It was fear of a man on a wall with a word in his mouth. She could not be angry at that.

“Twenty-two.” A pale narrow shape paced her on the right, close enough to touch. “Your roll names you. I won’t read it in the dark. At noon, in the sun, if you want it. You and me and whoever you choose.”

The shape ran beside her for ten strides. Then it dropped back, and the dark where it had been felt wider.

The old tappers’ verse came to her unasked, the line Ammu had said was a door. *The name given back at the closing of day.* She had heard it as a thing between two people at a dusk turning. She had never thought it could be done with her mouth, to a wood full of strangers, with no one answering.

Then the root. She never saw it. Her foot went, the ground came up, and the lamp rang off a stone. She rolled, and something took her calf.

Teeth, quick and narrow. It let go as soon as it had tasted. Blood ran warm into her wrap, and the pain came after, hot and bright.

Devan grunted mid-stride and slapped his own left calf. Under his palm a welt was rising, hot and shallow, the skin lifted in a weeping line that did not open.

"That's mine," he said.

"I know." She tried to rise and the leg folded. "Go on. I'll—"

"No."

He had the pack swung to his chest and the buckles snapped before she finished. Then his arms were under her, and he heaved her onto his back as if she were one more bundle. "Hold the lamp. Hold me."

She hooked her arms round his neck, the lamp ring biting her fingers. He ran. She called names over his shoulder into the dark.

A heavy brindled shape came out of the ferns on the left. She knew the gait. She had called its name three times.

"Madhavi," she said. "Madhavi, it's me."

It did not break off. It closed low and fast, and Devan turned his body to take it on the side away from her, and the jaws fastened high on his thigh. He went down on one knee with a sound she felt through her own ribs. Cloth tore. Blood ran down his leg, a real wound, deep and wet. A welt came up hot on her own thigh, and she gasped at it, and the blood was all his.

The teeth did not let go.

Her free hand found the packet under her wrap. Oilcloth, the stiff edges of forty pages, and in them Madhavi's whole night-shape in a witness's hand. One sentence, aloud, in the beast's hearing, and the jaws would stop for good. It sat against her ribs like a second heartbeat.

She took her hand away.

"Madhavi," she said, and her voice shook. "I'm not going to do it. I won't. Not to you. Let go."

A breath. Two. The brindled head jerked, as though something behind the eyes had pulled hard. The jaws opened. The shape fell back with his blood on its muzzle and stood a moment in the ferns, and then it turned and went.

"Up," Devan said through his teeth. He was already getting up.

*

She lost the hours after that.

She remembered his shoulders working under her, and the pack knocking the ledger against his ribs, and her cheek wet with his sweat. She remembered calling names until her voice went to a rasp and then calling them in a whisper, because he could run and she could still do that. Twice he stumbled. Once he went to one knee, and a long cold breath of fur passed within a hand of her face. He got up, and it did not follow.

When he finally set her down, his hands were shaking.

"I can walk," she said, and found she could, if she leaned. They went on together, two bleeding people on a hill, his arm round her and hers round him. His thigh still bled through the torn cloth, and the blood ran down his leg and over her welted calf where she pressed against him. The welt on her thigh wept clear.

The dark was thinning. It was not light. It was a greyness between the trunks, as though the night had worn through at the elbow.

She knew the tree before she knew where she was.

It stood alone in a ring of trampled fern, blackbark, old as the House, its trunk split at the base into roots like knuckles. Something pale lay among them. A rag of blue cotton, rained on and dried and rained on again, with a cord pouch beside it, held down by a flat stone.

Ammu's Valli cloth. Muthu had laid it there.

"This is where she—"

"I know," Devan said.

They had both stopped. Neither had chosen it. She thought, with the part of her that still counted: *The wood brought us here.* Then she heard the hitch.

A drag and a step. Slow, unhurried, from behind the trunk.

The bear came round the tree without a sound beyond that. He filled the gap between two roots. His coat was matted with the night, and in the grey his small eyes held nothing at all, neither hate nor pity, only a patient weariness that she knew. It was the look from the wall.

She had time to say, "Devan, go—" and then the forepaw swept her off her feet.

She hit the roots on her back where Ammu had died. The air left her. A weight came down on her breastbone, and claws pricked through the wrap, and the smell of him closed over her like a wet wool blanket. Scorched tamarind. Old blood. A man's sweat under an animal's musk.

He did not bite. She lay under his paw and understood, all at once and very coldly, why he did not.

Devan stood over them.

He had put the pack down. His right hand was inside his shirt, and it came out holding a folded strip of tacky paper. The lamp had rolled against a root. He snatched it up, struck flint twice with fingers that would not hold still, and the wick caught. The little flame put gold on his face and a shaking gold on the page.

He opened it. He held it to the light.

"Off her," he said.

The bear did not move. The paw pressed and the claws went in a hair deeper.

She could see the page from below, upside down: a name at its head in Chathu's neat black hand, a line beneath it, a number. One sentence, aloud, in the bear's hearing, before the dawn. She watched Devan's lips shape the heading. He had not said anything yet, but he was reading. He had begun.

Six years, she thought. Six years of Asha's notes tied in red thread, and a stair he had sworn on. The oldest claim on the hill.

She had stood at the foot of that stair with a shuttered lamp. She had counted to three hundred and ten.

"Devan."

He didn't look at her.

"You haven't struck first in eight years." She said it between breaths, because the paw left her little else. "You swore it to me twice, in our bed at Kettamala, that if you began to read I'd take it, and you'd let go. It's not a

throat. It's a year. A year of his mind going, in a cage behind the cookhouse, and you'd be the one who put him there."

"He killed her." His voice was very low and perfectly even, the voice he used for a charge. "He's standing on you. He could finish it now."

"He hasn't. Because you've got the page lit. That's the only reason I'm breathing, and I'm still asking."

"Neela—"

"You said if you begin to read, I take it." Her hand was free. She had known it was free since she fell. "I said I'd hold on till you let go."

The flame leaned in a draught. The bear's breath rolled over them both. Somewhere out in the grey, something moved and was still.

She reached up. It was a long way. Every claw lifted and settled with the stretch of her arm, and she did not look at them. She closed two fingers on the edge of the page, and then her whole hand.

His grip was iron for a moment, a man holding a sentence the way a drowning man holds a rope.

Then it opened.

He did not speak. He stood with his empty hand in the lamplight and let her have it. Through the tacky paper she felt a fine tremor that was not hers.

"Thank you," she said, and found her voice had gone.

"Don't." He knelt. His face looked scraped to the bone. "Tell me what to do with my hands."

"The book. Open the book. Hold the light."

*

He dragged the pack to him and unbuckled it one-handed, the lamp in the other. The ledger came out in its greased cloth. He laid it open on the roots beside her head, front half up, the loose contract leaves lifting in the draught. She turned the leaves with the hand that wasn't holding Vellan's page, and the bear's weight rode her breath.

She knew where it was. She had turned past it once, in the Resin House, unread.

*Thirty.* Chathu's cipher, small and tidy, plain ink on a plain leaf. No resin in it, no witness's hand. It couldn't cage a mouse. It was only what the House had written about a man.

She read it aloud in the plain tongue, slowly, so that every word would arrive.

"Thirty. Release not to be granted. Sell to the crown when spent."

Nothing happened.

She said it again, because it was a short line and she wanted the bear to have it twice. "Thirty. Release not to be granted. Sell to the crown when spent. That's in his hand, Vellan. It's been in his hand since your third contract. He wrote it in ordinary ink, so he'd never have to say it."

The paw stopped pressing. It did not lift, not at once. It rested on her, a weight with the intent drained out.

*Three times over,* she thought. *He earned it three times over.* A man who believed the blade was never guilty, only the hand that threw it, and who had waited years to be set down. The hand had written his price in advance.

The small eyes closed. When they opened they were looking at the page in her fist.

The paw lifted away.

The bear backed one step, then another. He lowered himself among the roots as if his legs had been cut. He put his chin on his forearms, six feet from her face, and did not move again.

She lay where she was. She did not trust herself to get up.

"Is he—" Devan began.

"Waiting."

"For what?"

"Light."

*

The grey went to pearl. A bird started up somewhere, and then another. The trunks came out of the dark one at a time like men stepping from a crowd.

Round the edge of the clearing she saw them. Low shapes at the fern line, a dozen, then more, standing in the paling dark and not coming nearer. The thin-flanked ones, the antlered, the spotted. A pale narrow one who held her eyes a moment too long. They had run all night on a hill with their minds whole, and now they stood and watched what a man and a woman and a bear were doing under a tree.

Then Vellan began to change.

She had seen it a hundred times from the other side. She had never watched from outside, with a lamp on it. The coat drew in like a tide going out. Bone slid under skin with a sound like green wood. The great shoulders narrowed, the muzzle drew back, and a big bearded man lay shuddering among the roots, bare to the waist, the old resin scars pale at his throat and wrists. He coughed. He got his hands under him.

Devan had not looked away. He had not been able to. The lamp was in his hand, and his eyes were on it all, the whole slow wrench of it, and she saw the instant he understood what he was seeing. His shoulders went still.

*Witness,* she thought. *Oh, Devan.*

Vellan raised his head. He was grey under the beard. He looked at Devan's face, then at the lamp, then at the page in her fist. His voice, when it came, was the low grumble of the yard.

"Well," he said. "You saw."

"Yes," Devan said.

"Then you've got it. Any dark you like."

"I know what I have."

Vellan's mouth moved. It might have been a joke. He didn't finish it, and he didn't ask for anything. He sat back on his heels with one hand flat on the root where a blue rag lay, and for the first time since she had known him he looked at no one.

All round them the light was coming. Along the fern line the shapes began to stir, then to go, one by one and then in a rush, loping downhill toward the House and the sheds behind the wall, where the dawn would take them out of sight of every eye. She counted them out. She could not

help it. Thirty-one, thirty-two. Behind the trunks, far off, the first of the cries began, the thin ragged turning-back that always came with the sun.

None of them was caged. She had not said a word of any page. She said it again to herself, slowly, to be sure it was true.

Devan sank down beside her. He still held the lamp, and the flame had gone pale in the daylight. He set it on the root, and it ran with him, smoking, a small stubborn light. Blood had dried black down his leg.

"I stood there," he said. "With it open."

"I know."

"Another breath—"

"You didn't."

"You took it." His eyes closed. "I let go."

"You did."

She lay with her head on the root and looked up through the black branches at a sky going pink. Forty pages sat flat and warm against her ribs. One more, tacky and creased, lay curled in her fist. In the clearing behind her a man who had killed Asha knelt in the dirt and did not run.

The night was over. Nothing in the wood had been caged.

She had until the House woke to decide what she was going to do with the forty pages and with Vellan.

## Chapter 28

# Daylight Reading

Thirty riders sat their horses on the apron outside the Resin House gate, and every one of them had his back to the wall.

Neela stopped at the edge of the trees. Her calf had stiffened on the walk down into a hot line of pain, and Devan's weight was on her shoulder as hers was on his, two limps making one bad stride. Vellan came last, bare to the waist, with nobody holding his arm.

"Garrison grey," Devan said. "That's Muthu."

The captain swung down and came across the trampled ground. He didn't laugh and he didn't greet them. He looked at the two welts, the blood dried black on Devan's leg, the bear-sized man behind them, and he took it in the way he took in a bad ford.

"Rema posted her order on the hall door the morning you rode," he said. "Plain, so no man could say he misheard. No soldier of Kettamala to give aid to any rogue odiyan, on pain of the queen's displeasure." He rubbed his jaw. "Bhaskaran's holding the ridge road behind us. I brought thirty. Told them to face the road and not turn round, whatever they heard."

"They'll lose their stripes for this," Devan said.

"Some of them. I asked for volunteers and got more than I could mount." He pulled a folded square from his sleeve. Grey wax, unbroken. "My month's letter. Wrote it at the second watch, for the first runner on

the goat path. Unni watched me do it and said nothing, which was kind of him."

An iron basket stood by the gate where the tappers burned their rag ends. The hunters had kept it lit all night. Muthu held the letter over it a moment and looked at Neela.

"I spelled your name right," he said.

"Thank you."

"Burned it anyway." He dropped it in. The wax ran grey over the coals and the paper browned and curled. "I'm talking, Neela. Have you noticed? Loud as a drum. I want it noted."

It was almost a joke. She nearly laughed, and the sound cracked in her throat instead. For six years he had carried two loyalties in one pocket. She watched the smoke lift off the last of the second one.

Above them the wall had filled with hunters. Hooked poles, nets, iron rings on chains. Pachan stood below the gate arch, tall and stooped in his grey wrap, with his eyes on his boots.

"Pachan," she said.

He looked up.

"I'm not asking you for anything. The book is down here in a pack, and nobody owns anyone in it by dawn. You can take that to the wall and hold it for him, or you can put down the pole."

A pole came off the wall and rang on the stone. Then another. Then all of them, clattering down like dropped spits. Pachan lifted the bar himself, and the gate dragged open.

"Face the road," Muthu told his men, very quietly. Thirty heads stayed forward.

Neela went in alone first. She would not cross that sill with a soldier at her back.

*

The forty stood in the yard at noon, and the sun stood straight over them.

They wore blankets and sacking and one another's shirts. The torn resin scars at their throats and wrists had been bound with strips of tapping

cloth, and the cloth had bled through. Some looked at her. Most looked at the ground. Pavi had ridden back from the cairn camp at first light, and she stood at the edge of the crowd with her curled forepaw hand pressed to her chest.

Chathu sat on the cook-house step, quite upright, with his hands in his lap. Two of Muthu's men had walked him there. He had taken in the empty hunters' wall and said nothing.

"You two," Neela said to the soldiers. "Out to the apron. Face the road with the rest."

They looked at Devan. He nodded. They went, and the gate shut behind them. Thilak and Kuttu came and stood either side of the step, and Chathu did not turn his head to either.

Devan stood at the gate with the pack at his feet. Vellan sat against the well wall under the eye of nobody. Thilak had put a cup of ginger tea beside her boot without a word.

"I'm going to read your pages aloud," Neela said.

The yard hushed.

"All of them. Aloud, in full, in daylight, in front of whoever you choose. Once I've read yours, you take it, and from then on nobody can read it against you. Not me. Not him." She didn't point at the step. "That's the one way out of the leash that Chathu never told you about."

"What's the price?" That was Kuttu, thin and angry.

"Whoever hears your page hears your shape. The reading makes them your witness. If I read it here, the whole yard has it." She made herself say the rest. "That's thirty-nine new people with a word in their mouths, and I don't get to pick who they are. The soldiers are outside, and they stay outside. But everyone in this yard is a witness by the end. You can ask me to read yours alone, in the shed, to one person you name. You can ask me to wait. If you ask me to wait, I hold it, and a holder is a master, and I don't want to be that to anyone. But it's yours to say."

"And if we say nothing?" Kuttu asked.

"Then I stand here until you do."

Nobody moved for a long moment. A hunter had left a tapping bell on the ground, and it rocked in the dust and went still.

Twenty-two stepped out first, narrow and pale in a man's shirt. "Shed," she said. "Her." She pointed to Pavi. "Nobody else."

"Noon sun, I said."

"The shed has a skylight."

They went in together. When they came out, a quarter hour later, Twenty-two held a strip of tacky paper in both hands and kept saying a word under her breath, four syllables. *Kamalakshi.* She said it like someone trying a stair in the dark.

After that they came. Six asked for the shed. The rest stayed in the sun and heard each other's animals read out in Neela's flat, careful voice. *Thirteen. Boar. Witnessed at first turning, and sworn in resin-ink by Chathu of the Resin House.* A boy flinched at *wolf.* Nobody laughed at *hare.* She read the intake rolls fastened behind the pages, and she watched what they did to faces.

"Thulasi," she read. "A salt-boiler's daughter, of Pazhayangadi."

"My mother boils salt," Thulasi said. Then she sat down in the dust.

"Kumaran, called Kuttu. A ferryman's son."

Kuttu said nothing. He took the page. Twice more as the afternoon went on, she heard him say it to himself, flat and wondering: *Kumaran.*

Her voice went twice. Thilak brought more tea, and she drank it and went on.

When she reached him, he stood with his big hands hanging. A tapper before he was ever a beast, twenty-two years in the House. *Four. Boar.* She finished the roll, and his village, and the name of the man who had signed him over for a debt.

"Burn it," Thilak said.

"The roll burns with the page. You won't get it back."

"I know where I'm from. I know who sold me." He held out his palm. "I don't want it written down anywhere for someone to carry."

She gave it to him. He took it to the gate basket and fed it in, page and roll, his village and the debt together. The ink curled green and black. He stood watching the smoke with his shoulders loose.

She had not known a man could look lighter for losing something.

Madhavi came last of the forty, brindled shape and bitten tongue. She looked at Devan's thigh, then at the ground. "I'm sorry," she said, to the dirt between them.

"It's closed," Devan said. "Take your page."

She took it, and she did not look up.

*

Vellan's she read standing, because she did not trust her knees.

She had torn it from the ledger herself, on a rock, and it had lain against Devan's ribs most of a night. She unfolded it in the sun with the whole yard watching.

"Thirty. Sloth bear. Witnessed at his first turning, and sworn in resin-ink by Chathu of the Resin House."

Vellan sat very still against the well. When she reached the roll she read it plainly. "Vellan. A joiner's son, of Venmanal. Sold at nine."

"I knew that," Vellan said.

"I know." She walked across the packed earth and held it out. "It's yours. Read against you by no one. Burn it or keep it, but you decide."

His big hand closed on it and stopped. He looked up past her, to the gate. "Not me you should be giving it to."

"You were holding it all night," she said, over her shoulder, to the man at the gate. "I'm done holding it."

Devan came forward. His limp showed with every step. Some of the forty drew back, and Thilak's weight shifted. Pavi caught his arm without turning her head.

"Nobody touches him," Neela said. She said it as a request, and she heard how it sounded. It was her voice, not a master's. "He walks out of here. He owes every one of you, and he knows it, and you can tell him so when you find him. Today he walks."

Devan stopped an arm's length from the man who had killed his sister. She could not read his face. She had thought she could read it by now.

"You saw me," Vellan said. "Dawn. You've got it."

"I have."

"Say it, then. It's all I'd have done." Vellan's mouth did something that was nearly a smile. "Not a bad swap, for the stair."

Devan said nothing for the length of a long breath. Then he turned his back.

He did it slowly. He put himself between the bear and the gate, and he put his bare shoulders and his bitten leg in reach of a man with a joiner's hands. The yard saw it. She saw it. Vellan's eyes widened, and he had no mouth for a joke now.

"Go," Devan said, to the gate.

Vellan got up, which took him two tries. He folded the page small and put it in his waistband. He stood a moment by the well wall as though he had left something there. Then his hitching stride crossed the yard behind Devan's back, and out through Pachan's gate, and across the apron past thirty soldiers staring at the road, and into the wood.

Neela counted his steps. At forty-one she stopped.

"Seventeen," Devan said, still not turning.

"What?"

"The steps. After I said go." He turned at last. His face stood open as a shutter, as it had been under the lamp. "I learned it from someone."

She tried to answer, and it didn't come. She stood and looked at the man who had held the one sentence he had wanted for six years, and had put it in her hand, and had just let it walk. He looked at her in turn, at the stack of empty cloth on the ground where forty pages had been, and the ink on her fingers.

He didn't say it. Neither did she. Her eyes burned, and he nodded once, as if she had.

*

Kennel nine had straw changed that week, and a clean cloth in one corner.

The aisle was cool and dim, forty-two cages in a row under the oldest roof, forty-one of them filled, and Muthu's water-carriers had been through. Pavi walked behind her with the ledger's back half. Devan stayed at the door. Neela went down on her knees at the iron bars.

The civet lay on the cloth with its chin on its paws. A silver anklet circled one thin hind leg above the foot, its bells cut off long ago.

"Kirri," Neela said. "It's Neela. Ammu's chechi, I think she'd say. I've come to read your page."

The small eyes moved, slowly. They found her face and went away again.

She read it through the bars. *Number Twelve. Civet. Witnessed at first turning, and sworn in resin-ink.* Then the roll, in the plain tongue, at the speed of walking. "Kirthika. A boatwright's daughter, of the coast. Sold at five."

A boatwright's daughter. She read it again, in case it might matter.

Ammu had written four times. Neela told her that, in a low voice, because someone ought to. Ammu had sat in her inn at Kettamala and hummed a fishing song and written a fifth letter that she'd never had time to send.

Kirri's whiskers trembled. The long grey body stayed where it lay.

There was no use waiting for more. She had known it, the way she'd known the hour at which her own second wrist would burn. A caging could not be undone, and a page in the straw could not undo it. She folded the sheet once and slid it through the bars. It lay on the cloth by the silver anklet, in reach of a paw that would never close on it.

"It's yours," she said. "Nobody reads it but you."

The civet blinked once. Then it curled round and slept.

Pavi put a hand on her shoulder. Neela stayed on her knees until she could trust her face, and then she got up and went to ten. There were forty more pages in the book, and she read them one after another through the afternoon, cage by cage, until the light went from the slats. Each time she laid a page down in the straw.

*

At dusk, Muthu's men took Chathu out through the gate.

He did not struggle. His hands were bound before him, and a strip of clean cloth hung at his neck for after dark. Devan had been very exact about that: gag him at sunset until the sun comes up again, and nobody speaks to him but by daylight. He walked with his uneven left foot on the packed earth and stopped by Neela.

"Seventeen," he said. He said it kindly. "There's a balance, child. Twenty-one years of feeding and keeping and—"

"My name's Neela." Her voice was steady. "And Indu. I keep both. The account's closed."

He looked at the back half of the ledger on Pavi's arm, empty of pages, stitched thread and stubs. "A book is a thing that holds," he said, almost to himself. "Take it away and see what's left."

"We'll see," she said.

They put him on a horse for the Justice at Kettamala. Pachan stood in the gate and watched him go, his long face working. When it was done he turned to Neela with his hands open.

"Someone should keep the kennels," he said. "And the groves. If anyone wants them kept."

"Keep them. Water them every day. Nobody rations resin. No one is the master of the groves. You tap, and each member takes a season's flask from the store tonight, and next season you ask them what they need."

He nodded slowly. "And who's it for, if it's nobody's?"

"Everyone," she said. "That's the whole trouble with it."

They left in the dusk, the forty, in twos and threes, with their bound wrists and a flask apiece. They rode east along the ridge to the old cairn camp, where Bhaskaran's men would hold the stones and look the other way until the court had spoken. Some of them spoke to her as they passed, and some did not. Thulasi put her page to her mouth. Kuttu said the word *Kumaran* once more and grinned like a boy.

Neela cut the back half of the ledger from its cover with a tapping knife. It came away from its stitching with a soft sigh. Before she wrapped it she turned it over once more, and her thumb found the stubs near the end.

Leaves had been cut from the binding with a clean blade. There were a great many. By each stub, in the margin, someone had inked a sunbird no bigger than a lentil, with its wings folded.

She counted them twice. Then she closed the book on them and said nothing. Devan was at the gate with the pack, and she could not make the number mean anything yet.

The emptied back half she kept, wrapped, and what she had meant to keep: the contract books, loose-stitched, and the last quire in its green thread under the wax of a spread-winged bird. Devan took them from her and buckled them under his flap. He did not ask what else she had seen.

"A day's hard ride to Kettamala," he said. "The assize is still sitting."

"I know."

She knew what the court would want, too. A leaf in the black book, in Chathu's hand, with a number at its foot. *Lookout, Seventeen.* She had read eighty-two pages today and given every one of them away. She could not hand that one on to anyone.

Devan did not look at her. He did not ask. She stood with her ruined hands in the dusk, the ledger gone from her, and understood that she would have to decide it on her own.

## Chapter 29

# The Assize

Rema sat in his father's chair with the tally chest open at her feet, and Devan stood where the accused would have stood and thought: *eight pillars, and not one of them will hold me up.*

His thigh had stiffened on the ride. Every step across the hall flagstones tugged at a welt that wasn't his, a hot line on his left calf, and it did not matter. He had come in with a canvas pack and the court's whole attention, and he meant to spend it well.

The hall was full. Janu stood on the hearth step with her hands wrapped in her apron. Muthu had the door, and Kandan of Mathoor stood three men down from him with the scar through his brow drawn tight. Bhaskaran had put the garrison along the wall in their grey, and two of his men held the dais step. Rema's escort was long gone down the goat path. She sat alone with her pen.

Neela sat on the household bench, bound hand in her lap. She had washed. She had put on the day kasavu with the torn border, mended. Her eyes stayed off him, and he understood why. Last night he had told her what he would and would not do.

"The leaf names a lookout," he had said, in the dark, with the pebble in his cheek and no reason for it. "I'll put it before Rema. I'll say whose number it is. You needn't stand. I'll say it, and the cost is mine."

She had said nothing. Her breathing had been very even, and he'd known that breath.

Rema laid a board across her knees. Fifty-eight years old, grey at the temples, plain brown wrap. She wrote like a clerk who loved her ink.

"This is an assize of the queen's border, sitting at Kettamala for the high court's record," she said. "I write what is said and what is shown. I decide nothing today but what I will carry south. Warden. Begin."

He opened the pack.

Asha's token came first. The split-ash stick lay on the table in its oilcloth, the red thread still twisted round it, council wax gone dull. Beside it he set the beeswax impression he'd lifted from Bhaskaran's tally. Dot and split, at the sprig's stem. Then the scouts' satchel tally, with its clove-sweet wax. Then thirty-six blanks from Ittan's chest, in a row, each wrapped, each sealed in the same mark.

"Asha, my sister, found the first of these six years ago," he said. "She wrote on a note beside it that she needed a second to be sure. She was dead within the month. Last spring a second came off a raider's body in the lower narrows. It matches. Today I give you thirty-six more, found in a false-bottomed chest on the Keeper's own cart, with no clerk's number on any."

"And what would they have done?" Rema asked, writing.

"Opened the pass. Not to a gate clerk. A gate would never stamp them. To a widow holding the seal in trust, with the Keeper at her elbow to advise." He kept his voice flat. "My marriage writ names her. The same clause. The Keeper proposed the match."

He set Ittan's tally book beside the blanks. Forty leaves, dated sums, pass names. He did not open it for her. Rema had spent two days in it already, alone in the south range, and her pen told him she knew where it would read.

"And the guild contract," she said.

He took the leaf from its fold. It was cut from the Keeper's quire, hooked in the margin, written in Chathu's tidy hand. It was not the other quire, the one stitched in green thread that he had carried in under his flap. That one was a different matter, and he left it buckled. He laid the leaf on the table face down.

"I'll have the man who wrote it speak first," he said. "By daylight, as the charter requires."

*

They brought Chathu in from the south range with his hands tied before him and the gag cloth hanging at his neck. It was an hour past noon. Devan had counted every tick of the sun to be sure.

The old man walked with his uneven foot on the flagstones and stopped at the foot of the dais. He looked at Rema's board, and at the false-bottomed chest, and last at the hall. His gaze went along the grey line of the garrison without hurry, taking inventory.

"Master of the Resin House," Rema said. "You are not charged here. You are heard."

"I thank the court." The fatherly voice. Soft, unhurried, a man at a ledger by lamplight. "I will speak in what I know, which is accounts. A man who keeps accounts keeps them true. It is the only mercy in my trade."

"Then give me the account," said Rema.

"The cold month, six years gone, by the Keeper's hand." He did not say *Ittan*. He said the office, as if the man had already ceased to be a person. "Four slashes paid, one hook delivered. The buyer was the Keeper of the Passes. The subject was the warden's sister of Kettamala. The service was a bear's."

The hall made a sound. It was not a gasp. It was lower, the noise of sixty men shifting their weight.

"She was found by the stair," Chathu went on, "as the contract required. Closed. Paid in full. I have never in forty years carried a balance past the day it fell due, and the Keeper was as exact."

"Why?" That was Janu, from the hearth step. Her voice cracked in the middle. "Why her?"

Rema lifted a hand. Chathu turned his head toward the old woman and answered her anyway.

"Because the girl had found a tally, mistress. A little thing. The Keeper's trade was in little things." He folded his bound hands. "She cost the House nothing to feed. It was a short account. I wept, when it was closed. I do, always."

Devan's nails were in his palm. At the end of the household bench a hand tightened on the wood rail. He felt it as a drag at his own right wrist, and he did not look.

"Enter it," Rema said, to no one, and wrote.

*

"The leaf," she said.

He turned it over. He had turned it over in his head a hundred times on the road, and the wording had not changed. He drew breath to read, and a bench scraped.

Neela had stood.

She still hadn't looked at him. She stood with her bandaged hand against her skirt and the other lifted, the way a child lifts a hand in a pit when she wants the instructor's eye. The hall stilled. He had seen her walk into a Resin House and take it. He had never seen her stand so carefully, like a person carrying a full cup.

"Madam," she said. "I'll read the lookout."

"Neela." He said it very low. "I told you—"

"You did." She had not turned. "You said you'd carry it, and the cost would be yours. I know." Her eyes flicked to him then, once, very bright. "It was never only yours."

Rema watched her over the board. "You are the warden's wife and the household witness to the closing writ. You're not sworn today to speak to this."

"Then swear me after." Neela crossed the flagstones. Her calf dragged. Muthu's hand twitched on the door and stayed where it was. She stopped at the table beside Devan, close enough that he could smell the tamarind of the Resin House salve, and took the leaf from the cloth. She did not read yet. She held it a moment against her palm.

"Asha, the warden's sister, was killed on the west stair of this fort six years ago," she said. "I know where the stair is. I walked round its foot for weeks before I let myself say why. I stood at that foot once. I stood at it with a shuttered lamp and a blindfold just off my eyes, and counted to three hundred and ten, and nobody came."

The hall did not breathe. Kandan's scarred brow had gone white.

She read then, in the plain flat voice she'd used for forty pages in the sun. "The cold month, six years gone. Kettamala, the warden's daughter, the west stair. Buyer, the Keeper. Hand, Thirty. Lookout, Seventeen. Closed. Paid in full."

She lowered the leaf.

"Seventeen is a number. It was mine for twenty-one years." She turned and looked straight at Rema. "My name is Neela. I'm the lookout. I was told to open a lamp twice if anyone came into the court. I wasn't told what the lamp was for. I didn't ask. I do not offer that as a reason."

Devan stood very still.

*My father was warden then*, he had said at the Resin House, with the stolen ledger open between them. The leaf said *daughter*, as if the girl on the stair were only her father's. It gave the lookout a number, and nobody who wrote that line had thought she might carry a name of her own. He had told himself for two nights how this would sound. He had not been ready to hear it in her voice, level and without excuse, a woman handing over the one thing she could have kept.

Beneath it lay the quiet fact that Asha would have done the same. *Say it anyway*, her last note had said. *The truth protects whoever finds it.* He had carried that line since the night he found it under the camphor block, not knowing it would be spoken in this hall by this mouth.

"I asked you not to," he said, so low only she heard.

"I know." She didn't turn her head. "You asked me nothing. You told me what you'd do. I decided the rest."

He had won. He knew it the way you know a gate has fallen. The proof would hold, and Rema would carry it south. And the price was this woman standing in the open with her own name on a record, and he had not

been the one to pay it. He did not know what to do with the gladness or the grief of that. When she held out the leaf, he took it, and his fingers were steady. Then he laid his hand flat over hers on the table's edge, where the whole hall could see, and she let it stay.

Muthu, at the door, had closed his eyes.

*

Rema wrote for some time.

The garrison did not move. Somewhere in the courtyard the cistern chain clanked the hour, and every head in the hall took it in. Janu had pressed her apron to her mouth. She had kept to the hearth step all morning, as if the flagstones beyond it were the stair. Now Devan saw her step down and cross the floor toward the household bench, her face wet. She passed Neela without a word. She sat down beside her empty place and put her hands in her lap.

At last Rema laid down her pen.

"I will record the finding for the high court at Kodiyur," she said. Her voice had a clerk's dryness, and under it something he could not have named. "That the killing of Asha, second of Kettamala, on the west stair six years since, and the sale of forged pass-tokens to Thurai raiders, were one conspiracy. That the Keeper of the Passes bought both. That the Resin House executed the first at his purchase. That he is dead by the queen's warrant and cannot answer, and that I record his death with my objection."

She dipped her pen and wrote a moment longer.

"Entered in the record by name," she said. "Asha, daughter of the late warden of Kettamala, officer of the border, aged twenty-two. Killed under contract. Her name is written."

Devan had thought, for six years, about that sentence in different shapes. In none of them had it come so quietly.

He nodded once. It was all he had. Along the wall a few of the garrison dipped their heads, and one man at the back let out a sound that he tried to cover with a cough.

"Warden," Rema said. "Is there more?"

"There is." He had known the question was coming. "I hold one document more. I will not lay it before this assize. It's for the high court in full session, and no bench below it."

The hall rustled. Rema did not move.

"What does it concern?"

"Who paid for the contract on my own death," he said. "The rest I will say where it can be answered."

For a long time she looked at him. Her eyes went to the sealed case at her feet, the second one, her own, tied in green thread, which she had not opened all morning. Then, quickly, to Neela. The look was nothing. A glance at a name on a board.

"Noted," Rema said. "Entered as held, and not shown." She wrote it. "I will not press it, Warden. That is for those with the right to press."

It struck him that she'd said it like a woman taking a very small step back from a very large drop.

*

"One matter remains," Rema said, "and I will ask it now, in the hall, with the garrison to hear and my pen to take it down."

Devan felt the room sharpen. He had half known. He had not wanted to.

"Neela, wife of the warden. You have named yourself the lookout. That is a guild number, from a guild's book, and a guild's book names no one who is not of its kind." She laid the board flat. "You will be sworn as household witness to the closing writ. In that oath I ask you now, once, plainly, and I will have no answer but the true one. Are you an odiyan?"

Muthu's hand tightened on the door. Kandan did not blink. Along the grey wall sixty men waited, and Devan saw faces he had trained, men who had learned her name from her own mouth, who would sit through this oath and then eat or not eat with her at noon.

He could stop it. He could say *I won't answer that* for her, as he had for himself a hundred times. He could say he held a writ and the hall had no right. Rema might even allow it.

He looked at Neela instead.

She had gone quite white, and her hands were steady. She did not search for him. That was how he knew she had made up her mind before she stood. She stood in the clean light from the west shutters and put her bound hand over her heart, the way a witness does, and when she raised her eyes they were not afraid. They were counting. Doors, steps, breaths. And then they were not counting at all.

"Yes," Neela said.

## Chapter 30

# The Sealed Writ

Nobody in the hall moved. Neela counted three doors, sixty men and one held breath, and not one of them let go of it.

"Yes," she had said, and the word stayed in the rafters like smoke.

Kandan of Mathoor stared at her from the wall. His scarred brow had gone the colour of tallow. Janu sat with her hands open in her lap, as if someone had taken something out of them. Muthu had stopped being a man at a door. He was a post.

Rema nodded once and wrote it down. Then she bent and set her fingers to the green thread on the case at her feet.

"I carried this from Kodiyur," she said, "with an instruction. I was to open it if, and only if, a sworn answer to that question was yes." She drew a small knife from her sleeve and cut the thread. "I would have preferred to be told no. Sit down, Warden. It's a long sentence."

Devan did not sit. Neela stood beside him with her bound hand against her skirt. His shoulder was an inch from hers, solid as a wall.

Inside the case lay one folded sheet. Rema broke the wax with her thumbnail. Green wax, crushed-leaf smell, a sunbird with its wings spread. Neela knew the chip at the left wing tip before it came clear. She had seen that wing on a payment writ under a loose slat. Beside her, Devan's breath went in and out once, very evenly.

Rema read it aloud in her clerk's dry voice.

"By the hand of Nirmala, queen of Varanad, to the border at Kettamala. Should the warden of that fort harbour, shelter, or keep as household any odiyan not vouched by a master's page, he shall be stripped of Kettamala and of every office of the border. He shall leave the fort within three days of the finding. The seal of the pass shall pass in trust to the captain of the fort, Muthu, who holds it for the crown."

She turned the sheet toward the hall so the garrison could see the date.

"Written eleven days before the Keeper's execution," she said. "Before I left Kodiyur. Before any of us had heard the word *rogue* in this hall."

"I didn't know," Muthu said. It came out hoarse, with no laugh anywhere in it. "Warden, I swear it. I didn't know my name was on it."

"I know," Devan said.

Neela looked at the date and did the sum. The queen had sealed Devan's death, and then, when that plan slipped, sealed his exile. She had used the same bird and the same ink, before the closing writ with Neela's name on it could have reached Kodiyur. The queen had not needed a name. She had made room for one.

*Unvouched.* The word sat in her like a swallowed stone. A master's page vouched an odiyan, and Neela's page was ash. She had burned it herself, at dusk, with her own mouth. The same act that made her uncageable had made her a rogue in the crown's eyes. Nobody could vouch for her now, because nobody held anything to vouch with.

She could not undo it. She could do one thing.

*

"Madam," she said. "May I speak to the court?"

Rema's pen paused. "You are sworn. Speak."

"The writ says *harbour*." Neela kept her voice level. She had used it on forty pages. "A man can't harbour what isn't under his roof. I'll go today, alone, over the east wall, before the sun is down. He turned me from his door. That's what you can write."

She meant it. She knew how much she meant it, in her calf and in the soles of her feet. It would hurt like a limb coming off, and it would be cleaner than anything else on offer.

"I can write that," Rema said slowly. She was looking at Devan. "If she is gone by sunset, and I see her go, I can set down that on the day of the finding the warden of Kettamala did not hold an unvouched odiyan. The writ names harbouring. I only record what I've seen." She laid down the pen. "I tell you this plainly, Warden, because it is a way out, and I will not have it said I hid one."

"No," Devan said.

He said it before she finished. He didn't turn to Neela. He stepped out from the table and faced the hall, so that sixty pairs of eyes went to him and left her alone. Her count, which had reached sixty-one, let go. She started again at one, and her shoulders came down from around her ears.

"Write this down," he said to Rema. "The warden of Kettamala harbours his wife."

The garrison made a sound like a long breath through a door.

"She is an odiyan. I have known it since the night we married. I shut her shutters and kept my mouth shut, and when a man asked why, I said rain." His voice stayed flat and exact, the way he gave the guard rota. "I'd do it again tomorrow. The writ takes a fort and an office for that. Then it takes them. I held this pass for five years, and I'll hold nothing at the price of sending her over a wall in the dark."

He stopped. His jaw worked once.

"I won't answer for it to anyone but her. She doesn't get to leave alone, because I won't be left. That's all. Enter it."

Rema wrote. The scratch of her pen was the only sound in the hall.

Neela's eyes stung. She had stood in the kennel aisle at the Resin House and not wept, and she was not going to weep here. She stepped up beside him, facing the garrison, near enough that her sleeve touched his.

"Listen to me," she said.

Sixty men listened. She could feel it, a hot, bright pressure.

"I came into this house with a number and a lie. I was sold. You gave me your names anyway. Vasu, whose mother keeps ducks. Kuttan, who can't write. Raiu, who is dead because of the people I came from." She did not look away from Kandan. "You can hate me for that. You have the right. I'd think less of you if you didn't."

Kandan did not move.

"He knew what I was before I told him. He kept it. In all my life nobody has kept anything of mine." Her voice shook and she let it. "He's losing this fort because he won't let me carry that for him. So hear it from me, too. I don't go alone. I'm his wife. I chose it once because I was told to, and I'm choosing it again, now, with all of you watching. Wherever he walks out of this hall, I walk out beside him. Not behind. Beside."

She stopped. There was no more.

Devan did not look at her. His hand found hers at her side, the one without the bandage, and closed. It was not the hand of a man making a show. It shook a little, and she held on harder.

*

Rema laid down her pen and let the ink dry.

"The finding is made," she said. "The writ stands, and I'll carry it. You have three days from this hour." She said it without pleasure. "Captain Muthu. Come forward."

He came the way a man walks onto a rope bridge, big hands hanging at his sides.

"The writ names you to hold the seal in trust for the crown," Rema said. "I'll have it put into your hand, in front of the garrison."

"I'll do it," Devan said.

He reached to his belt. The iron disc hung there on a worn cord, cut with a hill and a gate, the seal that eleven wardens had worn. He worked the hook loose. It took him two tries, which Neela had never seen. Then he laid it in Muthu's palm and folded the fingers over it with his own.

"Hold the pass," he said. "Not for the crown. For the villages below it. Parukutty's, and Kesu's, and every roof between here and the sea that can't

shut a gate behind the rains. The raiders won't wait for spring because the council's changed. They'll look for the soft place."

Muthu stood with the disc in his fist. His face worked, once, ugly and honest.

"I'll hold it," he said. "I'll hold it for the border." He turned, and for the first time since Neela had met him he spoke without being loud, and the whole hall leaned in. It was not the quiet he wore for lies. She knew that one, and this was its opposite. "Not for any household. Not the queen's. Not this house. Not mine. If one of them writes to me, I'll answer with the gate."

"That's all I'd ask," said Devan.

Muthu saluted him, fist to breast, with the iron held hard between.

*

They walked out down the middle of the hall.

Nobody had told them to. It was simply the way to the door, and Devan took it, with Neela on his left, on the side of her bad calf, at a pace slower than his own. She saw him do it.

The garrison stood along the wall in their grey. Their faces went by her as she walked. Vasu. Sankaran. Unni, wet-eyed and furious about it. Bhaskaran, his jaw shut hard on four daughters' worth of worry.

Kandan of Mathoor stood three men from the door, and he was the one who had called her a witch. He had said it flat behind the barracks door, not a month after Raiu burned, with the scar white through his brow and his mother's lame leg in his voice. She had not argued. She had learned his mother's name instead, and he had hated her for it.

He stepped off the wall.

He did not look at her. He looked at the man beside her, and he brought his fist to his chest hard enough to ring on the buckle. He held it there.

"Warden," Kandan said.

It was all he said. After a moment Vasu's fist came up, and Sankaran's, and then a ripple ran down the whole grey wall, fist after fist, like a field

under wind. It was not for her. She knew that, and was glad of it. She had not asked for it, and she did not want it.

Devan stopped. His face was bare as he looked at the man. Then he returned the salute, fist to breast, slow, the way one pays a debt.

They went out under the arch into the wet light of the court, and the hall closed behind them.

*

Rema sent for them an hour later. She was in the south range, at the long table, with the tally chest shut and a single lamp lit in the middle of the day.

She had taken off the brown wrap and sat in plain linen, and she looked older than fifty-eight. She did not rise. The door shut on the three of them.

"I want to say something," she said, "and I would like it not to be written down."

Devan stood with his back to the wall, hands folded, as if on guard. Neela stayed near the door and counted the shutters. Two. Barred.

"The queen does nothing by accident," Rema said.

"I've begun to notice," said Devan.

"No, Warden. Listen." She turned her pen in her fingers. "A writ like that isn't made in a bad hour. It's made in a good one, with the ink steady and the question already answered. I carried it five days down a road and opened it on my own knees. It was ready before your wife's name reached her desk, and it was ready for you. I serve her. I'll serve her again." She put the pen down. "I'll write that you left within the three days. That's the law. I won't write where you went."

"We'll not tell you," Neela said.

"Good. I'll not ask. I'd rather not lie in the record." Rema's eyes came up. They were not unkind. "But she will remember where you go. Understand me. She keeps every road a person's ever taken, and every door she's had closed on her. She will know your road, if not from me. There is always a letter. Someone always writes."

Neela thought of grey wax curling over coals, and of Ittan asking, of all things, for his wife's cough syrup. She thought of a physician, a key, and a drained lamp. Muthu had burned his. But a house that had one pair of ears had many.

"It's not Muthu," Devan said.

"No." Rema folded her hands. "I think not. I don't say it is anyone." She stood at last, the board tucked under her arm, and for a moment she looked at Neela alone. "You read the lookout leaf in a hall that could have turned on you. I've been thirty years a clerk, and I don't see that often. Whatever the queen has written about you, I've written that."

"Thank you," Neela said. It was an awkward word, and she meant it.

Rema went to the door and stopped with her hand on the bar.

"Three days," she said. "And a closed country."

She went out.

The lamp guttered in the draught. Neela listened to the cistern chain clank the hour outside, and thought of the pass. Monkey Pass was shut for the rains, four months of it, with Devan's own seal and her name beside it on the writ that had closed the road. The hill roads were drowned. Nothing came in and nothing went out.

She had counted the exits of every room she had ever slept in. She had never before stood in one that had no way out at all.

Devan's hand found her wrist, over the wound that was not his, and held it.

"Three days," he said. He didn't say it was enough, and he didn't say it wasn't. He never lied to her.

"Where?" she said.

"I don't know yet."

It was the most honest thing anyone had ever said to her, and it frightened her more than the writ.

## Chapter 31

# The Third Slat

The third slat creaked when he pressed it, as it always had.

Devan stood at the west shutters on the last night with the lamp turned low and his thumb against the teak. Nobody had asked him to fix it. He had never wanted to. His father had said a room should breathe, and Asha had said a room should talk. Then a woman had slipped the latch on her wedding night, pressed this slat to see whether the sound would wake him, and gone out over the sill. He had lain with his eyes shut and counted her feet.

He slid the housing aside. Behind it, in the hollow of the frame, lay an oilcloth bundle tied with red thread.

The bundle came out cold from the wall. Devan sat on the bed to untie it. The buyer's half of Chathu's chit was a hide strip, narrow as a finger, with the warden's chamber and *death by beast* cut into it. The payment writ lay under it, folded in thirds. The green wax had a chip at the left wing tip. He turned it to the lamp, and the chip made the sunbird look mid-wingbeat, or a little hurt. Last came the cut seal from the palace betel set, which he had carried in his sleeve for weeks and then stopped being able to look at.

Three things that said the same sentence. His queen had paid for his death, and she had been courteous about it.

"You could mend it," Neela said from the door.

She had come in without a sound, as she always did. She wore the day kasavu with the torn border, and her hair was wet from the court. One hand rested on the frame. She wasn't counting. He could tell by her lips.

"No."

"It gave me away every night."

"It gave *you* nothing," he said. "It told me where you were." He wrapped the bundle again and tied the thread in the knot he had used before. "I never fixed it. I'm glad."

She almost laughed. It showed in her shoulders first. He put the bundle in his pack beside the quire stitched round in green thread.

It was the last quire of the guild's ledger, sewn shut under the queen's sunbird. Neela thought it held the queen's own sealed contracts with the Resin House, and perhaps the answer to the small folded-wing birds inked beside the cut-away stubs in the back half. Rema had looked at that wax, said a seal the queen laid on was not hers to break, and left it in his pack. She had not asked for it. No court was left to keep it for. Whether it was ever opened was theirs to choose.

Neela crossed the floor and set her palm over the slat, pressing. It creaked. She lifted her hand and the room was quiet again.

"Janu wants us in the kitchen," she said. "She says she has a bag."

"She has several."

"She says a bag."

*

Janu had five.

They stood in a row on the kitchen table, tied at the neck with cord: rice cakes in banana leaf, jaggery, dried fish wrapped three times against the damp, a twist of salt, a smaller twist of pepper. Someone had stood a copper pot at the end of the row. Chinna leaned in the back doorway with her bad hip against the frame and her arms folded, running a wager with herself on how many bags Devan would refuse.

"We're riding," he said. "Not marching."

"Then you'll be riding fed." Janu did not look up from the cord she was knotting. "Sit."

"Janu."

"Sit, boy."

He sat. Neela, beside him on the bench, pressed her mouth very flat, which was how she hid a grin. The rain walked on the roof tiles. The cistern chain clanked once.

Janu finished the last knot and stayed standing with her hands flat on the table. Devan had seen her stand that way a thousand times, usually before the words *not in my kitchen*. Tonight she looked at Neela instead.

"I told leopard stories at this table for forty years," she said. "To a boy who liked them, and then to a girl who didn't."

"I liked them," Neela said.

"You went white." Janu's chin came up. "I'm old, not blind. I thought it was the dark. Then my boy here said he was tired of leopards, and I took offence, and I never told the end."

"That was my doing," Devan said.

Janu turned.

"I said it so the kitchen would stop looking at the window." He heard how it sounded in the room, a grown man owning to a story. "Every servant who heard that tale at supper was one step from wondering why the bride's shutters were barred. I wanted their eyes off her. I lied to you in your own kitchen. I'm sorry for it."

"You were never any good at it," Janu said. Her mouth worked. "You could have asked me to stop. I'd have stopped."

"You'd have asked why."

"I would." She sniffed. "I'd have been told, too, in the end. I always am."

Nobody spoke. Chinna had unfolded her arms.

"You always stopped in the same place," Devan said. "The leopard at the edge of the hills. I never heard what came after. Tell it now."

Janu looked at him a long moment. Then she drew a breath, and he saw her go back forty years.

"There was a leopard who came down off the hill in a dry year. The village hunted her out. She went far, into forests with no names, and she grew thin, and she ate what she could. Every night she came back to the edge of the hills and looked down." Her voice dropped. "They kept the door open, and a lamp lit. And one night she walked in. That's all. It's a child's end. I always thought it foolish."

Devan did not answer. A door left open, a lamp left burning. It was his father's rule in an old woman's mouth: a room should breathe. He had barred every shutter in the fort against the dark, and the story he had silenced had been waiting all along to tell him the opposite. He looked at the table. Beneath it, Neela's hand found his and held on.

Janu came round the table and took his face between her hands, which she had not done since he was twelve, and kissed his forehead hard enough to hurt. She did the same to Neela, who sat quite still and took it.

"Eat," Janu said. "Both of you. There's more than you can carry, and you'll carry it."

Chinna pushed off the door frame. "Nobody won the shutters wager," she said. "I'm keeping the stakes." Neela laughed out loud, and so, after a moment, did he.

*

At sunset he came up the stair alone and stood in the room.

He had told himself he would not do this. He did it anyway. He said, to the bed and the window and the slat, in a voice kept low in case a ghost was listening, "Raiu. I put you on that stair and you died on it. I'm sorry." Then he said it again, because the first time was stiff. The second was worse. He gave up and sat with his hands between his knees, which was where Neela found him.

"Practising?" She shut the door with her heel.

"I was talking to Raiu."

"Did he answer?"

"No. He never said much."

She crossed to the shutters. He thought she meant to bar them out of habit, all those months of it, and so did she, for her hand went to the bar. Then she stopped. She took her hand away, lifted the latch and folded both leaves open, wide, onto the failing light.

Rain came in on the wind. It smelled of wet red laterite and, from below, of the lantana banks, which she hated and which tonight she breathed straight in. The hills lay copper under the cloud where the sun went down behind them.

"Rain," Devan said.

She turned. Her face did something he had no word for, a slow thing, a door going back on its hinge. "You said that under a clear sky."

"I did."

"It's actual rain this time."

"I thought I'd be honest for once."

Then the last of the light slid off the hills, and her hand went to her throat.

He was on his feet before he knew it. She held up the other hand, flat. *Wait.* Her scars stood out pale against her skin, and her jaw was set against a burn he could only guess at. She breathed in. Out. In again, long, the way one breathes through a cramp. It took ten counts, and he counted them with her and did nothing, because she had asked.

The pull let go. She dropped her hand and stood human in the open window.

"That's the dusk," she said. "It comes every night I leave the resin off, and it passes, and the ache counts every one. I've nothing to ration on the road. The forty have the season's flasks, mine with them, and I told them they were theirs. So tonight's paid for out of the next moon, and I'll feel the bill." Her chin lifted. "I chose it. Say you heard me."

"I heard you."

"Say yes if you want me. Not because I asked."

"Yes," he said. "Because I want you."

She came to him across the boards. She was twenty-seven, he thirty-two, and they were married by two vows and a writ, and neither had to say any

of it. She took his face in both hands as Janu had and kissed him slowly, then not slowly at all.

They went to the bed without hurry. He undid the kasavu at her shoulder, the torn gold border that she had mended with fingers that still did not know how to be gentle with themselves. She found the buckle of his belt and fumbled it, and he laughed into her hair. She said, "Don't," and he said, "I'm not," and he was. Her scars lay pale and ridged along her wrists, and he turned her hands over and kissed each one, throat last. She shut her eyes. His mouth caught her pulse jumping.

When he lifted his head she had opened them, and she bit him on the shoulder, hard enough to leave a welt. He hissed. Her hand flew to her own shoulder, where the same red mark was rising.

"That's my bite," she said. "Why does it hurt me?"

"Because it's on both of us," Devan said. "Your teeth, my shoulder, your shoulder. You bit yourself through me."

They lay a moment staring at each other in the lamplight and began, helplessly, to laugh again.

After that there wasn't much laughing. The rain came in over the sill, and neither of them reached to close anything. She took him in her hands, and then in her mouth, and he lost the thread of the evening altogether. When she moved over him in the lamp's dim gold he held her hips and let her set the pace, as he had learned she wished, and watched her face. She kept her eyes open. That was the thing. In all those months, in all the rooms with their shut windows, she had never kept them open. She looked at him the whole way down, and he said her name, the one she had chosen, and then the older one she was still trying on. She shook when she heard it.

He turned them gently when she asked, and was careful of her calf and of his own. He touched her until she said *there*, and *there*, and then said nothing. Afterwards she lay over his chest with her breath running ragged and her hair across his mouth.

"Terms," she said into his collarbone, after a time.

"Terms?"

"I've had two sets. The guild's and yours." She lifted her head. Her eyes were very clear. "Neither fits any more. You're not the warden now, and I'm not a bride. I came to this bed sold. I'd like to leave it free."

He thought about it with her weight on him. He didn't hurry; she had never wanted him to.

"No one leads," he said. "Or both do. If you say stop, we stop. If I say it, we stop, and neither asks why until we've stopped." He found her hand. "I won't carry things for you alone. You won't carry things for me alone. We tell each other what we're doing before we do it."

"Even if it's stupid."

"Especially."

"And at the back." Her fingers tightened. "You've slept with a wall behind you since the stair. I want to be the one behind you. Not the wall. Someone who could strike and doesn't."

His throat closed. He had told her that, once, in the dark, in a bad hour. He had not known she was keeping it.

"And you," he said, when he could. "Whoever comes at you comes through me. I'll know it's yours to answer and I won't take it. But I'll be there."

"Partners," Neela said, testing the word.

"If it's a good one."

"It's a terrible word." Her mouth shook. "I'll keep it."

*

The rain slackened toward the middle watch. He lay on his back and she lay along his side, and neither slept.

"Count me," she said.

He turned his head.

"You've counted me in your head every night." Her voice was low. "I've heard you. Your breath goes slow and square. I always knew. Tonight I want you to. Out loud, if you like."

So he did. He put his hand on her ribs and counted her breaths under his palm, in the dark with the shutters open, softly, like a man laying stones across a stream. *One. Two. Three.* She breathed in and out, long and even.

At nine, the breath caught.

Small. A skipped step. He waited, and on the next long count it came again at the same place.

"Neela."

"What?"

"You have a hitch."

She was quiet. "I don't."

"Yours falls on the ninth count. Mine falls on the third part of mine. You catch it like a woman missing the eleventh step."

She turned her face into his shoulder, and he felt her smile there, wet. "I've been trying to count it out of mine for twenty years," she said. "Nobody told me."

"Nobody was listening."

"No." Her hand lay on his heart. "You were."

*

He woke to numbers.

Grey light came through the open shutters, thin as watered milk. The rain had dwindled to a drip from the eaves. Somewhere below, the cistern chain clanked once, and Gopan's rhythm held.

She wasn't asleep. She lay on her side facing him with her chin on her arm, and her lips moved. *Eleven. Twelve. Thirteen.* Her eyes were on his chest.

He did not move. He kept his breath where it was. Slow, square, and at the third part of the count, the small catch he had never been able to cure.

"There," Neela whispered. "There it is."

"Do you always do that?"

"Every morning. It means you're still here." She did not look away from his ribs. "I never told you why."

"You've told me now."

She nodded. Her lashes were wet. Then her eyes lifted, and the fear in them went out like a lamp.

Below the window, hooves sounded on the wet road, many of them, and a horse blew. Then Bhaskaran's voice came up from the padippura, pitched low, the way a man speaks when he doesn't want to wake a house. Devan sat up and put his feet to the cold floor.

The gate stood open on the rain. Beyond it in the red road sat forty riders on forty borrowed horses, with no lamps, in the grey. Not one looked up at the window. They had learned to wait, and they waited with their hoods down for the two people who were coming.

He reached for his pack. The green-stitched quire lay at the top, the wax still whole. Forty people on that road each held a page of their own. This one nobody held, and no court waited to take it from them. They would break that wax on the road, over whatever fire they had, with her hand beside his, when they chose.

He shouldered the pack. Neela was already at the door, and together they went down the stair toward the forty and the rain.

## Chapter 32

# Sold to the Crown

They climbed for two days with the rain on their backs.

Neela rode the grey mare, who favoured her off hind and told the whole hill about it. Devan rode beside her. Behind them came forty people on borrowed horses, strung out along a goat track no cart had ever used. Nobody spoke much. Every few hundred paces someone looked back down the slope, then forward again, as if the road might change its mind.

On the second afternoon the trees gave out.

Ahead lay grass and grey rock and cloud, and a wind that smelled of nothing at all. After months of lantana and laterite and resin, nothing was a strange thing to breathe.

"There," Devan said.

The shelter sat in a fold of the ridge, built of stacked stone with a turf roof and a doorway no taller than Neela's shoulder. Kesu's grandson had drawn the route on a tally stick. Pepper hunters used the place in the dry months, when they came up to cut wild vine from the high gullies. It had a hearth, a stack of damp dung-cake fuel, and one long, low room that would hold half of them lying down.

The rest would sleep in the lee of the wall. Nobody complained. Neela counted the doors anyway. One. The old fear rose and fell away, because for the first time in her life she stood at a room with one door and wanted all forty of them inside it.

*

Inventory was Thilak's idea. He laid it out on a flat rock in the last of the light, with a care that made her throat tight.

"Flasks," he said. "One season each. Forty-one, counting the spare Pavi carried." He tapped them in a row. "Tapping knives, nine, hooked for the bark. Pachan's grove map, copied small. It shows every tree on the north slope, and the three that run best at noon." He nodded at the long plank lashed to the packhorse, still black with her lamp-black names. "And that. Kuttu wouldn't leave it. That's what we own, Master."

"Don't call me that."

"What should I call you?"

She opened her mouth and found no word. "Neela," she said. "For now."

"Neela." He tried it like a new tool. Then his eyes went to her split nails, and he said carefully, "You've not taken a flask."

"I gave mine up."

"Ach." He looked at the row. "There's one spare."

"It stays the spare." She heard her own voice and softened it. "The ache is mine to carry. You'll need that flask when somebody's is lost, or somebody's too sick to walk to the groves. If I ration the House by one flask for myself, I'm no different from Chathu."

He nodded once, slowly, and laid the spare at the end of the row where everyone could see it.

Devan had been listening from the doorway. He crossed the grass, took the dung-cake basket from Kuttu, who was struggling with it, and went in to light the fire.

The ache waited. It lived in her nails and in the new heat behind her eyes. Forty others would know it too, as soon as the flasks ran out. After a season came a moon without resin, and a question nobody had answered: who in all Varanad would give them more?

*

Dusk came slowly at that height. The cloud pulled apart, and for a quarter hour the whole sky above the pass lay open, pale gold at the rim and violet in the middle.

The forty did not take resin. Thilak had asked them to wait one night, and nobody argued. They sat on the grass in twos and threes, human and tired, and ate Janu's rice cakes out of banana leaf. Pavi was telling Kamalakshi something with her hands, and Kamalakshi was laughing. Neela had not heard her laugh before.

She took her own rice and went in to the fire.

Devan sat cross-legged by the hearth with his pack open. He took out the green-stitched quire and laid it on his knee, and they looked at it together.

It was thin. Stitched round all four edges in green thread, sealed under a thumb of green wax. A sunbird with its wings spread, and a chip at the left tip.

"Rema left it with us," Neela said.

"Rema said a seal the queen laid on was not hers to break."

"Ours, then."

"If we want." He turned it over. "We could carry it unopened. We could throw it down a gully."

"We could." She watched the firelight slide on the wax. "I'd think about it every night for the rest of my life."

"So would I."

They both reached for it. His hand closed on one corner and hers on the other. She had read eighty-two pages aloud in a day. This one was thinner than any of them, and it frightened her more.

"On three," she said.

"Whose three?"

"Yours. You count slower."

"One," said Devan. "Two."

They tore it together.

The wax cracked like old bark. The thread gave a little at a time, and then all at once. Inside lay a single sheet, folded once, and nothing else. She

smelled it before she saw it: scorched tamarind, pine sap, resin-ink. Chathu's hand.

She unfolded the sheet and read the heading aloud, because that was how she read now.

"Sold to the crown."

Devan's breath changed beside her.

Under it ran a column of numbers, each with a year and a sum in panam. She counted them with her finger. She counted them again, because the first time she did not believe it.

"Thirty."

"Thirty what?"

"Ledger numbers. Chathu sold them one at a time, over twenty years, and the sums go up." Her voice had gone flat. She let it. "Every line has a little bird in the margin. Wings folded."

She knew those birds. She pulled the cut-down back half of the ledger from the pack and opened it where the pages had been sliced out. She had counted those stubs twice at the Resin House, and told no one but Devan. Now she laid them in a row beside the sheet and bent to the lamp.

Each stub carried a number in the margin, and a folded-wing bird beside it. She went down the column with one finger and down the stubs with the other.

They matched. Every one.

"Thirty stubs," she said. "Thirty lines. Not burned, not lost. Taken out, the way a man takes a loaf from a tin." Her hand shook. She pressed it flat to her knee. "They went to Kodiyur, in a green-sealed box. The queen holds their pages. She is master of thirty odiyans, and she has been since before you were warden."

From somewhere far below, out of the dusk, a langur barked.

Once. Then again, farther down the slope. The sound ran along the hillside like a rope drawn through a ring, and stopped.

It stopped completely. The wind went on. The grass went on. But something under the world had gone quiet, and all of them heard it.

Neela was on her feet. Devan had the knife out of his belt and the sheet in the pack in one movement. At the doorway the whole camp was already rising. Thilak had a tapping knife in his fist. Pavi had stepped in front of Kamalakshi without seeming to think about it.

"Nobody turns," Neela said, low. "Nobody takes resin. Stay human."

Below them, where the last stunted trees gave out, a figure was walking up the path.

He was big. He walked with a hitch on the left leg, a drag and a step, and carried nothing in his hands. He came into the firelight and stopped at the margin of it, at the exact distance where a man could not be accused of coming closer.

It was Vellan.

*

The forty made a sound: not a word, a breath drawn in through teeth. Several had been in the yard the day he came for Devan. Several had walked past the kennels where he put girls. Thilak's knife came up, and Neela laid a hand across his wrist without looking.

"He has no resin on him," she said.

She knew it. The air round him was clean, no scorched tamarind, nothing. He stood with bare wrists and a bare throat, and the pale scars there were the oldest she had ever seen. He was only a man, and he had walked up a mountain alone, at dusk, on a night when every witness he had ever made was awake and listening.

"I've a page," he said, in the old low grumble. "You read it me yourself. It's in my coat. I'm nobody's but mine." He looked at Devan. "I thought you'd rather know that before you decided what to do with the rest."

Devan said nothing. His knife hung at his side. He was breathing slowly, very evenly, as he did on the kalari floor, and the evenness cost him. She could see it in his hand.

"Why are you here?" she said.

"The watcher at the pass village logs scent-posts. He logged a forty-strong trail going up the hills. I followed it." Vellan's mouth moved, not quite a smile. "I'm told I'm good at following."

"Who else reads that log?"

It was the right question. She saw him know it.

"It goes to Chathu's cell," he said. "Then to whoever opens his post. That's not the House any more. That's the queen's household." He drew a breath. "The watcher sends the next one in at the new moon. After that, anyone who can read a scent-post can follow it. You've that long."

Nobody moved.

"I've one more thing," he said. "I'd sooner say it to your face than leave it on a mat. Chathu's list. You've broken the green seal."

"How do you know it was green?"

"He told me when I was nine, the day he bought me." Vellan looked at the fire, not at her. "He said the odiyans who go up the green road never come back to the yard, and I should be glad it wasn't me. I was glad for thirty years." His jaw worked. "I'm not glad now."

"Say it," Devan said, in the voice he used for the guard rota.

"The queen's night-guard." Vellan's eyes lifted and held on him. "The ones who stand outside her door in green. Odiyans, all of them. Thirty. I'd have been the thirty-first." He turned his hands palm up. "The four who walked into Kettamala with that clerk, wearing her sashes, crossed a pass the rains had shut. They knew the goat path. I taught two of them the goat path. They're not hunters and they're not soldiers. They're sold."

"The first one had a seam on her wrist, not a ridge," Neela said slowly. "And her throat was clean."

"Lime-and-ochre paste." Vellan touched his own scarred neck. "The queen won't have scarred throats at her door. The wrists they hide in cuffs, and a palace surgeon pares the old ridges smooth, so a slipped cuff shows one seam. The scars are there under it, same as yours."

Neela's skin went cold. Devan had noticed a bare throat and a smooth seam and called it a burn, and she had let him. Every guard in green was a mark she had walked past.

"Their pages," she said.

"In her leaf. In her chest, under her hand." His voice stayed level. "And she witnessed every one of their first turnings. Chathu always brought her to see. Nobody told you that. Or if they did, you didn't hear."

He did not say the shapes. Neela noticed that. He stood with the whole camp watching, and he named not one, not the First Guard's, not his own, not hers. He had learned to be quiet about that the hard way, and he was giving them the gift of it.

"I have no master," he said. "I've nothing to offer you. But I carved this."

He took a small thing from his coat and held it toward the fire. A bird, pale wood, wing folded, head turned, plum-sized.

"For the youngest. I don't know who's the youngest."

Kamalakshi stared at it. After a moment she took one step forward. Pavi caught her sleeve, and she shook her head without looking round and walked to the rim of the firelight. She took the bird and turned it over. Its beak was whole.

"I'll keep it," she said, and her voice shook. "I haven't forgiven you."

"I'd think less of you if you had," Vellan said.

He did not ask for a place by the fire. He lowered himself to the ground where he stood, the bad leg out straight, at the very fringe of the glow. Devan looked at him a long time. Then he took one of Janu's cloths from his pack, folded it twice, and set it on the grass beside him. Vellan looked at it. He did not touch it, but he did not push it away.

*

Later, when the fire had burned down and the forty had gone to the long room and the lee of the wall, Neela sat outside alone.

The cloud had closed again. A few stars showed through a rent, very white. Beyond the ridge the land fell away in black folds toward the coast, toward the pass she had crossed once as a child, and not by choice.

She said the first word quietly into the wind, as if testing a stone.

"Indu."

A village name. A girl in a house with a lantana hedge, who had hated the smell. She tried to see her. She saw a flicker, a hem, a hand in someone else's hand, and then nothing.

"Neela," she said then, and that came easily, easy as an old knife. It was the name Ammu had called across a courtyard. It was the name forty people had said that evening and meant. It was the name of a woman who had been counted, and had learned to count back.

She let both lie in her mouth. Neither belonged to the guild or the crown. They belonged to her, and to the man now crossing the grass with two cups of hot water between his hands.

He sat down beside her. For a time neither spoke.

"The queen holds thirty pages," she said at last, "and she's a witness to every one. If I read them back, I give each of the thirty a dozen new witnesses. If I don't, she can cage any of them with one sentence." She pressed her hands to her knees. "Vellan says we've till the new moon before someone reads our trail."

"Probably less."

"You're not going to tell me it'll be all right."

"I never have." He passed her a cup. Steam rose between them. "I'll tell you what I know. Forty people trust us and we have a season of resin. We have a grove map and nine knives. We have a paper the queen did not want read, and we've read it." He drank. "No hall, no seal, no road. We'll need all three before spring."

"We have a plank."

"We'll need a bigger plank." His mouth twitched. "And a bigger hall. Forty won't fit in a hunters' hut for four months. Seventy won't fit in anything we own. Seventy-one, if Vellan stays."

"You're counting ahead."

"You taught me that."

She laughed. It surprised her, and it cracked in the middle. She leaned her head on his shoulder and his arm came round her, and they sat while the wind went over the grass.

Thirty pages sat in a chest in Kodiyur, under the hand of the one master they could not reach. The queen knew every road and every door. She had a courteous voice, and a sunbird seal that had once paid for a warden's death.

Neela thought of Janu's leopard, thin from a long way, looking down at the lit door. Nobody was going to leave a lamp burning for thirty people in green sashes. They would have to carry it down there themselves.

She finished the water. It was still warm.

"Come on," she said.

They went in together and lifted the plank between them, one end each, and carried it out into the light of the banked fire. The forty were already stirring. Thilak came out of the long room, then Pavi, then Kuttu with his blanket round his shoulders. Kamalakshi stood with the wooden bird in her fist. Beyond them, Vellan raised his head.

They stood the plank against the wall of the hut, its black names toward the fire.

"I will read every one of the thirty their page, by daylight, to their face," Neela said, loud enough for the last of them to hear. "And I'll be no one's master. So here is what I give you. Any time the forty say so, by your vote, I put down the ledger and the plank and walk away from this. Not one of you needs a reason."

Nobody breathed. Thilak's mouth opened and closed.

"I won't stand in front of her," Devan said. He did not look at Neela. He looked at the forty. "I've been a wall most of my life. I'm not one now. I stand at her back, where she can turn and find me, and I go where your vote sends her. If you put her out, you put me out. That's said before you all, and before him." He tipped his head toward Vellan, out in the dark.

It was not what they had agreed in the dark. She turned and found his eyes, and he nodded once.

Thilak lifted his hooked knife, point up, the way tappers do at the first cut of the season. One by one the others raised whatever they held. Kamalakshi raised the bird. Last of all, at the edge of the light, Vellan lifted an empty hand.

# Also by Anya Kalloor

**The Odiyan Contracts**

1. *Vow of Teeth*
2. *Oath of Claws* (this book)
3. *Crown of Night*

# Coming next

The forty are free. They hold their own pages, and the guild that owned them is ash.

But Neela is learning that freedom is a debt with a long tail. Thirty more odiyans stand behind the queen's own throne. They are unseen and unnamed, painted clean of their scars and sworn to a woman who witnessed every first turning they ever made. Their pages sit in a hidden crown leaf. The queen's promise is simple: bring them to heel, and Neela may command a night-guard with no leash at all. Safe. Unseen. Hers.

Devan has no fort now, no seal and no office. He has a right hand he trusts less each day and a border he will not stop guarding. Wardens are not what keep a pass, he tells her. People are.

Then the treaty that kept Varanad quiet breaks. Sails come out of the sea mist, and Thurai raiders land on a coast with no night-guard left to hold it. A foreign envoy walks into their camp with an offer to hire the Night Company, and with him walks an odiyan who has never been written in any ledger at all.

Freedom was never going to be free. To break the queen's hold, every guard must choose one person to bind themselves to, and every pair will share every wound. A battle will bleed far more than the soldiers who fight it.

Neela once swore that freedom meant belonging to no one. Now the whole kingdom is on the line, and she may have to prove otherwise.

Can they free every odiyan, even the queen's guard, if it leaves Varanad without its night-guard as Thurai raiders land?